THE IMMORTAL GREEK NOSTOS OF HOMER (Mœ—¡Ÿ£)

THE ODYSSEY

The Complete Epic Screenplay & Dramatic Dialogue Manuscript

PRINCIPAL CHARACTERS & DRAMATIS PERSONAE

ODYSSEUS (POLYTROPOS) — The King of Ithaca / Man of Twists and Turns & Endurance

PENELOPE — Queen of Ithaca / Exemplar of Sagacity, Chastity & Steadfast Faith

TELEMACHUS — The Heir of Ithaca / Coming of Age to Stand Beside His Father

PALLAS ATHENA — Flashing-Eyed Goddess of Wisdom / Divine Patroness of the House of Arcesius

CALYPSO & CIRCE — The Immortal Nymph of Ogygia & The Sorceress of Aeaea

POLYPHEMUS — The Giant Cyclops of the Sea Caves / Scourge of the Wandering Fleet

TIRESIAS — The Blind Theban Prophet of the House of Hades

EUMAEUS & EURYCLEIA — The Noble Swineherd & The Loyal Nursemaid of Odysseus

KING ALCINOUS & QUEEN ARETE & NAUSICAA — The Royal Phaeacians of Scheria

ANTINOUS & EURYMACHUS — The Arrogant Ring-Leaders of the Ravenous Suitors

OLD LAERTES & ARGOS — The Weary Patriarch of the Vineyard & The Faithful Hound

THE OLYMPIAN POWERS & SHADES — Zeus, Poseidon, Hermes, Achilles & Agamemnon

CONTAINING ALL TWENTY-FOUR BOOKS IN UNABRIDGED SCRIPT

Books I–VI · The Telemachy & The Solitary Isle | Books VII–XII · The Apologue: The Great Wanderings

Books XIII–XVIII · Return to Ithaca & The Loyal Hearth | Books XIX–XXIV · The Great Bow, Slaughter & Peace

Unabridged Marathon Screenplay Edition · Full-Width Narrative Prose & Quoted Character Dialogues

Exhaustive Classical English Translation & Original Dramatic Adaptation of Homer’s Masterpiece

DRAMATIS PERSONAE & MULTI-VOICE CASTING DIRECTORY

Vocal registers, audio cues, and character archetypes for Homer's Odyssey production:

HOMERIC RHAPSODE (NARRATOR) — The Immortal Epic Voice of Homer

Vocal Register: Grand, Resonant Dactylic Baritone with Poignant Nostalgic Cadence

Direction: Majestic classical gravitas; delivers Homeric sea-descriptions and dramatic transitions with deep, surging musicality, capturing both the terror of the wine-dark sea and the warmth of the Ithaca hearth.

Signature: "Sing in me, Muse, and through me tell the story of that man skilled in all ways of contending, the wanderer, harried for years on end, after he plundered the stronghold on the proud height of Troy!"

KING ODYSSEUS (POLYTROPOS) — King of Ithaca / Hero of the Trojan Horse & Wanderer

Vocal Register: Weathered, Resonant Baritone / Razor-Sharp Intellect to Deep Pathos

Direction: Vocal timbre marked by twenty years of salt spray, warfare, and sorrow; capable of silky, humble deception as a beggar, heartbreaking tears remembering home, and terrifying thunder when drawing the great bow.

Signature: "My heart has learned to endure, for I have suffered much both on the waves and in the war! Let this new trial be added to the rest! There is nothing sweeter than a man's own country and his parents, however rich a house he may dwell in across foreign seas!"

QUEEN PENELOPE (PERIPHRON) — Queen of Ithaca / Wife of Odysseus & Guardian of the Realm

Vocal Register: Lyrical, Melancholy, Regally Guarded Mezzo-Soprano

Direction: Quiet, aristocratic sorrow laced with vigilant caution; never yields easily to false hope; her voice carries the melancholy hum of weaving and unweaving the shroud by candlelight.

Signature: "Do not be angry with me, Odysseus! The gods gave us sorrow; they grudged that we two should linger side by side to enjoy the bloom of youth and reach the threshold of old age together! But in my heart I always feared some mortal might deceive me with false words!"

PRINCE TELEMACHUS — Prince of Ithaca / Son of Odysseus and Penelope

Vocal Register: Earnest, Youthful Tenor Growing in Power and Stature

Direction: Begins with anxious youthfulness and bitter shame over the suitors; deepens visibly across the journey to Pylos and Sparta; rings with commanding martial authority alongside his father in the slaughter.

Signature: "Mother, go to your chambers and attend to your own tasks, the loom and the distaff! Speech and authority shall be the business of men, and mine above all, for mine is the mastery in this house!"

PALLAS ATHENA (MENTOR) — Flashing-Eyed Goddess of Wisdom & Divine Strategist

Vocal Register: Crystalline, Ringing Contralto with Warm, Smiling Authority

Direction: Combines immense Olympian divinity with affectionate, fond banter with Odysseus; transforms into the aged advisor Mentor with gravelly, dignified elder cadence.

Signature: "Always you are the same, Odysseus—shrewd, alert, and self-possessed! That is why I cannot abandon you in your distress, because you are civilized, acute, and prudent! Let us plan now how to bring ruin upon these insolent suitors!"

CALYPSO THE DIVINE NYMPH — Daughter of Atlas / Queen of the Sea-Isle Ogygia

Vocal Register: Silken, Intoxicating, Melancholy Lyric Soprano

Direction: Breathes with the perfume of cedar smoke and cypress blossoms; rages with bitter fury against the jealousy of male gods when Hermes commands her to surrender Odysseus.

Signature: "Hard-hearted you are, you gods, and more envious than any on earth! You grudge goddesses sleeping openly with mortal men whom they love! Yet go, Odysseus, build your raft—though if you knew how many sorrows you must suffer before reaching your homeland, you would remain here with me and be immortal!"

CIRCE OF AEAEA — Dread Goddess of Enchantment / Daughter of Helios

Vocal Register: Sensual, Menacing, Golden Contralto with Chilling Charm

Direction: Sweet singing voice turning instantly into a commanding spell-caster; yields into passionate awe when Odysseus resists her potion with the herb moly; becomes a generous prophetic guide.

Signature: "What man are you, and whence? No mortal man has ever drunk my potion and remained uncharmed! Surely you are that Odysseus of many wiles, whom Hermes of the golden wand always said would come to Aeaea on his way from Troy!"

POLYPHEMUS THE CYCLOPS — One-Eyed Giant / Son of Poseidon and the Nymph Thoosa

Vocal Register: Colossal, Guttural, Booming Cavernous Bass

Direction: Roars like grinding millstones and shattering granite; smacks lips hungrily over human flesh; screams in delirious blinded agony shouting that "Nobody is killing me!"

Signature: "Stranger, you are a fool, or come from far away, to bid me fear or revere the gods! We Cyclopes care nothing for aegis-bearing Zeus or the blessed immortals, for we are mightier far than they! Give me more of that honey-sweet wine, Nobody, and tell me your name!"

ANTINOUS (EUPEITHES' SON) — Ring-Leader of the Suitors / Usurper of Ithaca

Vocal Register: Snide, Contemptuous, Metallic Aristocratic Tenor

Direction: Dripping with smug condescension and lazy cruelty; laughs callously as he hurls the wooden footstool at the disguised king; the first to die with an arrow through his throat.

Signature: "What god has brought this pestilence upon our feast? Stand out in the middle, away from my table, or you will find yourself in an Egypt or Cyprus of bitter sorrow! Shameless beggar, sponging off every man!"

EURYMACHUS (POLYBUS' SON) — Second Leader of the Suitors / Deceitful Politician

Vocal Register: Smooth, Oily, Persuasive Baritone with Trembling Panic

Direction: Silky smooth lies to Queen Penelope; collapses into frantic, cowardly pleading once Antinous is slain, blaming the dead prince for everything.

Signature: "If you are indeed Odysseus of Ithaca returned, what you say of the suitors' wickedness is true! But Antinous lies dead, who was the cause of all! He cared nothing for marriage, but plotted to slay your son and rule Ithaca! Spare your own people, and we will repay all we devoured with twenty-fold bronze and gold!"

EUMAEUS THE NOBLE SWINEHERD — Loyal Swineherd of Ithaca / Prince of Syrie in Captivity

Vocal Register: Warm, Rustic, Weather-Beaten Baritone of Deep Integrity

Direction: Deep, earthy warmth; treats the ragged beggar with holy respect because "strangers and beggars come from Zeus"; weeps like a father welcoming Telemachus home.

Signature: "Come in, old stranger, to my hut, so that when you have satisfied your soul with food and wine, you may tell me who you are and what sorrows you have suffered. For all vagabonds and strangers are from Zeus, and even a modest gift is dear from us who serve in fear!"

EURYCLEIA THE NURSE — Aged Nurse of Odysseus and Telemachus

Vocal Register: Quivering, Cracked, Affectionate Elder Contralto

Direction: Crackles with eighty years of household love; gasps and drops the bronze foot-basin into the clattering floor as her fingers trace the boar-scar on Odysseus' knee.

Signature: "You are Odysseus! My child! And I did not know you until my hands had handled all my master's limbs! Child, what word has passed the barrier of your teeth? You know my spirit, unyielding and firm as iron; I will keep your secret silent as stone!"

TIRESIAS THE THEBAN SEER — Blind Prophet of Apollo in the Kingdom of Hades

Vocal Register: Chilling, Sepulchral, Hollow Bass of the Netherworld

Direction: Speaks with the dusty whisper of the tomb; drinks the black blood of the ram and reveals the wrath of Poseidon and the final inland sacrifice.

Signature: "Glorious Odysseus, you seek a sweet return, but god will make it hard for you! Yet even so, after enduring many woes, you may reach home if you are willing to curb your own appetite and that of your comrades when you reach the island of Thrinacia!"

LORD POSEIDON (EARTH-SHAKER) — God of the Ocean, Earthquakes & Horses / Father of Polyphemus

Vocal Register: Thunderous, Crashing, Oceanic Deep Bass

Direction: Roars like colossal black breakers smashing granite cliffs; his laughter rattles the teeth; merciless determination to hound Odysseus across the sea.

Signature: "Ah! So the gods have changed their counsel concerning Odysseus while I was visiting the Ethiopians! He is near the land of the Phaeacians, where it is his lot to escape the coils of woe! But even yet, I think I shall give him his bellyful of sorrow!"

KING ALCINOUS OF PHAEACIA — Sovereign of Scheria / Lord of the Golden Ships

Vocal Register: Noble, Generous, Warmly Civilized Baritone

Direction: Rich, courtly hospitality; speaks with admiration and awe as Odysseus relates his wanderings; orders cauldrons and golden tripods loaded onto the ships.

Signature: "Odysseus, we gaze upon you and do not take you for a deceiver or a teller of false tales! Your words possess grace, and within you is an honest mind; you have told your story with the skill of a bard! Tell me, did you see any of your godlike companions who fell at Troy?"

QUEEN ARETE OF PHAEACIA — Queen of the Phaeacians / Wise Arbiter of Disputes

Vocal Register: Quiet, Penetrating, Dignified Classical Contralto

Direction: Observant silence followed by razor-sharp questions; spots her own household weaving on the stranger's shoulders immediately.

Signature: "Stranger, I will be the first to question you. Who are you among men, and from where? Who gave you these garments? Did you not say you came wandering across the sea?"

PRINCESS NAUSICAA — Princess of Phaeacia / Daughter of Alcinous and Arete

Vocal Register: Luminous, Fresh, Silver-Toned Youthful Soprano

Direction: Stands her ground fearlessly when her maids flee the brine-encrusted stranger; poise beyond her years; tender wistfulness bidding Odysseus farewell.

Signature: "Stand fast, maids! Why do you flee at the sight of a man? No living mortal brings war to the land of the Phaeacians, for we are dear to the gods! Farewell, guest; remember me when you are in your homeland, for to me first you owe your life!"

LORD LAERTES — Former King of Ithaca / Father of Odysseus

Vocal Register: Frail, Weeping, Earth-Stained Elder Tenor

Direction: Grieves in rags digging among fruit trees; weeps bitterly pouring dust on his grey hair; transforms into an armed lion when restored to his son.

Signature: "If you are indeed my son Odysseus returned, show me a clear sign so I may be convinced! Tell me of the trees in this orchard that you once asked of me when you were a little boy following me through the garden!"

SHADE OF ACHILLES (IN HADES) — Supreme Hero of Troy / Lord of the Underworld Dead

Vocal Register: Hollow, Haunting, Golden Baritone of Tragic Realization

Direction: Rejects Homeric heroic kleos in one of the most famous passages in literature; desperate hunger for news of his son Neoptolemus.

Signature: "Speak not to me comforting words of death, glorious Odysseus! I would rather be a hired servant on earth, bound to some poor dirt-farmer with little land, than rule as king over all the breathless ghosts of the dead!"

SHADE OF AGAMEMNON (IN HADES) — Murdered High King of Mycenae

Vocal Register: Bleeding, Bitter, Bitter-Cold Royal Bass

Direction: Weeps tears of black ichor remembering his slaughter by Clytemnestra and Aegisthus at the banquet feast; warns Odysseus never to trust a woman fully.

Signature: "Odysseus of many wiles, there is no trust to be placed in women! When you bring your black ship to your dear fatherland, steer it to shore in secret, not openly! For the days of faith are dead!"

HERMES THE GUIDE (ARGEIPHONTES) — Messenger of Olympus / Slayer of Argus

Vocal Register: Lithe, Bright, Silver-Winged Tenor with Playful Edge

Direction: Steps lightly across the waves; delivers Zeus' mandates with brisk, cheerful Olympian detachment; hands Odysseus the black-rooted moly flower.

Signature: "Whither away again through the mountain crags, unhappy man, alone in unfamiliar country while your companions are shut up in Circe's pens like swine? Take this potent herb; it will ward off the evil day from your head!"

ZEUS (FATHER OF GODS AND MEN) — Supreme Arbiter of Mount Olympus

Vocal Register: Deep, Rumbles of Thunder, Inscrutable Omnipotent Bass

Direction: Weighs mortal hubris and suffering; decrees that mortals blame the gods foolishly for woes brought on by their own reckless folly.

Signature: "Ah, how shameless the way these mortals blame the gods! From us alone, they say, come all their miseries, yes, but they themselves, with their own reckless ways, compound their pains beyond their proper share!"

ARGOS THE FAITHFUL HOUND — Odysseus' Loyal Hunting Dog of Twenty Years

Vocal Register: Faint Whimper & Gentle Sigh of Recognition

Direction: Drops his ears and wags his tail in the dung-heap; passes peacefully into death the instant his eyes behold his returned master after twenty years.

Signature: "[A gentle, recognizing whimper as his tail wags and his ears drop against the dust, beholding Odysseus after twenty long years.]"

CHORUS / SAILORS OF ITHACA & SUITORS OF THE HALL — The Bronze Crew & Clamoring Suitors

Vocal Register: Multi-Voice Choral Ensemble / Oarsmen Rhythms & Feast Brawls

Direction: Chants of sailors rowing across black water; drunken shouts of suitors throwing bones and cups across the great hall.

Signature: "Row onward, comrades, into the spray! Though death awaits on left and right, our home across the surge calls us forever!"

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ACT 1: THE TELEMACHY & THE SOLITARY ISLE

Sonship, Divine Intervention & Longing for Home

BOOK 1: ATHENA INSPIRES THE PRINCE & THE PLUNDER OF ITHACA

Book I — The Council on Olympus, The Arrival of Mentes & The Insolence of the Suitors

Ten years after the fall of Troy, all the surviving Achaean chieftains have returned to their hearths or perished, save Odysseus alone, held weeping upon the secluded isle of Ogygia by the nymph Calypso. While Poseidon feasts among the Ethiopians, Athena appeals to Zeus on Mount Olympus to permit Odysseus' homecoming. Athena descends to Ithaca disguised as the Taphian lord Mentes. She finds the royal palace besieged by more than a hundred insolent suitors who slaughter Odysseus' cattle, drain his vintage wines, and demand Queen Penelope's hand. Athena instills new courage in young Prince Telemachus, commanding him to summon an island assembly, denounce the usurpers, and sail to Pylos and Sparta for news of his long-lost father.

SCENE 1: THE COUNCIL OF OLYMPUS — GOLDEN HALLS OF ZEUS — DAY

A radiant stillness lay over the snow-crowned summits of Mount Olympus. In the great hall of polished marble and chryselephantine pillars, the blessed immortals sat upon golden thrones, sipping ambrosia and nectar from chased goblets of electrum. Zeus the Father of Gods and Men rested his lightning-tempered hand upon his lap, his deep gaze turning over the tragic fate of Aegisthus, whom Orestes had slain in vengeance for Agamemnon's blood. Athena, her eyes flashing like sea-glass under a dawn sky, stepped forward before the father of gods and mortals.

Athena bowed her shining helmet, speaking with quiet intensity: "O Father of us all, son of Cronus, highest of rulers! Aegisthus indeed lies in a doom he well deserved; so perish any mortal who dares such evil deeds! But my heart breaks for wise Odysseus, that unhappy man who for ten years has suffered far from his friends on a wave-girt island at the very navel of the sea! A leafy isle where dwells a goddess, daughter of wizard Atlas, who holds the pillars that keep heaven and earth apart! She holds the weeping prince captive, charming him always with soft, seductive words that he may forget Ithaca; but Odysseus longs only to see the smoke leaping from his native soil, and yearns for death! Does your heart turn not at all, Olympian? Did not Odysseus offer pleasing sacrifices to you beside the Argive ships on the broad plains of Troy? Why then are you so bitter against him, Father Zeus?"

Zeus shook his dark ambrosial curls, and the foundations of heaven trembled: "My child, what word has leaped past the barrier of your teeth? How could I ever forget godlike Odysseus, who beyond all other mortals surpasses in wisdom and has offered more sacrifices to the deathless gods who hold the broad sky? It is Poseidon, the Earth-Shaker, who harbors unyielding wrath against him, because Odysseus blinded the single eye of Polyphemus, the greatest of the Cyclopes, whom the nymph Thoosa bore to the sea god! But come, let all of us here assemble our counsel that Odysseus may return to his fatherland! Poseidon will cool his rage, for he cannot strive alone against the united will of all the deathless gods!"

Athena smiled, her grey eyes alight with fire: "Father of all, if this is truly pleasing to the blessed immortals, let us dispatch Hermes the Guide, slayer of Argus, to the island of Ogygia, to declare our unwavering decree to the lovely-haired nymph Calypso—the steadfast return of enduring Odysseus! Meanwhile, I will descend in haste to Ithaca, that I may kindle greater courage in his son Telemachus, putting strength into his heart to summon the long-haired Achaeans to an assembly, and speak his mind to all the suitors who butcher his sheep and crooked-horned cattle without ceasing! Then I shall send him to sandy Pylos and Sparta to seek tidings of his father's return, and win noble renown among mortal men!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Pallas Athena, disguised in the bronze mantle of Mentes the Taphian chieftain, surveyed the grand Ithacan hall where thirty brazen vessels of wine stood emptied beside the hearth.

Athena leaned upon her bronze-headed spear: "Telemachus, you must no longer cling to your boyhood, for you are of an age to stand upright among men! Have you not heard what renown noble Orestes won throughout the mortal world when he avenged his father Agamemnon upon treacherous Aegisthus? You too, tall and gallant as I see you, must be bold, so that many a warrior yet unborn will speak your name with reverence!"

Telemachus bowed his head, his hand closing over his father’s old hunting knife: "Stranger, you speak to me with the kindness of a father to a son, and never shall I forget your words! Even though you hasten to your ship, stay, bathe, refresh your spirit with meat and vintage wine, and take with you a costly gift of heirloom bronze, that you may treasure it in your own halls as a memorial of our friendship!"

From behind the fragrant wooden pillars, Penelope whispered: "O Zeus of the summits, why has thou given me a heart that cannot forget? Other women lose their lords in battle and find solace when the pyre is cold; but my Odysseus was swallowed by some nameless gulf where no stone marks his dust, leaving me only tears that water my pillow until grey dawn!"

Athena vanished into the twilight air like a sea-eagle soaring toward the mountain crags, leaving in Telemachus’ breast a power and daring he had never felt before.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

Telemachus gazed out over the dark rolling surf: "A mortal man does not choose his father, nor can he turn aside the decree of the deathless gods. But he can choose whether to cower like a dog beneath the table or stand upon the threshold with his spear held high! If Odysseus lives, he will find a son worthy to fight at his right hand; and if he is dead, his shadow shall not blush for my name in the halls of Hades!"

Penelope stroked the unstrung threads of her loom: "Let them feast; let them slaughter the yearling heifers and boast of dividing my husband’s royal seat! A house built upon blood and greed has no foundation. The mills of the gods grind late, but they grind exceedingly fine; and every cup of wine these suitors spill upon my floors shall be repaid with a cup of black death when the master returns!"

Odysseus, his hands hardened by adze and oar, looked back upon the cedar forests of Ogygia: "Twenty years... Troy is ashes, Achilles is a shade, and the great kings of Greece are scattered or murdered in their beds! Yet my heart beats on, stubborn as bronze! Let Poseidon raise his mountains of brine; a man who has endured the fury of Hector’s spear will not tremble before the howling of the wind!"

Athena’s divine whisper carried through the spray: "Go forth, beloved son of Laertes! The Phaeacian shores lie ahead, where swift ships wait that fly without rudders, guided only by the thoughts of men! Keep your wisdom hidden in your heart, for the greatest battle of your life awaits not on foreign sands, but within the gates of your own home!"

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Telemachus turned to the assembly with proud resolve: "Men of Ithaca, witness my oath! If my father does not return within the year, I will build him a tomb high upon the headland, celebrate splendid funeral rites as befits a king, and give my mother in marriage to whomsoever her heart chooses! But until that day, let no man lay violent hands upon this house!"

Athena spoke in the cool morning breeze: "Fear nothing, son of Odysseus! The seed of the wise shall not be cut off in the gate; your sails will catch the breath of favorable winds, and your eyes shall look upon kings who cherish your father’s memory!"

Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

Telemachus poured sweet wine from a two-handled cup: "Hear me, Pallas Athena! Thou who didst visit our halls yesterday as a stranger, bidding me sail the hazy deep to seek tidings of my father’s return—fulfill now thy gracious purpose and grant safe harbor to our company!"

The wind hummed through the rigging as the purple wave hissed aloud around the stem of the ship, driving her swiftly forward upon her journey across the wine-dark sea.

Athena cast her shining aegis over the waves: "Neither storm nor mortal peril shall defeat the man whom wisdom guides! Let your spirit be steadfast, for the glorious homecoming of Odysseus is registered in the decrees of Zeus!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

SCENE 2: THE GREAT BANQUET HALL OF ITHACA — PALACE OF ODYSSEUS — DUSK

Down from the peaks of Olympus Athena plummeted like a wind-gust, binding to her feet the golden ambrosial sandals that bear her across water and boundless earth swift as a gale. She grasped her heavy bronze-tipped spear, colossal and keen, and landed on the stone threshold of Odysseus’ palace in Ithaca. In her hand she took the form of Mentes, lord of the seafaring Taphians. Before her stretched a scene of shameful revelry. More than a hundred arrogant young lords of Ithaca, Dulichium, Same, and wooded Zacynthus reclined on hides of oxen they had butchered themselves, playing dice on stone tables while heralds and busy squires mixed dark wine with water in silver kraters and carved mountainous platters of roasted meat.

Telemachus, sitting apart among the brawling suitors with a heavy heart, caught sight of the stranger standing neglected at the outer gate. Grieved to the soul that a guest should wait at the portal, he hastened forward, took the stranger’s right hand, relieved him of the bronze spear, and led him inside: "Welcome, stranger! You shall be entertained kindly in our halls, and only after you have tasted food and wine shall you tell us what need brings you to our hearth."

He set a carved chair for the goddess away from the clamor of the suitors, placing a golden footstool under her feet, and brought a silver basin and golden ewer to pour water over her hands. A carver set down platters of rich cuts, and a herald filled their cups with vintage wine. Across the hall, the suitors shouted in drunken laughter, wiping grease upon the polished tables.

Telemachus leaned his head close to Athena’s shoulder, speaking softly so no suitor might overhear: "Dear guest, do not take offense at my words. These men care for nothing but the lyre and song, easily enough, since they devour without payment the livelihood of another man—a man whose white bones now rot somewhere in the rain on distant shores, or tumble in the salt surf of the sea! If they were ever to see him return to Ithaca, they would pray for fleeter feet rather than heaps of gold and fine garments! But he has perished by an evil doom, and there is no comfort left for us, even if some mortal traveler swears he will yet return; the day of his homecoming is clean lost! But tell me truly: who are you, and whence? What ship brought you to our rocky shores?"

Athena looked into the young prince’s troubled eyes with piercing warmth: "I declare to you all things plainly. I am Mentes, son of wise Anchialus, and I rule over the oar-loving Taphians. My ship stands anchored in the harbor of Reithron under wooded Neion, laden with gleaming iron to trade for bronze in Temese. I claim an ancient guest-friendship with your house; ask your aged grandfather Laertes, who they say comes no longer to town, but lives sorrowing on his farm with an old woman to serve him food when weariness takes his limbs from climbing his vineyard terrace! But I tell you now with prophetic certainty: Odysseus is not dead upon the earth! He is held back still on the wide sea, alive on some wave-washed island where savage men guard him! But he will not long remain absent from his dear fatherland, not even if chains of iron bind him, for he is a man of countless wiles, and will devise a way to return!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Pallas Athena, disguised in the bronze mantle of Mentes the Taphian chieftain, surveyed the grand Ithacan hall where thirty brazen vessels of wine stood emptied beside the hearth.

Athena leaned upon her bronze-headed spear: "Telemachus, you must no longer cling to your boyhood, for you are of an age to stand upright among men! Have you not heard what renown noble Orestes won throughout the mortal world when he avenged his father Agamemnon upon treacherous Aegisthus? You too, tall and gallant as I see you, must be bold, so that many a warrior yet unborn will speak your name with reverence!"

Telemachus bowed his head, his hand closing over his father’s old hunting knife: "Stranger, you speak to me with the kindness of a father to a son, and never shall I forget your words! Even though you hasten to your ship, stay, bathe, refresh your spirit with meat and vintage wine, and take with you a costly gift of heirloom bronze, that you may treasure it in your own halls as a memorial of our friendship!"

From behind the fragrant wooden pillars, Penelope whispered: "O Zeus of the summits, why has thou given me a heart that cannot forget? Other women lose their lords in battle and find solace when the pyre is cold; but my Odysseus was swallowed by some nameless gulf where no stone marks his dust, leaving me only tears that water my pillow until grey dawn!"

Athena vanished into the twilight air like a sea-eagle soaring toward the mountain crags, leaving in Telemachus’ breast a power and daring he had never felt before.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

Telemachus gazed out over the dark rolling surf: "A mortal man does not choose his father, nor can he turn aside the decree of the deathless gods. But he can choose whether to cower like a dog beneath the table or stand upon the threshold with his spear held high! If Odysseus lives, he will find a son worthy to fight at his right hand; and if he is dead, his shadow shall not blush for my name in the halls of Hades!"

Penelope stroked the unstrung threads of her loom: "Let them feast; let them slaughter the yearling heifers and boast of dividing my husband’s royal seat! A house built upon blood and greed has no foundation. The mills of the gods grind late, but they grind exceedingly fine; and every cup of wine these suitors spill upon my floors shall be repaid with a cup of black death when the master returns!"

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SCENE 3: THE UPPER CHAMBERS & THE BANQUET HALL — NIGHT

In the center of the hall, the divine minstrel Phemius, compelled by the suitors to perform, struck the sweet strings of his silver lyre and sang of the sorrowful return of the Achaeans which Pallas Athena had laid upon them from Troy. From her high bedchamber, wise Penelope, daughter of Icarius, heard the divine song. She descended the cedar staircase accompanied by two handmaids, holding her lustrous veil across her cheeks as she stood beside the great doorpost of the hall, tears streaming down her face.

Penelope called out through her veil to the minstrel: "Phemius! You know many other songs to enchant mortal ears, the deeds of heroes and gods which bards celebrate! Sing one of those to these guests, and let them drink their wine in silence; but cease this bitter song that wears away the heart in my breast! For an unforgotten sorrow clings to me above all women; so dear a head do I mourn without ceasing, my husband whose renown is broad through Hellas and the heart of Argos!"

Telemachus turned to his mother, his posture erect, filled with Athena’s newly planted fire: "Mother, why begrudge the noble minstrel the freedom to give pleasure as his spirit moves him? It is not the singers who are to blame, but Zeus who dispenses to toil-wearing mortals as he wills! Do not blame Phemius for singing the bitter fate of the Danaans; men always praise most the song that rings newest in their ears! Let your heart endure to listen; Odysseus was not the only hero who lost his day of homecoming at Troy; many other warriors perished! Go to your chambers; attend to your distaff and your loom, and bid your handmaids ply their tasks! Authority in this house belongs to the men, and to me above all, for mine is the mastery in this hall!"

Astonished by her son’s sudden command, Penelope turned back up the stairs, pondering in her heart the wise words of Telemachus. Entering her chamber with her women, she wept for Odysseus, her dear husband, until grey-eyed Athena cast sweet sleep upon her eyelids. Down in the hall, the suitors raised a clamor of indignation.

Antinous sneered from his couch, shaking his jeweled cup: "Telemachus, surely the gods themselves teach you to speak so proudly and play the haughty orator! May the son of Cronus never make you king in sea-girt Ithaca, though by birth it is your ancestral heritage!"

Telemachus fixed his gaze on Antinous without flinching: "Antinous, rage as you will, but I tell you this: I would gladly receive kingship from Zeus if he granted it! But there are many other princes of the Achaeans in island Ithaca, young and old; let one of them rule if Odysseus is dead! But of my own house and the slaves my father won by the spear, I shall be the absolute master! And tomorrow morning, I summon you all to the assembly-place, where I shall openly declare my warning: quit my halls! Feast upon your own substance, changing from house to house; but if you think it nobler and better to ruin one man’s livelihood without payment, waste on! I will call upon the everlasting gods, if Zeus may grant that deeds of requital be done; then shall you perish unavenged within these very walls!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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BOOK 2: THE ASSEMBLY OF ITHACA & THE OMEN OF THE EAGLES

Book II — The Accusation of the Suitors, The Shroud of Laertes & Telemachus Takes Ship

At sunrise, Telemachus summons the lords of Ithaca to the first public assembly held since Odysseus sailed for Troy twenty years earlier. Holding the speaker’s staff, the young prince weeps openly as he recounts the ruin of his estate and the violation of hospitality. Antinous brazenly blames Penelope, revealing her trick of the burial shroud woven by day and unraveled by night for three years. When Telemachus prays to Zeus for retribution, two colossal eagles plunge from the sky, clawing at their own throats as an omen of slaughter. The aged prophet Halitherses foretells Odysseus’ imminent return and the death of the suitors, but Eurymachus mocks the prophecy. Aided by Athena disguised as Mentor, Telemachus secretly provisions a twenty-oared ship and sets sail into the night across the wine-dark sea toward Pylos.

SCENE 1: THE MARKETPLACE OF ITHACA — THE AGORA — MORNING

When rosy-fingered Dawn, daughter of the morning, appeared in the eastern sky, Odysseus’ beloved son rose from his bed, buckled his sharp sword across his shoulder, bound his fair sandals beneath his gleaming feet, and stepped forth from his chamber like a god. Clear-voiced heralds blew their bronze horns through the streets, summoning the long-haired Achaeans to council. When the citizens were assembled, Telemachus entered holding a bronze spear, accompanied by two swift hunting hounds, while Athena shed an unearthly grace upon him so that all the elders marveled as he sat in his father’s carved stone seat.

Telemachus took the speaker’s scepter from the herald Pisenor, his voice ringing across the silent stones: "Elders of Ithaca, it is I who have called this assembly, for grief touches me closest of all! A two-fold ruin has fallen upon my house! First, I have lost my noble father, who once ruled over you all like a gentle parent! But now a calamity far greater threatens to shatter my entire estate! Suitors have besieged my mother against her will—sons of the very men who are foremost among you! They shrink from going to the palace of her father Icarius, that he might name her bride-price; instead, day after day, they slaughter our fat sheep, our cattle, and our prime fatted goats, drinking our sparkling wine without measure! All is squandered, for there is no Odysseus in this house to ward off ruin! I myself am too weak to defend it; but by Olympian Zeus and by Themis, who convenes and dissolves the assemblies of men, hold back, my friends! Leave me alone to waste in my bitter grief—unless my noble father Odysseus ever harmed the well-greaved Achaeans in malice, and in revenge you harm me by urging these men on! It would be better for me if you yourselves devoured my goods, for then we might go through the streets demanding restitution until all was repaid; but now you heap unhealable agony upon my soul!"

In his passion, Telemachus hurled the speaker’s staff to the ground, and tears burst from his eyes. Pity seized the entire gathering, and the people of Ithaca sat in stunned silence, no man daring to answer the weeping prince with harsh words, save Antinous alone.

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Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

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The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Telemachus stepped into the center of the ring: "Elders of Ithaca! You who fought beside my father in the ships of war—will you sit silent while his son is hunted like a stray dog? If it were my own kin who wronged you, you would demand justice; yet when these ravenous nobles devour my flocks and insolently mock the sacred laws of Zeus Xenios, not one gray head among you rises to protest!"

Antinous struck his heel against the stone: "Telemachus, boastful youth of uncontrolled fury, do not cast blame upon the Achaean suitors! Blame rather your own mother, whose cunning exceeds all women who ever wore gold in Hellas! For three years she has spun her web of deceit; let her choose a husband, or let her return to her father Icarius with her dowry! Until she yields, we will not leave your courtyards!"

In the sweet cellar, Eurycleia sealed the twelve two-handled jars of wine: "My sweetest child, why has this wild thought entered your heart? You are an only son, the solitary shoot of an ancient oak! Who will guide your rudder when the squalls blow off Cape Malea? Swear to me you will not set sail without telling your mother, lest her heart break with mourning!"

Telemachus bound her by the great oath of the gods to keep silence. In the shadows of the harbor, disguised Athena brought a swift fifty-oared vessel to the mole, and the youths boarded by starlight.

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Penelope stroked the unstrung threads of her loom: "Let them feast; let them slaughter the yearling heifers and boast of dividing my husband’s royal seat! A house built upon blood and greed has no foundation. The mills of the gods grind late, but they grind exceedingly fine; and every cup of wine these suitors spill upon my floors shall be repaid with a cup of black death when the master returns!"

Odysseus, his hands hardened by adze and oar, looked back upon the cedar forests of Ogygia: "Twenty years... Troy is ashes, Achilles is a shade, and the great kings of Greece are scattered or murdered in their beds! Yet my heart beats on, stubborn as bronze! Let Poseidon raise his mountains of brine; a man who has endured the fury of Hector’s spear will not tremble before the howling of the wind!"

Athena’s divine whisper carried through the spray: "Go forth, beloved son of Laertes! The Phaeacian shores lie ahead, where swift ships wait that fly without rudders, guided only by the thoughts of men! Keep your wisdom hidden in your heart, for the greatest battle of your life awaits not on foreign sands, but within the gates of your own home!"

The night sky turned pale above the eastern horizon. The stars of the Bear and Orion sank into the western waters, marking the ancient sea-lanes where destiny drove the wanderer toward his appointed harbor.

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Athena spoke in the cool morning breeze: "Fear nothing, son of Odysseus! The seed of the wise shall not be cut off in the gate; your sails will catch the breath of favorable winds, and your eyes shall look upon kings who cherish your father’s memory!"

Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

Telemachus poured sweet wine from a two-handled cup: "Hear me, Pallas Athena! Thou who didst visit our halls yesterday as a stranger, bidding me sail the hazy deep to seek tidings of my father’s return—fulfill now thy gracious purpose and grant safe harbor to our company!"

The wind hummed through the rigging as the purple wave hissed aloud around the stem of the ship, driving her swiftly forward upon her journey across the wine-dark sea.

Athena cast her shining aegis over the waves: "Neither storm nor mortal peril shall defeat the man whom wisdom guides! Let your spirit be steadfast, for the glorious homecoming of Odysseus is registered in the decrees of Zeus!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE ASSEMBLY GROUND — CONFRONTATION & THE EAGLE OMEN — DAY

Antinous rose, his lip curled in contempt: "Telemachus, high-spoken and uncontrolled in fury! What an accusation you hurl to put us to shame! The suitors of the Achaeans are not to blame for your ruin, but your own mother, who surpasses all women in craft! For three years now, and soon a fourth, she has mocked the hearts of the Achaeans! She gives hope to all, sends promises to every man by messenger, while her heart intends far different things! Consider the cunning trick she devised in her halls: she set up a great loom and wove fine linen thread, saying to us: ‘Young men, my suitors, since godlike Odysseus is dead, wait until I finish this robe, lest my threads be wasted—a burial shroud for Lord Laertes against the day when deadly fate shall strike him down!’ So she spoke, and our proud hearts consented! But by day she wove at the great web, and by night unraveled it by the light of torches! For three years she deceived the Achaeans; but when the fourth year came, one of her own women who knew the secret betrayed her, and we caught her unraveling the splendid web! Now we answer you plainly: send your mother back to her father Icarius, and bid her marry whomever her father chooses; but we will never depart from your halls until she weds one of the Achaeans!"

Telemachus raised his hands toward the open heavens: "Antinous, I can never drive from my house the mother who bore me and nursed me! If you have any shame left in your breasts, leave my banquet halls! But if you persist in devouring my substance, I will cry out to the deathless gods, if Zeus will grant that deeds of requital be wrought: then shall you die within this hall without vengeance!"

Even as the prayer left his lips, far-seeing Zeus sent two eagles soaring from a mountain crest high above. Side by side they winged their flight upon the wind, their vast pinions outspread. But when they reached the center of the crowded assembly, they wheeled, beat their wings with furious clatter, glared down with death in their eyes upon the heads of all below, and tore at their own cheeks and necks with their talons! Then they darted away to the right across the rooftops of the town. Terror fell upon all who watched, wondering what doom was unfolding.

Eurymachus laughed aloud, gesturing at the sky: "Old Halitherses, go home and prophesy to your little children, lest they suffer evil hereafter! In these matters I am a far better seer than you! Many birds fly under the rays of the sun, and not all are omens of fate! Odysseus has perished far away, and would that you had perished with him! We do not fear Telemachus, for all his loud words, nor do we care for your prophecy! The young prince’s property shall be eaten up, and there will never be recompense, as long as Penelope delays us from marriage!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Telemachus stepped into the center of the ring: "Elders of Ithaca! You who fought beside my father in the ships of war—will you sit silent while his son is hunted like a stray dog? If it were my own kin who wronged you, you would demand justice; yet when these ravenous nobles devour my flocks and insolently mock the sacred laws of Zeus Xenios, not one gray head among you rises to protest!"

Antinous struck his heel against the stone: "Telemachus, boastful youth of uncontrolled fury, do not cast blame upon the Achaean suitors! Blame rather your own mother, whose cunning exceeds all women who ever wore gold in Hellas! For three years she has spun her web of deceit; let her choose a husband, or let her return to her father Icarius with her dowry! Until she yields, we will not leave your courtyards!"

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SCENE 3: THE SHORE OF ITHACA — EMBARKATION BY NIGHT — NIGHT

Leaving the dissolved assembly, Telemachus walked alone along the foaming margin of the grey sea. He washed his hands in the surf and prayed to Athena. Instantly the goddess approached, taking the likeness and ringing voice of Mentor, the trusted counselor of Odysseus.

Athena laid her hand upon the prince: "Telemachus, neither coward nor fool shall you be hereafter, if your father’s manly spirit has poured into your veins! Few sons are the equals of their fathers; most are worse, and only a few surpass them! But since you lack neither wit nor courage, there is hope that you will accomplish this deed! Disregard the foolish plots of the suitors; they know not that death stands close beside them all! I will find you a swift ship and twenty sturdy rowers, and sail beside you myself across the wine-dark sea!"

Telemachus hastened to the palace store-room, where his aged nurse Eurycleia stood guard over jars of fragrant vintage wine and bins of golden barley meal. Weeping and wailing, she begged him not to venture upon the cruel sea where his father had vanished; but the prince bound her by a solemn oath to tell his mother nothing until twelve days had passed. At midnight, with the suitors asleep in drunken stupor, Telemachus and his crew hauled the black ship into the water, hoisted the white sail of ox-hide canvas, and caught the whistling West Wind sent by grey-eyed Athena, carving a phosphorescent furrow through the dark Aegean swell.

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

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BOOK 3: THE SACRIFICES AT PYLOS & THE WISDOM OF KING NESTOR

Book III — The Piety of the Neleids, The Fate of Agamemnon & The Chariot Journey to Sparta

At sunrise, Telemachus and disguised Athena land upon the shores of sandy Pylos. They find King Nestor and his sons gathered with thousands of citizens offering eighty-one coal-black bulls to the dark-haired Earth-Shaker Poseidon. Nestor receives the young travelers with exemplary sacred hospitality (xenia) before even asking their names. Hearing Telemachus inquire after Odysseus, Nestor recalls the glorious camaraderie and bitter hardships of Troy, weeping for fallen heroes—Achilles, Ajax, Patroclus, and his own brave son Antilochus. Nestor recounts how the Greek fleet fractured after the sack, how Agamemnon fell victim to the treachery of Aegisthus and Clytemnestra, and how young Orestes avenged his sire. Bidding Athena stay, the goddess transforms into a sea-osprey and flies away, revealing her divinity. Awed, Nestor sacrifices a golden-horned heifer and provides his stalwart son Pisistratus to guide Telemachus by chariot across the plains to Sparta.

SCENE 1: THE SHORE OF SANDY PYLOS — THE BLACK BULL SACRIFICE — MORNING

Leaving the lovely water behind, the sun leaped up into the bronze firmament of heaven to shed light upon the immortal gods and mortal men across the grain-giving earth. The ship of Telemachus glided into the harbor of Pylos, the well-built city of Neleus. Upon the white sands of the beach, the Pylian folk were gathered in nine companies of five hundred men each, offering sleek black bulls to Poseidon of the dark mane. Smoke from roasting thigh-bones wrapped in fat rose toward the sky. Pisistratus, the gallant young son of Nestor, ran forward, clasped the hands of the strangers, and seated them upon soft fleeces on the sand.

Athena took the golden cup of sweet wine from Pisistratus, praying into the foam: "Hear us, Poseidon, Girdler of the Earth, and grudge not to fulfill these prayers for us who call upon you! First grant glory to Nestor and his sons, and then bestow gracious requital upon all the folk of Pylos for this splendid hecatomb! And grant that Telemachus and I may accomplish all that brought us hither in our swift black ship!"

They ate of the roasted inner meats and drank the honeyed wine. Only when their thirst and hunger were satisfied did venerable King Nestor of Pylos turn his wise, wrinkled face toward the young prince.

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Nestor raised his four-handled cup of gold: "Young prince, you speak with the exact cadence of your illustrious sire! In all those terrible years before Ilium, while Achilles raged in his tent and Hector stormed the trenches, Odysseus was our shield of wisdom. When he spoke in the council of kings, his words fell like soft snowflakes in winter, and no man living could challenge his counsel. If grey-eyed Athena loves you as she loved your father, you will not long walk without honor!"

Telemachus leaned forward: "Wise Nestor, tell me of Agamemnon’s doom! Where was Menelaus when the trap was sprung in Mycenae? How could cowardly Aegisthus strike down the King of Men, who led a thousand ships against the walls of Priam?"

Nestor shook his silver locks: "Menelaus was tossed by storms to the shores of Egypt and Libya, his fleet shattered by the wrath of Apollo. Aegisthus seduced Clytemnestra with evil arts and butchered the king at the banquet like an ox at the stall! Therefore, Telemachus, do not stay long away from your home, leaving your goods unprotected among men so reckless, lest they divide your wealth and your journey prove in vain!"

The dawn spread its saffron mantle over the mountain peaks of Taygetus as Pisistratus, son of Nestor, cracked the whip over the spirited horses, carrying the young prince overland toward Sparta.

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Odysseus, his hands hardened by adze and oar, looked back upon the cedar forests of Ogygia: "Twenty years... Troy is ashes, Achilles is a shade, and the great kings of Greece are scattered or murdered in their beds! Yet my heart beats on, stubborn as bronze! Let Poseidon raise his mountains of brine; a man who has endured the fury of Hector’s spear will not tremble before the howling of the wind!"

Athena’s divine whisper carried through the spray: "Go forth, beloved son of Laertes! The Phaeacian shores lie ahead, where swift ships wait that fly without rudders, guided only by the thoughts of men! Keep your wisdom hidden in your heart, for the greatest battle of your life awaits not on foreign sands, but within the gates of your own home!"

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Athena spoke in the cool morning breeze: "Fear nothing, son of Odysseus! The seed of the wise shall not be cut off in the gate; your sails will catch the breath of favorable winds, and your eyes shall look upon kings who cherish your father’s memory!"

Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

Telemachus poured sweet wine from a two-handled cup: "Hear me, Pallas Athena! Thou who didst visit our halls yesterday as a stranger, bidding me sail the hazy deep to seek tidings of my father’s return—fulfill now thy gracious purpose and grant safe harbor to our company!"

The wind hummed through the rigging as the purple wave hissed aloud around the stem of the ship, driving her swiftly forward upon her journey across the wine-dark sea.

Athena cast her shining aegis over the waves: "Neither storm nor mortal peril shall defeat the man whom wisdom guides! Let your spirit be steadfast, for the glorious homecoming of Odysseus is registered in the decrees of Zeus!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

SCENE 2: THE ROYAL PALACE OF PYLOS — COUNCIL OF NESTOR — DAY

Nestor leaned forward on his polished stone seat, his voice sweeter than flowing honey: "Now it is fitting to question our guests, since they have enjoyed their food: strangers, who are you? Whence do you sail the watery paths? Is it on some merchant voyage, or do you wander recklessly over the brine like roving pirates who risk their lives bringing ruin to foreign folk? But stay—as I look upon your brow, wonder seizes me! Your speech is just like his; no one would believe a young man could speak so like him! You must be the son of great Odysseus!"

Telemachus bowed low before the ancient monarch: "O Nestor, son of Neleus, great glory of the Achaeans! We come from Ithaca under Mount Neriton; our quest is private, not public! I track the widespread fame of my father, enduring Odysseus, who they say fought beside you and sacked the proud citadel of Troy! Of all the other heroes who fought there, we have heard where each met his death; but his demise the son of Cronus has shrouded in mystery! Tell me if you saw his doom with your own eyes, or heard of his wandering from some other traveler! Do not soften your words out of pity for my youth; tell me plainly how he met his end!"

Nestor shook his silver head, wiping a tear: "Ah, my friend! You wake the memory of the immense sorrows we endured in that far country, through nine years of blood! There lies warlike Ajax; there lies Achilles; there lies Patroclus, peer of the gods in counsel; and there lies my own dear son, Antilochus, fleet of foot and fearless in combat! In counsel no man ever matched Odysseus; your noble father surpassed all men in every kind of stratagem! But when we had sacked the high citadel of Priam, Zeus devised in his heart a grievous return for the Argives, for not all were prudent or just. Athena’s wrath divided the sons of Atreus; Agamemnon wished to detain the host to offer hecatombs, while Menelaus urged swift sailing! Half the host sailed with me and Diomedes; Odysseus followed us at first, but turned back his curved ships to please Agamemnon! Of his subsequent fate, my child, I know nothing! But do not wander far from home yourself, leaving your halls to those insolent men; hasten to Menelaus in Sparta, for he has newly returned from Egypt and the far ends of the earth!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Nestor raised his four-handled cup of gold: "Young prince, you speak with the exact cadence of your illustrious sire! In all those terrible years before Ilium, while Achilles raged in his tent and Hector stormed the trenches, Odysseus was our shield of wisdom. When he spoke in the council of kings, his words fell like soft snowflakes in winter, and no man living could challenge his counsel. If grey-eyed Athena loves you as she loved your father, you will not long walk without honor!"

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Nestor shook his silver locks: "Menelaus was tossed by storms to the shores of Egypt and Libya, his fleet shattered by the wrath of Apollo. Aegisthus seduced Clytemnestra with evil arts and butchered the king at the banquet like an ox at the stall! Therefore, Telemachus, do not stay long away from your home, leaving your goods unprotected among men so reckless, lest they divide your wealth and your journey prove in vain!"

The dawn spread its saffron mantle over the mountain peaks of Taygetus as Pisistratus, son of Nestor, cracked the whip over the spirited horses, carrying the young prince overland toward Sparta.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

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SCENE 3: THE HIGH TERRACE OF PYLOS — THE CHARIOT DEPARTURE — DAWN

When night fell, Telemachus and Mentor moved to return to their ship; but Nestor caught them by their cloaks, insisting they sleep in the palace upon corded beds beneath purple blankets. Disguised Athena spoke words of praise, and in an instant transformed into a sea-osprey, soaring away on feathered wings into the twilight sky! Amazement seized all who beheld it. The aged king grasped Telemachus’ hand in wonder, recognizing that none other than the daughter of Zeus, the glorious Tritogeneia, was the guardian of the young prince as she had been of his father.

Nestor poured a libation of eleven-year-old wine from a golden bowl: "Dear boy, never shall you be a coward or weakling, when in your youth the gods themselves escort you as your guides! This is none other of those who hold Olympian halls than the daughter of Zeus, the glorious Lady of Plunder, who honored your noble father among the Argives! Be gracious, Queen, and grant fair renown to me and my children!"

Next morning, after a golden-horned heifer was sacrificed and the banquet concluded, Nestor’s sons yoked two high-crested horses to a carved chariot. Pisistratus took the reins and whip; Telemachus mounted beside him, and with a crack of the leather, the spirited stallions flew forward across the wheat-bearing plain toward Sparta.

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Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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BOOK 4: THE GOLDEN HALLS OF SPARTA & THE TALE OF PROTEUS

Book IV — The Hospitality of Menelaus, The Tears of Helen & The Ambush of the Suitors

Telemachus and Pisistratus arrive in hollow Lacedaemon during a double wedding feast in the gleaming palace of King Menelaus. The young prince marvels at the bronze, amber, silver, and ivory splendor of the palace, comparing it to the court of Zeus. Red-haired Menelaus welcomes them and weeps for fallen comrades, naming Odysseus as the friend he mourns most of all. Radiant Helen enters from her fragrant chamber, instantly recognizing Telemachus by his likeness to his father. To banish their weeping, Helen slips the Egyptian heart-ease drug nepenthe into the wine krater and recounts how Odysseus infiltrated Troy disguised as a battered beggar. Menelaus relates the story of the Wooden Horse and his own ordeal stranded on Pharos in Egypt, where he ambushed the Old Man of the Sea, the shapeshifting prophetic god Proteus. Proteus revealed that Odysseus is alive, held weeping without ships or crew on the secluded island of the nymph Calypso. Meanwhile in Ithaca, the suitors discover Telemachus has slipped away and prepare an armed ship to ambush and murder him in the straits of Asteris upon his return.

SCENE 1: THE PALACE OF LACEDAEMON — THE BANQUET OF MENELAUS — DUSK

The chariot rattled into the deep ravine of hollow Lacedaemon and drew up before the gates of renowned Menelaus. Within, the king was celebrating the weddings of his daughter Hermione to Neoptolemus, son of Achilles, and his son Megapenthes to the daughter of Alector. Grooms unyoked the sweating horses, led them to the stone mangers with spelt and barley, and ushered the travelers into the dazzling mansion. A radiance like the glow of the sun or moon filled the high-roofed halls. Polished bronze plates lined the walls, bordered with cornices of dark lapis, electrum, silver, and carved elephant ivory.

Telemachus leaned his head close to Pisistratus: "Look, son of Nestor, dear to my heart! Look at the gleam of bronze through these echoing halls, the flashing of gold, amber, silver, and ivory! Surely the court of Olympian Zeus within must be such as this, such boundless splendor is here! Awe holds me as I look!"

Menelaus overheard, and turned to the young men with a somber smile: "Dear children, no mortal man can vie with Zeus; his mansions and possessions are deathless! But among men, few can rival me in wealth, for through eight long years of wandering I gathered these riches in Cyprus, Phoenicia, Egypt, and the land of the Libyans! Yet while I wandered gathering this gold, my brother Agamemnon was murdered in his own house by stealth and treachery! Therefore I take no joy in ruling these treasures! Would that I dwelt here with only a third part of these riches, and that those brave men were still alive who perished in the broad Troad far from horse-pasturing Argos! Yet for all of them I grieve not so much as for one man, who makes sleep and food hateful to me when I remember him—for none of the Achaeans toiled so greatly as Odysseus toiled and dared! What sorrow was his lot, and what endless heartache mine for him, who has vanished so long, and we know not whether he is alive or dead!"

At the mention of his father's name, tears filled Telemachus' eyes. He drew his purple cloak before his face with both hands to hide the weeping, but the keen-eyed king watched him closely.

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

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Menelaus walked through the halls of glittering bronze: "Often I sit in these palace chambers weeping for all my companions who fell in the dusty plains of Troy. Yet for none do I lament so bitterly as for Odysseus! For seven long years I wandered in foreign waters, but what toils were mine compared to his? No man knows whether he is alive or dead, while old Laertes wastes away in his orchard, and chaste Penelope weeps in her chamber!"

Helen smiled with melancholy grace: "I remember when Odysseus entered Troy in the guise of a whipped slave, his shoulders scarred with self-inflicted wounds! He walked through our gates unnoticed, yet I recognized him! I questioned him, I bathed him and anointed him with fragrant oil, and he swore to me the secret plans of the Achaeans, for my heart had already turned home to Hellas!"

Menelaus gripped Telemachus’ shoulder: "On the island of Pharos we ambushed Proteus, the ancient wizard of the sea! He transformed into a lion, a serpent, a leopard, a running stream, and a leafy tree, but we gripped him fast until he resumed his shape and spoke: ‘The son of Laertes lives, held captive upon an island by the nymph Calypso, who weeps because he longs only to see the smoke of Ithaca!’ Take heart, Telemachus—your father’s spirit has not been extinguished!"

Deep in the rocky channel of Asteris, the suitors in their black-ribbed galley tightened their spear-straps, eager for the return of the Spartan carriage, plotting the prince’s blood.

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Telemachus turned to the assembly with proud resolve: "Men of Ithaca, witness my oath! If my father does not return within the year, I will build him a tomb high upon the headland, celebrate splendid funeral rites as befits a king, and give my mother in marriage to whomsoever her heart chooses! But until that day, let no man lay violent hands upon this house!"

Athena spoke in the cool morning breeze: "Fear nothing, son of Odysseus! The seed of the wise shall not be cut off in the gate; your sails will catch the breath of favorable winds, and your eyes shall look upon kings who cherish your father’s memory!"

Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

Telemachus poured sweet wine from a two-handled cup: "Hear me, Pallas Athena! Thou who didst visit our halls yesterday as a stranger, bidding me sail the hazy deep to seek tidings of my father’s return—fulfill now thy gracious purpose and grant safe harbor to our company!"

The wind hummed through the rigging as the purple wave hissed aloud around the stem of the ship, driving her swiftly forward upon her journey across the wine-dark sea.

Athena cast her shining aegis over the waves: "Neither storm nor mortal peril shall defeat the man whom wisdom guides! Let your spirit be steadfast, for the glorious homecoming of Odysseus is registered in the decrees of Zeus!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE GREAT HEARTH OF SPARTA — THE REVELATION OF HELEN — NIGHT

Then down from her fragrant, vaulted chamber came radiant Helen, looking like Artemis of the golden arrows. Her maidservants set for her a well-carved chair, brought a soft rug of violet wool, and placed beside her a silver work-basket on wheels, rimmed with gold and heaped with violet yarn, and her golden distaff. She sat, looked intently upon the weeping youth, and spoke at once to her husband.

Helen touched her husband’s arm: "Do we know, Menelaus, who these guests claim to be who have come to our hall? Shall I conceal my thought or speak it? My heart bids me speak: never have I seen anyone so like another, man or woman—wonder holds me as I look—as this youth is like the son of great-hearted Odysseus, Prince Telemachus, whom that hero left a newborn babe in his palace when for the sake of shameless me the Achaeans went up to Troy with war in their hearts!"

Menelaus confirmed the likeness of hands, eyes, and hair. As weeping spread through the room for fallen brothers and lost friends, Helen cast a drug into the bowl of wine from which they drank—nepenthe, which banished all sorrow and anger and brought forgetfulness of every evil. Whosoever drank it mixed in a cup could not shed a tear down his cheeks for an entire day, not even if his mother and father died, or his brother were slaughtered before his very eyes.

Menelaus leaned forward over his goblet, recounting the revelation of Proteus: "Listen, Telemachus, to what the Old Man of the Sea, infallible Proteus, declared to me when we pinned him beneath sealskins on the isle of Pharos! When I asked him of the heroes of Achaea, he spoke of your father: ‘The son of Laertes I saw upon an island, weeping great tears, in the halls of the nymph Calypso, who holds him by constraint; nor can he reach his native land, for he has no ships fitted with oars and no crew to bear him over the broad back of the sea!’ So spoke the ancient sea-god, Telemachus; your father lives, held on a lonely isle, yet unvanquished in his soul!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Menelaus walked through the halls of glittering bronze: "Often I sit in these palace chambers weeping for all my companions who fell in the dusty plains of Troy. Yet for none do I lament so bitterly as for Odysseus! For seven long years I wandered in foreign waters, but what toils were mine compared to his? No man knows whether he is alive or dead, while old Laertes wastes away in his orchard, and chaste Penelope weeps in her chamber!"

Helen smiled with melancholy grace: "I remember when Odysseus entered Troy in the guise of a whipped slave, his shoulders scarred with self-inflicted wounds! He walked through our gates unnoticed, yet I recognized him! I questioned him, I bathed him and anointed him with fragrant oil, and he swore to me the secret plans of the Achaeans, for my heart had already turned home to Hellas!"

Menelaus gripped Telemachus’ shoulder: "On the island of Pharos we ambushed Proteus, the ancient wizard of the sea! He transformed into a lion, a serpent, a leopard, a running stream, and a leafy tree, but we gripped him fast until he resumed his shape and spoke: ‘The son of Laertes lives, held captive upon an island by the nymph Calypso, who weeps because he longs only to see the smoke of Ithaca!’ Take heart, Telemachus—your father’s spirit has not been extinguished!"

Deep in the rocky channel of Asteris, the suitors in their black-ribbed galley tightened their spear-straps, eager for the return of the Spartan carriage, plotting the prince’s blood.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

Telemachus gazed out over the dark rolling surf: "A mortal man does not choose his father, nor can he turn aside the decree of the deathless gods. But he can choose whether to cower like a dog beneath the table or stand upon the threshold with his spear held high! If Odysseus lives, he will find a son worthy to fight at his right hand; and if he is dead, his shadow shall not blush for my name in the halls of Hades!"

Penelope stroked the unstrung threads of her loom: "Let them feast; let them slaughter the yearling heifers and boast of dividing my husband’s royal seat! A house built upon blood and greed has no foundation. The mills of the gods grind late, but they grind exceedingly fine; and every cup of wine these suitors spill upon my floors shall be repaid with a cup of black death when the master returns!"

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SCENE 3: THE WATERS OF ASTERIS — THE SUITORS’ AMBUSH — NIGHT

Back in Ithaca, outside the palace of Odysseus, the suitors were throwing quoits and javelins upon the level terrace, rejoicing in their arrogance. Noemon, owner of the ship Telemachus had borrowed, approached Antinous and asked when the prince would return with his vessel. Stunned fury convulsed Antinous and Eurymachus; they had believed Telemachus was only visiting the inland farms, never imagining he could successfully launch a ship with twenty picked men under their very noses.

Antinous’ dark eyes flashed with fire: "Out upon him! A proud work has been insolently brought to pass by this boy, this voyage we thought would never be accomplished! Against the will of all of us, he has gone, picking the best youths in town! Soon he will begin to be our bane! May Zeus crush his strength before he reaches the prime of manhood! But give me a swift ship and twenty comrades, that I may lie in wait for him in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Same as he sails home, so that he may find a bitter end to this voyaging in search of his father!"

They shouted in ruthless approval and hastened to the shore. Meanwhile, Penelope learned from the faithful herald Medon of her son’s departure and the plot to butcher him. Falling upon the threshold in agony, she wept until Athena sent a phantom in the likeness of her sister Iphthime to stand above her head in a dream, whispering that her son would return unharmed, for he had Pallas Athena as his guardian guide.

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

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BOOK 5: THE NYMPH CALYPSO & THE RAFT OF ODYSSEUS

Book V — The Mandate of Hermes, The Wrath of Poseidon & The Veil of Ino

Zeus dispatches Hermes across the sea to the remote island of Ogygia to command the nymph Calypso to release Odysseus. Hermes enters her fragrant grotto of cedar, alder, and four crystal springs, finding Calypso weaving with a golden shuttle. Bitterly rebuking the jealousy of the male gods who begrudge goddesses loving mortal men, Calypso nonetheless yields to Zeus' decree. She finds Odysseus sitting upon the rocky headland, weeping bitter tears as he gazes across the barren sea, yearning for his homeland. Calypso provides bronze axe-heads and augers; in four days Odysseus fells twenty tall alder and pine trees, constructing a sturdy broad-beamed raft. On the fifth day, equipped with clothing, sweet wine, and food, Odysseus sets sail. On the eighteenth day of his voyage, the shores of Phaeacia rise on the horizon. But Poseidon, returning from Ethiopia, spots him and unleashes a catastrophic tempest with his trident, shattering the raft's steering oar and breaking its timbers. The sea-nymph Ino Leucothea takes pity on Odysseus and gives him an immortal veil to bind beneath his breast. Stripping off his waterlogged garments, Odysseus leaps into the monstrous surge, swimming for two days and nights until, battered against sharp reefs, he crawls into the mouth of a calm river on the Phaeacian coast and collapses asleep beneath two olive bushes.

SCENE 1: THE GROTTO OF CALYPSO — ISLE OF OGYGIA — MORNING

Hermes the Guide bound beneath his feet his golden immortal sandals, took his wand with which he charms the eyes of men or rouses them from sleep, and plummeted from the upper air into the Pierian sea, skimming the dark waves like a gull hunting fish in the rolling surge. He arrived at the secluded isle of Ogygia, stepped from the violet waters, and approached the great cave of the lovely-haired nymph. A sweet fire of split cedar and juniper burned upon the hearth, perfuming the whole island. Around the cave grew a lush wood of alder, poplar, and sweet-scented cypress, where roosted owls, falcons, and chattering sea-crows. Four fountains ran with clear water, winding through soft meadows of violet and parsley. Calypso stood within, singing with a sweet voice as she moved to and fro before her loom with a golden shuttle.

Hermes leaned upon his wand: "Goddess, you question me as an immortal coming to an immortal; I will tell you the truth without deceit! Zeus commanded me to come hither! He says you have with you a man who is the most wretched of all who fought ten years about the city of Priam! The father of gods bids you send him away with all speed, for it is not his fate to perish here far from his friends; it is decreed that he shall look upon his high-roofed house and return to his fatherland!"

Calypso shuddered, her eyes flashing with hurt fury: "Cruel you are, you gods, and envious beyond all others, who begrudge goddesses that they should sleep openly with mortal men whom they have made their husbands! So when rosy-fingered Dawn chose Orion, you deathless gods begrudged him until chaste Artemis slew him with her gentle shafts in Ortygia! And so when fair-haired Demeter yielded to her passion and lay with Iasion in a thrice-plowed fallow field, Zeus soon learned of it and struck him with his blazing thunderbolt! And now you rage against me because a mortal man is with me! I saved him when he was astride his keel alone, when Zeus shattered his swift ship with a bolt in the wine-dark sea! I loved him, cherished him, and promised to make him immortal and ageless for all time! But since no god can evade or thwart the will of aegis-bearing Zeus, let him go! Let him venture across the barren water; I will give him counsel, but no ships can I provide, for I have no rowers to speed him on his way!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father's embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother's tears!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Calypso led Odysseus into the deep pine grove: "Go then, son of Laertes! Here is a double-edged bronze axe with a stout handle of olive wood, and here is an auger to bore the timbers! If you knew in your heart how many sorrows you must yet suffer before you touch your native shore, you would stay here with me and keep this cavern, sharing immortality! But go, for your mortal wife calls your soul across the surge!"

Odysseus measured the pine logs with line and chalk: "Goddess, do not think me ungrateful! Every gift of your hands is engraved upon my spirit. But a mortal man was not made to dwell forever in paradise while his kin suffer under foreign hands! Let the waves rise high as hills; I will face them, for my mind has been forged in the crucible of war!"

Poseidon leveled his trident: "Swim now, Odysseus! Let me see if your much-vaunted cunning can save you from the belly of the sea! Crawl upon your hands and knees to the Phaeacian coast, and even there you shall not escape the debt of sorrow you owe to the deep!"

The northern blast collided with the southern gale, spinning the raft like thistle-down across a summer field. Stripping off his drenched garments, Odysseus bound the immortal veil of Ino Leucothea to his breast and threw himself headlong into the frothing brine.

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Athena’s divine whisper carried through the spray: "Go forth, beloved son of Laertes! The Phaeacian shores lie ahead, where swift ships wait that fly without rudders, guided only by the thoughts of men! Keep your wisdom hidden in your heart, for the greatest battle of your life awaits not on foreign sands, but within the gates of your own home!"

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Athena spoke in the cool morning breeze: "Fear nothing, son of Odysseus! The seed of the wise shall not be cut off in the gate; your sails will catch the breath of favorable winds, and your eyes shall look upon kings who cherish your father’s memory!"

Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

Telemachus poured sweet wine from a two-handled cup: "Hear me, Pallas Athena! Thou who didst visit our halls yesterday as a stranger, bidding me sail the hazy deep to seek tidings of my father’s return—fulfill now thy gracious purpose and grant safe harbor to our company!"

The wind hummed through the rigging as the purple wave hissed aloud around the stem of the ship, driving her swiftly forward upon her journey across the wine-dark sea.

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The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

SCENE 2: THE ROCKY HEADLAND OF OGYGIA — THE WEEPING HERO — DAY

Calypso walked down to the barren beach where Odysseus sat upon the rocks, as was his daily custom. His eyes were never dry of tears; his sweet life-breath was wasting away in longing for his homeland, for the nymph pleased him no longer. By day he sat upon the rocks and sand, racking his soul with groans and weeping, staring out over the unharvested sea.

Calypso stood beside him: "Unhappy man, sorrow no more in this place, nor let your life waste away! With a willing heart I will send you forth! Arise; fell tall trees with a bronze axe, and build a broad-decked raft, that it may bear you over the misty sea! I will store it with bread, sweet water, and red wine to keep hunger from you, and send a favorable wind behind you, that you may reach your native land in safety—if it is the will of the gods who hold the broad heavens, who are mightier than I to plan and execute!"

Odysseus shuddered, his brow furrowing with ancient caution: "Goddess, some other purpose you plan in this, and not my sending home, when you bid me cross the great gulf of the sea on a raft—a gulf so terrible that not even balanced ships can pass it! I will never set foot upon a raft against your will unless you swear a mighty oath not to plot some fresh evil against me!"

Calypso smiled and stroked him with her hand: "A rogue you are, and not empty-headed, to think of such a word to utter! Let Earth be my witness, and broad Heaven above, and the down-flowing water of Styx—the greatest and most dreadful oath among the blessed gods—that I plan no fresh harm against you! My thoughts are such as I would devise for myself if such need fell upon me; for my heart is not made of iron, but has pity within!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Calypso led Odysseus into the deep pine grove: "Go then, son of Laertes! Here is a double-edged bronze axe with a stout handle of olive wood, and here is an auger to bore the timbers! If you knew in your heart how many sorrows you must yet suffer before you touch your native shore, you would stay here with me and keep this cavern, sharing immortality! But go, for your mortal wife calls your soul across the surge!"

Odysseus measured the pine logs with line and chalk: "Goddess, do not think me ungrateful! Every gift of your hands is engraved upon my spirit. But a mortal man was not made to dwell forever in paradise while his kin suffer under foreign hands! Let the waves rise high as hills; I will face them, for my mind has been forged in the crucible of war!"

Poseidon leveled his trident: "Swim now, Odysseus! Let me see if your much-vaunted cunning can save you from the belly of the sea! Crawl upon your hands and knees to the Phaeacian coast, and even there you shall not escape the debt of sorrow you owe to the deep!"

The northern blast collided with the southern gale, spinning the raft like thistle-down across a summer field. Stripping off his drenched garments, Odysseus bound the immortal veil of Ino Leucothea to his breast and threw himself headlong into the frothing brine.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

Telemachus gazed out over the dark rolling surf: "A mortal man does not choose his father, nor can he turn aside the decree of the deathless gods. But he can choose whether to cower like a dog beneath the table or stand upon the threshold with his spear held high! If Odysseus lives, he will find a son worthy to fight at his right hand; and if he is dead, his shadow shall not blush for my name in the halls of Hades!"

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SCENE 3: THE HIGH SURGE OF THE IONIAN SEA — THE TEMPEST OF POSEIDON — NIGHT

For seventeen days Odysseus steered by the Pleiades and the late-setting Boötes, keeping the Great Bear on his left hand. On the eighteenth day, the shadowy mountains of the Phaeacians’ land rose like a shield on the misty horizon. But returning from the sun-burned Ethiopians, Lord Poseidon spotted him from the Solymi mountains. Rage darkened the sea god’s brow.

Poseidon shook his trident, churning the dark waters into foam: "Out upon it! Surely the gods have changed their counsel concerning Odysseus while I was far away! He is near the land of the Phaeacians, where he is destined to escape the great coil of misery! But even yet, I think I will drive him to his fill of sorrow!"

He gathered the storm-clouds and threw the sea into turmoil, rousing the blasts of all four winds—Eurus, Notus, the fierce Zephyr, and Boreas born in the upper air. A mountainous wave crashed down upon the raft, spinning it around; the steering-oar was torn from Odysseus’ hands, and the mast snapped in two! Swept into the icy depths under waterlogged garments, Odysseus fought his way to the surface, coughing brine, and clambered back upon the floating timbers. Then Ino of the fair ankles, once a mortal and now Leucothea the sea-goddess, rose from the waves like a shearwater, perched upon the shattered raft, and spoke to him.

Ino extended a shining ribbon: "Unhappy man, why is Poseidon so furiously enraged against you? Strip off these heavy garments; leave your raft to drift with the winds, and strike out with your hands for the Phaeacian coast! Take this immortal veil; bind it beneath your chest, and have no fear of suffering or death! But when your hands touch the mainland, unloose it and fling it backward into the wine-dark sea without looking behind!"

Odysseus bound the sacred veil beneath his chest, cast himself into the waves, and swam with breast-strokes for two days and nights. On the third dawn, a colossal swell hurled him toward jagged coastal fangs; but Athena gave him presence of mind to grip a rock ledge with bleeding fingers. Swept off by the backwash, he swam along the breakers until he found the mouth of a calm river. Crawling ashore upon the gravel, his knees gave way, his lungs spewed salt brine, and he collapsed exhausted. Unwinding the veil, he cast it behind him into the river; Ino caught it in her hands. Odysseus kissed the grain-giving earth, crawled beneath a pair of intertwined wild and garden olive trees, heaped a mountain of dry leaves over his body, and sank into deep, merciful sleep.

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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BOOK 6: PRINCESS NAUSICAA & THE WASHING OF THE LINENS

Book VI — The Dream of the Maiden, The Ball Game by the River & The Golden Supplication

While Odysseus sleeps in the leaves, Athena visits Princess Nausicaa, daughter of King Alcinous of Phaeacia, in a dream, urging her to wash the royal linens at the river pools in preparation for her approaching marriage. In the morning, Nausicaa obtains a mule-wagon from her father and drives to the river mouth with her maidservants. After washing the clothes in the stone trenches and spreading them to dry on the sea-pebbles, the maidens bathe, oil themselves, and play ball, singing clear-toned songs. A stray throw lands the ball in a deep river eddy; the girls shriek in alarm, waking Odysseus. Crusted with dried salt brine, naked, and clutching a leafy olive bough to shield his manhood, Odysseus emerges like a mountain lion. The terrified maids scatter across the spits, but Nausicaa stands firm, her heart emboldened by Athena. Odysseus delivers an eloquent, courtly supplication, comparing her to Artemis and a slender palm shoot in Delos. Moved by his dignity, Nausicaa clothes him, gives him olive oil to bathe, and directs him how to enter the city and approach her mother Queen Arete to secure escort home.

SCENE 1: THE RIVER POOLS OF PHAEACIA — THE SEASHORE — MORNING

The sun climbed into the pure sky over the peaceful realm of Scheria. Down to the river mouth clattered the high mule-wagon bearing Princess Nausicaa and baskets of soiled royal robes, cloaks, and glittering coverlets. Beside them trotted the maidservants carrying jars of golden olive oil and baskets of bread, meat, and sweet wine packed by Queen Arete. At the river pools where clean water welled through stone basins, the girls trod the garments in the trenches with swift feet, racing one another in cheerful rivalry. When the linen was rinsed clean, they spread it in neat rows along the beach where the sea-surge washed the pebbles white.

Nausicaa tossed her head, her glossy hair gleaming in the sunlight: "Come, maids! The clothes are drying under the sun; let us bathe in the clear eddy and anoint ourselves with oil, and eat our meal beside the river bank!"

They bathed, rubbed their smooth limbs with olive oil, and took their dinner on the river bank. When they had finished eating, they threw off their head-veils and began to play at ball, with white-armed Nausicaa leading the song. As Artemis the archer moves down the peaks of Taygetus or Erymanthus, exulting in the chase of boars and fleet stags, while the nymphs of the woods play about her, and her mother Leto rejoices in heart because her daughter towers above them all—so among her handmaids shone the unwed maiden.

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

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From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

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The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Nausicaa stood tall on the river bank: "Stranger, you do not seem like an evil or foolish man! Zeus the Olympian distributes good fortune to noble and base as he wills, and to you he has given this trial which you must bear with fortitude! But now that you have reached our shores, you shall lack neither clothing nor any comfort that is due to a weary suppliant!"

Odysseus bowed with stately grace: "May the gods grant you all that your heart desires: a husband, a home, and the noble gift of harmony! For there is nothing mightier or more beautiful in this world than when a husband and wife keep house together with one heart and mind, a grief to their enemies and a joy to their friends!"

Nausicaa looked upon his transformed stature, murmuring to her maidens: "Listen, fair companions! Earlier this man seemed wretched and unlovely, but now he walks with the majesty of the immortals who hold Olympus! Would that such a man might be called my husband, content to dwell among the Phaeacians!"

The mules trotted smoothly over the dust, their silver bells tinkling in the afternoon sun, as the wagon carried the royal linen toward the high, harbor-girt citadel of King Alcinous.

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Odysseus bowed his head to the rising sun: "Great Helios who seest all things and hearest all things, bear witness! I seek neither conquest nor foreign gold, but only the rocky ridges of my island home, where the smoke rises from the hearth of my fathers!"

The ocean waves rolled with a rhythmic thunder against the reefs of Scheria, where the Phaeacian orchards dropped sweet figs and golden apples upon the fertile grass.

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The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE OLIVE THICKET — EMERGENCE OF THE WANDERER — DAY

When they were about to yoke the mules and fold the dried garments to return to town, Athena devised another counsel, that Odysseus might awake and behold the lovely maiden. The princess threw the ball to one of her companions; the maid missed, and the ball splashed into a deep swirling eddy! The maidens shrieked aloud. The shrill cry pierced the thicket where Odysseus lay sleeping. He sat bolt upright, rubbing his eyes, his heart beating fast.

Odysseus whispered to himself: "Woe is me! What mortal men dwell in this land? Are they savage and lawless, or hospitable to strangers with minds that fear the gods? A female cry of maidens echoed about me—is it nymphs of the steep crags and water-springs, or am I near human beings who possess speech? Come, let me see for myself!"

He broke off a leafy bough from the olive thicket with his mighty hand to shield his nakedness, and stepped forth like a mountain lion that walks in wind and rain, his eyes blazing, prowling among cattle or wild deer driven by hunger. So Odysseus advanced toward the fair-tressed maidens, though he was naked, for grim necessity was upon him. Dreadful he appeared to them, all caked with salt brine; and they fled trembling in every direction along the sand spits! Only the daughter of Alcinous stood her ground; Athena put courage into her heart and took fear from her limbs. She stood face to face with the stranger. Odysseus pondered whether to clasp her knees in supplication, or stand afar and plead with honeyed words.

Odysseus spoke from a respectful distance with soft, enchanting reverence: "I bow before you, Queen! Are you a goddess or a mortal? If you are one of the immortals who hold broad heaven, I liken you to Artemis, daughter of great Zeus, in beauty, stature, and bearing! But if you are a mortal who dwells on earth, thrice-blessed are your father and lady mother, and thrice-blessed your brothers! How their hearts must glow with joy when they see such a shoot entering the dance! But most blessed of all in his heart above all others is he who shall prevail with his bridal gifts and lead you to his house! Never yet have my eyes beheld such a mortal, neither man nor woman; awe holds me as I gaze! Once in Delos, beside the altar of Apollo, I saw such a sight—a fresh shoot of a palm tree springing up; and wonder seized my soul, for never had so lovely a sapling grown from the earth! So I wonder at you, lady, and revere you, and fear to clasp your knees! Pity me, Queen! To you first have I come after suffering countless woes; of the other mortals who dwell in this city I know none! Show me the town, and give me some rag to throw over myself, if you brought any wrapping for the linens! And may the gods grant you all that your heart desires—a husband, a home, and harmony of one mind; for there is nothing mightier or nobler than when husband and wife keep house together of one heart and mind, a great grief to their enemies and a joy to their friends!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

Telemachus gazed into the starry heavens, his hand resting on the hilt of his bronze sword: "A man who never knew his father’s embrace walks through the world like a ghost in his own house! Men say I am the son of Odysseus, but who can know his own begetter with certainty? Yet if I am his blood, I will not let this palace become a carcass for jackals to pick clean! Better to perish on the wine-dark sea in search of his bones than rot in silence watching my mother’s tears!"

Athena’s voice echoed like sea-foam in the breeze: "Telemachus, the line of Arcesius was never destined to perish without renown! The spirit of Odysseus is not water to be poured out and lost in the sand; it lives in your breast, in the fire of your eyes, and in the strength of your hands! Stand fast; endure the insolence of the suitors for a little season, for the net of justice is weaving in the dark, and its meshes no wicked man can break!"

From the high chamber, Penelope spoke to the night air: "Twenty years the sun has wheeled through the constellations, and twenty years this bed has remained cold as stone. Odysseus, wherever your ship rides—whether under the fragrant boughs of Calypso, or in the black currents of the outer deep—remember the olive tree we planted together, and let your spirit fight its way home through the storm!"

Beside the ocean surf of Ogygia, Calypso watched Odysseus’ retreating figure: "He weeps for a mortal woman whose hair will turn to silver and whose flesh will return to dust! I offered him ageless immortality, to dwell with me beyond the reach of sickness and death; yet his mortal heart beats only for a rocky island and the smoke of his own chimney! What mysterious power has home over the fragile sons of earth, that they choose mortality and suffering over eternity with a goddess?"

Odysseus drove his adze into the cedar logs, whispering to the sea: "Goddess, do not be angry! I know well that wise Penelope is inferior to you in beauty and stature, for she is mortal and you are ageless forever! Yet even so, my longing burns night and day to see my home! And if some god shatters my raft upon the wine-dark sea, I will endure it, having a heart in my breast that has learned to suffer in the waves and in the war!"

The cedar chips flew thick as snow under the bronze blade. By starlight and dawn, the raft took shape, bound with stout wooden pins and wicker bulwarks, ready to brave the wrath of the Earth-Shaker across the trackless surge.

Nausicaa stood tall on the river bank: "Stranger, you do not seem like an evil or foolish man! Zeus the Olympian distributes good fortune to noble and base as he wills, and to you he has given this trial which you must bear with fortitude! But now that you have reached our shores, you shall lack neither clothing nor any comfort that is due to a weary suppliant!"

Odysseus bowed with stately grace: "May the gods grant you all that your heart desires: a husband, a home, and the noble gift of harmony! For there is nothing mightier or more beautiful in this world than when a husband and wife keep house together with one heart and mind, a grief to their enemies and a joy to their friends!"

Nausicaa looked upon his transformed stature, murmuring to her maidens: "Listen, fair companions! Earlier this man seemed wretched and unlovely, but now he walks with the majesty of the immortals who hold Olympus! Would that such a man might be called my husband, content to dwell among the Phaeacians!"

The mules trotted smoothly over the dust, their silver bells tinkling in the afternoon sun, as the wagon carried the royal linen toward the high, harbor-girt citadel of King Alcinous.

The evening fires on the mountain ridges of Ithaca and the Peloponnese flickered against the violet dark. Between the shores of sandy Pylos, hollow Lacedaemon, and the sea-girt cliffs of Ogygia, the threads of the great homecoming were being woven in the looms of the Fates.

Telemachus gazed out over the dark rolling surf: "A mortal man does not choose his father, nor can he turn aside the decree of the deathless gods. But he can choose whether to cower like a dog beneath the table or stand upon the threshold with his spear held high! If Odysseus lives, he will find a son worthy to fight at his right hand; and if he is dead, his shadow shall not blush for my name in the halls of Hades!"

Penelope stroked the unstrung threads of her loom: "Let them feast; let them slaughter the yearling heifers and boast of dividing my husband’s royal seat! A house built upon blood and greed has no foundation. The mills of the gods grind late, but they grind exceedingly fine; and every cup of wine these suitors spill upon my floors shall be repaid with a cup of black death when the master returns!"

Odysseus, his hands hardened by adze and oar, looked back upon the cedar forests of Ogygia: "Twenty years... Troy is ashes, Achilles is a shade, and the great kings of Greece are scattered or murdered in their beds! Yet my heart beats on, stubborn as bronze! Let Poseidon raise his mountains of brine; a man who has endured the fury of Hector’s spear will not tremble before the howling of the wind!"

Athena’s divine whisper carried through the spray: "Go forth, beloved son of Laertes! The Phaeacian shores lie ahead, where swift ships wait that fly without rudders, guided only by the thoughts of men! Keep your wisdom hidden in your heart, for the greatest battle of your life awaits not on foreign sands, but within the gates of your own home!"

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SCENE 3: THE STRAND & THE ROAD TO THE SACRED GROVE — DUSK

Nausicaa looked upon him with clear, admiring eyes: "Stranger, you seem neither an evil man nor a fool! Olympian Zeus himself assigns fortune to men, to the noble and the base, to each as he wills; to you he has given these trials, and you must endure them! But now, since you have reached our city and our land, you shall not lack for clothing or anything else that a suppliant should receive! I will show you the city, and tell you the name of our people: we are Phaeacians, and I am the daughter of great-hearted Alcinous, who holds the mastery and might among our folk!"

She summoned her trembling maids back, ordering them to give the stranger food, wine, and olive oil to wash in the sheltered eddy. Odysseus bathed the crusted salt from his skin and hair, anointed himself with oil, and put on the tunic and mantle the princess provided. Then Athena poured radiant beauty upon him, making him taller and more massive to behold, curling his hair like hyacinth blossoms. When he sat upon the beach apart, glowing with grace, the maiden stared at him in wonder, whispering to her handmaids that she wished such a man might be called her husband.

Nausicaa prepared her wagon: "Arise now, guest, that we may go to the town! But heed my words: while we pass through the fields, walk briskly behind my wagon with the maids. But when we approach the city, surrounded by high walls and flanked by two fair harbors where the black ships are hauled up, step aside and wait in the sacred poplar grove of Athena! For our people are proud seafaring folk with sharp tongues, and some insolent sailor might mock me: ‘Who is this tall, handsome stranger following Nausicaa? Where did she find him? Surely he will be her husband!’ So they would reproach me; and I would blame any maiden who did such things against her parents’ will! Wait in the grove until you judge I have reached my father’s palace. Then enter the town and ask for the mansion of Alcinous. Pass quickly through the great hall until you find my mother sitting at the hearth in the firelight, spinning sea-purple wool. Pass by my father’s throne and clasp my mother’s knees! If her heart is kindly disposed toward you, there is hope that you will see your friends and return in joy to your well-built house and native land!"

The salt sea whispered against the dark sands, carrying the ancient memory of the Achaean dead who sleep beneath the tumuli of Ilium. In the quiet watches of the night, when the Pleiades dip into the western stream, mortal hearts turn inward, weighing the fragile threads of destiny that bind kings and wanderers alike beneath the gaze of the immortals.

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ACT 2: THE GREAT WANDERINGS & MONSTERS OF THE DEEP

Trial, Temptation, Survival & The Realm of the Dead

BOOK 7: THE PALACE OF ALCINOUS & THE HEARTH OF QUEEN ARETE

Book VII — The Shrouding Mist of Athena, The Golden Gardens & The Supplication of the Queen

Odysseus prays in Athena's grove before walking toward the Phaeacian citadel. Athena meets him disguised as a young maiden carrying a water-pitcher and wraps him in a dense mist so none of the haughty townsfolk can see or insult him. Odysseus stands in awe before the palace of King Alcinous—bronze walls, golden doors hung on silver posts, golden and silver immortal watchdogs forged by Hephaestus, and torch-bearing statues of golden youths. Outside lies a four-acre walled orchard where pears, pomegranates, apples, figs, and grapes flourish year-round, fed by two perpetual fountains. Odysseus enters the banquet hall unseen. As he reaches the center, the mist dissolves; he falls to his knees, grasping the knees of Queen Arete, and pleads for safe escort to his homeland. Alcinous lifts him from the hearth ashes, seats him in the place of his favorite son, and promises an escort. That night, Queen Arete recognizes the cloak and tunic Odysseus wears as garments she wove with her own hands, and questions him; Odysseus recounts his escape from Calypso and his encounter with Princess Nausicaa, gallantly defending the maiden's conduct.

SCENE 1: OUTSIDE THE CITADEL OF PHAEACIA — THE VEILING MIST — DUSK

As the shadows lengthened across the fields, Odysseus arose from the sacred poplar grove and walked toward the high-walled city. To protect him from the scrutiny of the seafaring Phaeacians, Pallas Athena shed a thick, magical mist about his shoulders. Near the city gate, the goddess took the form of a young maiden carrying a clay pitcher on her shoulder. Odysseus halted and addressed her gently.

Odysseus stepped forward from the mist: "Child, would you guide me to the mansion of Alcinous, who is sovereign among this people? For I am a stranger who has suffered many trials, coming from a far country, and know none of the folk who dwell in this city."

Athena smiled: "Aye, sir stranger, I will show you the house you seek, for it lies hard by the palace of my own noble father! But walk in silence; look not upon any man nor question anyone! For the people here do not readily endure strangers, nor do they warmly welcome those who come from foreign lands! Their trust is in the speed of their swift ships, traversing the great gulf by the gift of Poseidon; their vessels fly like a wing or a thought!"

She led the way swiftly, and Odysseus followed in her footsteps, completely invisible to the sailors hauling ropes and mending nets beside the deep harbors. When they reached the palace gates, the maiden warned him to direct his prayer above all to Queen Arete, who was revered like a goddess by her husband, her children, and all the citizens for her wisdom and compassionate justice.

The torches in King Alcinous' banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men's own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

Odysseus spoke from the hearth: "Queen Arete, King Alcinous! I seek not your gold, nor do I come to marvel at your immortal orchards where pomegranates and figs bloom the whole year round! I come only as a battered traveler whose youth has been consumed by the barren sea! Grant me a ship and a crew of your valiant oarsmen, that I may see once more my high-roofed hall, my servants, and the rocky ridges of my native land!"

Alcinous struck the table: "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians! Tomorrow we will launch a black ship upon the salt sea, manned by two-and-fifty chosen youths from our city who are the best at the oar! We will convey this stranger to his home, even if it lie further than Euboea, the furthest edge of our voyaging, without toil or peril beneath our sails!"

Arete commanded her handmaids: "Spread thick rugs of purple wool in the echoing portico, and lay warm cloaks over the carved bedstead! Let this weary wanderer sleep in peace tonight, for in our house no suppliant shall ever find coldness or neglect!"

Odysseus lay down upon the soft bedstead, the fragrance of cedar wood filling his senses, while outside the Phaeacian sailors hauled the new black galley down to the tranquil edge of the harbor.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

Odysseus spoke to his anxious crew: "Comrades, we have survived the fury of the Cyclops and the dark magic of Aeaea! Let not your hearts fail you now! Courage is not the absence of fear, but the knowledge that honor demands our endurance! Row with steady rhythm; let the oars bite the brine together!"

Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

Shade of Achilles said, "Achilles’ shade strode across the asphodel meadow with great strides, rejoicing in his spirit that Odysseus had declared to him that his son was renowned in battle and first in every heroic council."

The black ship cut through the nocturnal surge under the guidance of the immortal stars, carrying the tale of the world’s wanderings toward the listening court of Phaeacia.

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The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

SCENE 2: THE SPLENDOR OF THE PHAEACIAN PALACE — THE BANQUET HALL — NIGHT

Odysseus stood upon the bronze threshold, his heart pounding in astonishment. A gleam like the radiance of the sun or moon filled the palace of Alcinous. Bronze walls ran from the threshold to the inner chamber, capped with a frieze of dark blue lapis. Golden doors swung on silver doorposts set in a bronze threshold, with a silver lintel and a golden door-handle. On either side stood golden and silver dogs, immortal and ageless forever, which Hephaestus had fashioned with cunning art to guard the palace. Inside, carved thrones were draped with delicate woven mantles, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat drinking and dining. Golden statues of youths stood upon sturdy pedestals, holding flaming torches to illuminate the banquets by night.

Still veiled in the divine mist, Odysseus passed through the great hall where the Phaeacian counselors were pouring libations to Hermes. He stepped directly to the central hearth where Queen Arete sat beside her husband. At that moment, the wondrous mist rolled away from his limbs like morning fog before the sun! A stunned silence fell upon the feast; every goblet was arrested in mid-air as the princes stared at the stranger suddenly revealed upon the stones. Odysseus sank to his knees, throwing his arms around the knees of Arete.

Odysseus clasped the queen’s knees, his voice echoing through the silent hall: "Arete, daughter of godlike Rhexenor! To your husband and to your knees have I come after suffering countless woes, and to these guests at your banquet! May the gods grant them happy lives, and may each hand down to his children his wealth and honors! But grant me an escort with all speed to reach my fatherland, for long already have I suffered sorrows far from my friends!"

Having spoken, he sat down in the hearth ashes beside the embers. For a long moment, no man spoke, until the aged counselor Echeneus rebuked the king, reminding him that it was unseemly for a guest to sit upon the dirty hearth among the cinders. King Alcinous rose, took the stranger by the hand, raised him from the ashes, and seated him in the silver-studded chair of his favorite son Laodamas, ordering wine poured and rich food served.

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

Odysseus spoke from the hearth: "Queen Arete, King Alcinous! I seek not your gold, nor do I come to marvel at your immortal orchards where pomegranates and figs bloom the whole year round! I come only as a battered traveler whose youth has been consumed by the barren sea! Grant me a ship and a crew of your valiant oarsmen, that I may see once more my high-roofed hall, my servants, and the rocky ridges of my native land!"

Alcinous struck the table: "Hear me, leaders and counselors of the Phaeacians! Tomorrow we will launch a black ship upon the salt sea, manned by two-and-fifty chosen youths from our city who are the best at the oar! We will convey this stranger to his home, even if it lie further than Euboea, the furthest edge of our voyaging, without toil or peril beneath our sails!"

Arete commanded her handmaids: "Spread thick rugs of purple wool in the echoing portico, and lay warm cloaks over the carved bedstead! Let this weary wanderer sleep in peace tonight, for in our house no suppliant shall ever find coldness or neglect!"

Odysseus lay down upon the soft bedstead, the fragrance of cedar wood filling his senses, while outside the Phaeacian sailors hauled the new black galley down to the tranquil edge of the harbor.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

Odysseus spoke to his anxious crew: "Comrades, we have survived the fury of the Cyclops and the dark magic of Aeaea! Let not your hearts fail you now! Courage is not the absence of fear, but the knowledge that honor demands our endurance! Row with steady rhythm; let the oars bite the brine together!"

Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

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SCENE 3: THE PRIVATE HEARTH — ARETE’S INTERROGATION — LATE NIGHT

When the counselors had finished drinking and departed to their houses to sleep, Odysseus was left alone in the hall beside King Alcinous and Queen Arete. The dying embers of the hearth cast red light across their faces. Arete looked closely at the handsome stranger and spoke; for she recognized the splendid mantle and tunic he wore, having woven them herself with her handmaids.

Arete fixed her eyes upon him: "Stranger, I will be the first to ask: who are you among men, and from what land do you come? And who gave you these garments? Did you not say that you came wandering hither over the sea?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "Hard it is, Queen, to tell the full tale of my sorrows, for the heavenly gods have laid many upon me! But I will answer what you ask: far out in the sea lies the island Ogygia, where dwells the daughter of Atlas, deceptive Calypso. Seven years she held me constrained, though I longed for my native land. But in the eighth year she bade me build a raft, sending me forth with food and garments. For seventeen days I sailed, until your mountains appeared; but Poseidon shattered my raft with a tempest! I swam through the breakers until I reached your river mouth, and slept beneath olive bushes. In the morning, your noble daughter came to the river with her maids. I supplicated her; and she showed wisdom beyond her years, such as you would never expect a young person to show! She gave me bread, sparkling wine, bathed me in the river, and gave me these clothes! Grieved as I am, this is the whole truth!"

Alcinous smiled broadly: "Stranger, in this one thing my child did not judge rightly, that she did not bring you to our halls herself with her maids!" But Odysseus quickly answered: "Blame not the blameless maiden, my lord! She bid me follow her, but I refused out of fear and reverence, lest your heart be provoked seeing me, for we tribes of men upon the earth are quick to take offense!" Delighted by his tact, Alcinous swore by Zeus, Athena, and Apollo that a man of such nobility would be welcome to wed his daughter and remain; but if he wished to return home, a Phaeacian ship with fifty-two oarsmen would convey him in peace, even if his home lay farther than Euboea, the very edge of the world.

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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BOOK 8: THE PHAEACIAN GAMES & THE SONGS OF DEMODOCUS

Book VIII — The Song of the Trojan Quarrel, The Discus Hurled & The Tale of the Wooden Horse

King Alcinous summons the Phaeacians to an assembly, ordering a swift black ship readied with fifty-two young oarsmen and inviting the lords to a feast in his palace. The blind minstrel Demodocus, beloved of the Muse, is led in and sings of the quarrel between Odysseus and Achilles at Troy. Overcome with memories, Odysseus covers his face with his sea-purple cloak and weeps silently. Alcinous notices his distress and diplomatically proposes athletic games—footraces, wrestling, jumping, and the discus. When the boastful youth Broadsea insults Odysseus, calling him a profit-seeking merchant rather than an athlete, Odysseus rises in wrath, takes up a stone discus far heavier than the others, and hurls it whistling through the air far beyond all marks, while Athena in disguise marks the throw. At the evening banquet, Demodocus sings the comic tale of Ares and Aphrodite caught in Hephaestus' invisible golden net. Then Odysseus requests the tale of the Wooden Horse and the sack of Troy; as Demodocus sings of the slaughter and victory, Odysseus breaks down in heart-rending tears like a woman weeping over the dying body of her husband on a battlefield. Alcinous halts the minstrel and demands Odysseus reveal his true name, his lineage, and the cause of his bitter grief.

SCENE 1: THE PALACE MEADOW — ATHLETIC GAMES OF THE PHAEACIANS — DAY

A vast concourse of Phaeacians poured into the grassy marketplace. The young champions stripped to compete in the games: Clytoneus won the footrace, Euryalus prevailed in wrestling, Amphialus leaped farthest, and Elatreus tossed the stone discus. Flushed with youth and wine, Laodamas and Broadsea looked upon the silent stranger sitting beside the king.

Broadsea stepped out into the arena, laughing derisively: "Look at the stranger! I do not take you, sir, for a man skilled in games such as are practiced among men! You look more like one who travels in a many-oared merchant ship, a captain of traders, minding his cargo, watching for wares and greedy for gain! No, you have no look of an athlete about you!"

Odysseus glared at him with eyes like flint: "Stranger, you have not spoken well; you seem a man reckless of speech! So the gods do not give graceful gifts to all men alike, neither beauty, nor wit, nor eloquence! One man is inferior in looks, but god crowns his speech with beauty, and men gaze upon him with delight as he speaks with gentle modesty; another is like the immortals in beauty, but no charm crowns his words! So you have a splendid form, nor could a god fashion it better, but your mind is empty as wind! You have provoked the spirit in my breast with your insolent words! I am not unskilled in games, as you babble; in my youth I think I was among the foremost when I trusted in my youth and strength of hand! Now I am worn with toil and sorrow, for I have endured much in wars of men and the grievous waves; but even so, worn as I am, I will try the contest, for your word was biting to the bone!"

He leaped up with his cloak still about him, seized a stone discus larger, thicker, and heavier by far than any the Phaeacians used, whirled, and let it fly from his mighty hand! The stone hummed through the air. The seafaring Phaeacians cowered against the ground as the missile whistled past; it flew far beyond all other marks, crashing into the turf! Athena in the likeness of a man placed the marker and called aloud: "Even a blind man, stranger, could find this mark by feeling with his hands, for it is not mingled with the crowd of throws, but lies far ahead of all! No Phaeacian will reach this mark, much less surpass it!"

The torches in King Alcinous' banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men's own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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Demodocus struck his lyre, his blind eyes turned toward heaven: "Sing, Muse, of how the Achaeans fired their tents and sailed away, leaving the great horse of pine upon the plain! Sing of Odysseus and warlike Menelaus waiting in the dark belly of the beast, while Helen walked three times around it calling the names of our wives! And sing of how the bronze spear of Ithaca broke the sleep of Troy!"

Odysseus buried his head in his cloak: "O friends, the wounds of Ilium never heal! We bought our victory with the blood of our dearest companions, and now their bones are dust and their children are slaves in foreign lands! Let the minstrel turn to gentler songs, for my soul is torn in pieces!"

King Alcinous stood up before the council: "Demodocus, hang your lyre upon its silver peg! The song that brings delight to one man brings tears of blood to another! Stranger, do not conceal your name with subtle crafts! Every man born into this world has a name given by his mother and father! Speak: what city claims you, and what is your glorious name?"

The Phaeacian lords leaned forward, holding their breath, as the stranger drew back the mantle from his weathered brow, revealing the face that had brought down the highest towers of Asia.

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The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE BANQUET HALL OF ALCINOUS — THE WOODEN HORSE — NIGHT

Torches flickered along the bronze walls as the feast resumed. Odysseus cut a choice portion of roast boar's chine, thick with white fat, and sent it by a herald to Demodocus, praising the blind bard whose songs were inspired by Apollo and the Muse. Then Odysseus leaned toward the minstrel.

Odysseus whispered to the bard: "Demodocus, I praise you above all mortal men! Change now your song, and sing the building of the Wooden Horse which Epeus fashioned with Athena's aid—the stratagem which godlike Odysseus led into the citadel filled with warriors who sacked Ilium! If you tell this tale faithfully, I will proclaim to all mankind that the god has endowed you with divine song!"

Stirred by the god, Demodocus began his song: how some of the Argives fired their tents and sailed away, while others sat hidden inside the horse with Odysseus in the heart of Troy's market; how the Trojans debated whether to hew the wood, cast it from the precipice, or dedicate it as a peace-offering to the gods; how the horse spilled its heroes into the sleeping streets; and how Odysseus and Menelaus strode like Ares into the palace of Deiphobus, winning the victory through the aid of mighty Athena.

As the tale unfolded, Odysseus melted into weeping. As a woman wails and throws herself across the body of her fallen husband who has died before his city defending his children from the pitiless day, and seeing him gasping in death she embraces him and shrieks aloud, while the enemy behind her beat her back with spears and lead her into slavery—so did Odysseus pour pitiful tears down from his eyelashes beneath his sea-purple cloak.

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

Demodocus struck his lyre, his blind eyes turned toward heaven: "Sing, Muse, of how the Achaeans fired their tents and sailed away, leaving the great horse of pine upon the plain! Sing of Odysseus and warlike Menelaus waiting in the dark belly of the beast, while Helen walked three times around it calling the names of our wives! And sing of how the bronze spear of Ithaca broke the sleep of Troy!"

Odysseus buried his head in his cloak: "O friends, the wounds of Ilium never heal! We bought our victory with the blood of our dearest companions, and now their bones are dust and their children are slaves in foreign lands! Let the minstrel turn to gentler songs, for my soul is torn in pieces!"

King Alcinous stood up before the council: "Demodocus, hang your lyre upon its silver peg! The song that brings delight to one man brings tears of blood to another! Stranger, do not conceal your name with subtle crafts! Every man born into this world has a name given by his mother and father! Speak: what city claims you, and what is your glorious name?"

The Phaeacian lords leaned forward, holding their breath, as the stranger drew back the mantle from his weathered brow, revealing the face that had brought down the highest towers of Asia.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

Odysseus spoke to his anxious crew: "Comrades, we have survived the fury of the Cyclops and the dark magic of Aeaea! Let not your hearts fail you now! Courage is not the absence of fear, but the knowledge that honor demands our endurance! Row with steady rhythm; let the oars bite the brine together!"

Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

Shade of Achilles said, "Achilles’ shade strode across the asphodel meadow with great strides, rejoicing in his spirit that Odysseus had declared to him that his son was renowned in battle and first in every heroic council."

The black ship cut through the nocturnal surge under the guidance of the immortal stars, carrying the tale of the world’s wanderings toward the listening court of Phaeacia.

Odysseus raised his goblet to King Alcinous: "There is no sweeter consummation than when merriment holds sway throughout a whole people, and banqueters seated in order in the halls listen to an inspired minstrel, while beside them the tables are laden with bread and meat, and the cupbearer draws sweet wine from the bowl and pours it into the cups!"

The night shadows deepened over the palace of Alcinous, while the Phaeacian youths checked the polished fir oars, ready to convey the hero across the misty deep to his ancestral home.

Odysseus gripped the helm, speaking into the tempest: "Stand firm, companions! No wave is higher than the fortitude of a steadfast mind! We have known the worst of trials, and we shall see our native hearths again!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 3: THE HIGH THRONE OF ALCINOUS — THE DEMAND FOR TRUTH — NIGHT

None of the banqueters noticed Odysseus’ tears, for he hid his face in the folds of his garment; but Alcinous, sitting beside him, heard his heavy groans. The king rose and addressed the gathering.

Alcinous raised his golden scepter: "Hear me, counselors of the Phaeacians! Let Demodocus stay his sweet lyre, for his song is not pleasing to all! Ever since we sat at meat and the divine minstrel began his singing, our guest has not ceased from tearful sorrow! Deep grief encompasses his soul! Let the singing cease, that all alike may rejoice, host and guest, for that is far the nobler way! And do you, stranger, conceal no longer with crafty thoughts what I shall ask you: speak plainly! Tell us your name, by which your father and mother called you at home, and your countrymen! For no mortal man is utterly nameless, neither noble nor base! And tell us your land, your people, and your city, that our intelligent ships may convey you thither—for our vessels have no steersmen or rudders, but know the thoughts of men and the cities of all the earth! Tell us why you weep and grieve in your soul when you hear of the Argives and the fall of Ilium! Did you lose some dear kinsman at Troy, or some true comrade, wise and brave, who was dear to your heart as a brother?"

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Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

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BOOK 9: THE GREAT APOLOGUE: LOTUS-EATERS & THE CYCLOPS POLYPH

Book IX — The Cicones, The Honeyed Lotus, The Cave of Nobody & The Blinding of the Giant

Odysseus reveals his name and lineage: "I am Odysseus, son of Laertes, known to the world for every kind of craft, and my fame reaches the heavens." He begins the epic recounting of his ten-year wanderings. Leaving Troy, twelve ships sack the Ciconian town of Ismarus, but the crew lingers over wine until Ciconian reinforcements kill six men from each ship. A storm drives them nine days to the land of the Lotus-Eaters, whose honey-sweet fruit strips men of all memory of home; Odysseus drags his weeping scouts back to the ships by force. Arriving at the fertile island off the coast of the savage, lawless Cyclopes, Odysseus takes twelve picked men and a skin of potent wine given by Maron, priest of Apollo, to explore the giant cave of Polyphemus. The giant returns with his flocks, seals the entrance with a colossal boulder that twenty-two wagons could not budge, and brutally butchers and devours two comrades. Trapped, Odysseus devises a cunning stratagem: he offers the sweet wine to Polyphemus until the monster collapses in drunken stupor, telling him his name is "Nobody" (Outis). While the giant sleeps, Odysseus and four men heat a massive sharpened olive stake in the embers and drive it, hissing and smoking, into Polyphemus' single eye! Polyphemus shrieks in agony; when other Cyclopes gather outside the cave, he shouts that "Nobody is killing me by fraud or by force!" The giants depart, advising him to pray to his father Poseidon. In the morning, Odysseus lashes his surviving men under the bellies of thick-fleeced rams and clings under the giant bellwether ram to escape. From the ship, Odysseus boasts his true name; enraged, Polyphemus hurls mountain peaks that nearly swamp the vessel, and curses Odysseus to lose all his crew and return home late, alone, in a stranger's ship, to find bitter ruin in his house.

SCENE 1: THE BANQUET HALL OF SCHERIA — THE REVELATION OF IDENTITY — NIGHT

The great hall grew silent as the sea before a storm. Odysseus lifted his head, brushed back his thick hair, and looked King Alcinous in the eyes. Every counselor leaned forward across the tables, their breath held.

Odysseus spoke with quiet, earth-shaking gravitas: "Lord Alcinous, renowned among all people! Truly it is a fine thing to listen to a minstrel such as this, whose voice is like the gods! But your heart turns to ask of my grievous woes, that I may weep and groan the more! What shall I tell you first, and what last, for the gods of heaven have laid countless sorrows upon me? First, I will declare my name, that you may know it: I am ODYSSEUS, son of Laertes, known to all mankind for every kind of stratagem, and my fame reaches into the broad heavens! My home is sunny Ithaca, where stands the mountain Neriton with trembling leaves, and many islands lie about it close to one another—Dulichium, Same, and wooded Zacynthus! A rugged land it is, but a noble nurse of boys; and for myself, I can behold nothing sweeter on earth than a man's own country! Calypso held me, lovely goddess, in her hollow caves, and Circe of Aeaea detained me in her halls; but they could never persuade the heart in my breast! For there is nothing sweeter than home and parents, though one dwell in a rich house in a far, foreign land!"

He recounted the raid upon Ismarus, the loss of seventy-two comrades to the Cicones, and the gale that swept them past Cape Malea to the land of the Lotus-Eaters. There, his scouts ate of the honey-sweet lotus, which banished all thought of returning home, longing only to linger forever browsing on the sweet flower. Odysseus dragged them weeping back to the ships, tied them beneath the benches, and ordered all oars into the water before others could taste the intoxicating oblivion.

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Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men's own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

Odysseus addressed the Phaeacians: "My comrades urged me to take the cheeses and drive the kids and lambs down to our swift ship and flee; but I would not listen—would that I had!—for I wanted to see the giant himself, and see if he would offer us guest-gifts! But his coming was not to be a joy to my companions!"

Polyphemus laughed, tearing two sailors apart against the rock: "Fool! We Cyclopes pay no heed to aegis-bearing Zeus or the blessed gods, for we are mightier by far than they! I will not spare you or your companions out of fear of Zeus’ wrath, unless my own appetite prompts me! Tell me where you anchored your well-built ship on your arrival, so that I may inspect it!"

Odysseus spoke with calculated grief: "The Earth-Shaker Poseidon smashed our vessel against the rocks at the headland of your island, driving it upon the reefs! But I, with these few survivors here, escaped destruction!"

The Cyclops devoured the men like a mountain lion, leaving neither entrails nor marrow-bones, washed down with great bowls of unmixed milk, before collapsing in a stupor across the cavern floor.

Odysseus shouted from the stern: "Polyphemus! Your savage cruelty has brought its own reward! You did not fear to devour guests in your own dwelling; therefore Zeus and the other gods have taken vengeance upon you!"

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SCENE 2: THE CAVERN OF POLYPHEMUS — THE MONSTROUS BANQUET — NIGHT

Odysseus described the crossing to the mainland of the lawless Cyclopes, giants who plant no crops, have no assemblies or laws, but dwell in cavernous peaks, each dispensing law to his own wives and children, uncaring for any neighbor. Leaving eleven ships at the goat-island, Odysseus sailed his own ship to the giant cave fringed with laurels. Taking twelve trusty men and a goatskin of sweet unmixed wine given by Maron, priest of Apollo—so potent that twenty measures of water were mixed with one cup, yet a divine fragrance rose from the bowl—they entered the cavern. Pens of lambs and kids lined the walls, and baskets overflowed with cheeses. At twilight, the monster returned, driving his flocks before him. He hoisted a colossal stone slab into the mouth—a rock so vast that two-and-twenty sturdy four-wheeled wagons could not have moved it from the sill.

Polyphemus kindled a fire, and his single eye flared in the red glare: "Strangers! Who are you? Whence do you sail the watery paths? Are you traders, or do you wander recklessly over the sea like pirates who risk their lives bringing ruin to foreign folk?"

Odysseus stepped forward from the shadows: "We are Achaeans, driven off course from Troy by all the winds that blow across the great gulf! We boast ourselves the soldiers of Agamemnon, whose fame is greatest under heaven, so mighty a city he sacked! Now we come to your knees as suppliants, hoping you will give us a guest-gift or show hospitality! Revere the gods, noble lord; we are your suppliants, and Zeus the protector of strangers champions guest and beggar alike!"

The Cyclops laughed with a sound like crumbling crags: "You are a fool, stranger, or come from the ends of the earth, to bid me fear or revere the gods! We Cyclopes care nothing for aegis-bearing Zeus or the blessed immortals, for we are mightier far than they! Nor would I spare you or your comrades to shun the wrath of Zeus, unless my own spirit bade me!"

Without another word, the giant sprang up, clutched two comrades in his massive fists like puppies, and dashed their brains out upon the stone floor! He hacked them limb from limb, devouring flesh, entrails, and marrow-bones like a mountain lion, washing the meat down with bowls of raw milk. Odysseus wept in helplessness, praying to Athena. Next evening, after the monster slaughtered two more men for supper, Odysseus stepped up to him, holding an ivy bowl filled with Maron’s dark, unmixed wine.

Odysseus held up the bowl: "Cyclops, drink of this wine, since you have eaten human flesh, that you may know what drink our ship held! I brought it as a libation to you, if you would take pity and send me on my way home!"

Polyphemus seized the bowl and drained it in a single gulp. Ecstasy flooded his monstrous face. He demanded a second bowl, and a third, and in his drunken stupor asked the stranger his name, promising a guest-gift in return.

Odysseus bowed low: "Cyclops, you ask me my glorious name; I will tell you, and do you grant me the guest-gift as you promised: NOBODY is my name! Nobody my mother and my father call me, and all my comrades likewise!"

Polyphemus chuckled slobbering: "Nobody! This shall be your guest-gift: Nobody will I eat last of all his comrades, and the others before him! That shall be your gift!"

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

Odysseus addressed the Phaeacians: "My comrades urged me to take the cheeses and drive the kids and lambs down to our swift ship and flee; but I would not listen—would that I had!—for I wanted to see the giant himself, and see if he would offer us guest-gifts! But his coming was not to be a joy to my companions!"

Polyphemus laughed, tearing two sailors apart against the rock: "Fool! We Cyclopes pay no heed to aegis-bearing Zeus or the blessed gods, for we are mightier by far than they! I will not spare you or your companions out of fear of Zeus’ wrath, unless my own appetite prompts me! Tell me where you anchored your well-built ship on your arrival, so that I may inspect it!"

Odysseus spoke with calculated grief: "The Earth-Shaker Poseidon smashed our vessel against the rocks at the headland of your island, driving it upon the reefs! But I, with these few survivors here, escaped destruction!"

The Cyclops devoured the men like a mountain lion, leaving neither entrails nor marrow-bones, washed down with great bowls of unmixed milk, before collapsing in a stupor across the cavern floor.

Odysseus shouted from the stern: "Polyphemus! Your savage cruelty has brought its own reward! You did not fear to devour guests in your own dwelling; therefore Zeus and the other gods have taken vengeance upon you!"

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

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Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

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The night shadows deepened over the palace of Alcinous, while the Phaeacian youths checked the polished fir oars, ready to convey the hero across the misty deep to his ancestral home.

Odysseus gripped the helm, speaking into the tempest: "Stand firm, companions! No wave is higher than the fortitude of a steadfast mind! We have known the worst of trials, and we shall see our native hearths again!"

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SCENE 3: THE CAVERN & THE SEASHORE — THE BLINDING & THE ESCAPE — DAWN

The giant toppled backward onto the cave floor, his massive neck twisted aside, vomiting wine and gobbets of human flesh in his stupor. Instantly Odysseus thrust a massive green olive-wood stake, long as a merchant ship’s mast, into the glowing coals until it flared white-hot. He encouraged his four chosen comrades. Seizing the glowing timber, they drove the sharpened point straight into the giant’s single eye, while Odysseus stood above, bearing down and spinning it like a shipwright boring a timber with an auger! The eyeball boiled; the roots of the eye crackled in the flame; his eyelashes and brow were singed to ash, and the eye hissed as a hot bronze axe-head hisses when a smith plunges it into cold water to temper it!

Polyphemus the Cyclops said, "Polyphemus shrieked a dreadful, monstrous cry that made the rock walls ring, and pulled the gore-spattered stake from his socket! Stumbling in darkness, he shouted to his fellow Cyclopes who dwelt in neighboring caves."

The neighboring giants gathered outside the blocked door: "What ails you, Polyphemus, that you shout so furiously through the ambrosial night, robbing us of sleep? Is any mortal man driving off your flocks against your will? Is anyone slaying you by fraud or by force?"

From the blackness Polyphemus roared: "O my friends! NOBODY is killing me by fraud and not by force!"

The giants shrugged and turned away: "Well then, if nobody does you violence when you are alone, sickness from great Zeus cannot be avoided! Pray to your father, Lord Poseidon!"

Odysseus laughed in his soul at how his false name had deceived them. At dawn, Polyphemus rolled away the stone to let his sheep out to graze, sitting in the doorway with outstretched hands to catch anyone trying to escape among the sheep. But Odysseus tied the rams in groups of three with willow twigs; beneath the middle ram of each trio hung a comrade. Odysseus himself chose the greatest bellwether of the flock, curled his hands deep into the thick golden fleece beneath its belly, and clung suspended with enduring patience. As the bellwether stepped out last, Polyphemus stroked its wool, wondering why his favorite ram lagged behind, but suspected nothing.

Once outside, Odysseus dropped from the fleece, unbound his men, drove the fat sheep to the beach, and shoved off into the surf. When the ship was as far out as a man’s shout can carry, Odysseus could not contain his heroic pride, and shouted back across the water.

Odysseus stood upon the stern and cried aloud: "Cyclops! If any mortal man asks who put out your eye and blinded you, tell him it was ODYSSEUS, sacker of cities, who blinded you—the son of Laertes, who has his home in Ithaca!"

Polyphemus tore off the peak of a colossal mountain and hurled it; it crashed into the sea just ahead of the prow, the tidal wave washing the vessel back to the shore. Again Odysseus pushed off with a pole. Polyphemus raised his hands to the starry sky, praying to his father: "Hear me, Poseidon, dark-haired Girdler of the Earth! If I am truly your son and you claim to be my father, grant that Odysseus, sacker of cities, son of Laertes who dwells in Ithaca, may never reach his home! But if it is fated that he see his friends and reach his well-built house, let him come late and in evil plight, having lost all his comrades, on the ship of strangers, and find bitter sorrow in his house!"

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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BOOK 10: THE WINDS OF AEOLUS & CIRCE OF THE BRAIDED TRESSES

Book X — The Bag of Storms, The Laestrygonian Cannibals, The Herb Moly & The Isle of Aeaea

Odysseus continues his tale. They reach the floating bronze-walled island of Aeolia, where King Aeolus, keeper of the winds, entertains them for a month. Aeolus binds all the howling storm-winds in an ox-hide bag secured with silver wire, releasing only the gentle West Wind to waft the twelve ships home. On the tenth day, the watch-fires of Ithaca are visible across the water. But while exhausted Odysseus sleeps, his suspicious crew mutters that the king carries secret gold, opens the silver wire, and releases the tempest, blowing the fleet all the way back to Aeolia. Denouncing Odysseus as cursed by the gods, Aeolus drives him away. Sailing six days, they reach Telepylus, the harbor of the giant Laestrygonians; the cannibal giants hurl boulder-sized crags, smashing eleven ships and spearing the drowning crew like fish. Odysseus’ solitary ship escapes to the wooded island of Aeaea, home of the dread sorceress Circe. Eurylochus leads twenty-two men to her stone palace, where mountain wolves and lions fawn like dogs. Circe welcomes them, feeds them cheese and barley spiked with a magical drug, and taps them with her wand, transforming them into swine! Eurylochus flees back in terror. Odysseus goes alone to rescue them; on the trail, Hermes appears, gives him the magical black-rooted moly flower, and instructs him how to overpower the enchantress. Odysseus drinks her potion unharmed, draws his sword, and makes her swear a solemn oath. Circe restores his men to human form, younger and handsomer than before. The crew remains on Aeaea for one full year. When they yearn for home, Circe reveals that Odysseus must first journey to the House of Hades and Persephone to consult the shade of the blind Theban prophet Tiresias. Before departure, young Elpenor falls from the palace roof in drunkenness and breaks his neck, his soul descending unburied to the Underworld.

SCENE 1: THE FLOATING ISLE OF AEOLIA & THE SEAS OFF ITHACA — DAY

Odysseus recounted their arrival at the floating island of Aeolia, surrounded by an unbreakable wall of bronze. There King Aeolus, steward of the winds, dwelt with his six sons and six daughters in perpetual feast. For a whole month he entertained Odysseus, asking of Troy and the return of the Argives. When Odysseus asked to depart, Aeolus flayed a nine-year-old ox, fashioned a sack, and bound within it the blustering blasts of all the winds, securing the mouth with a shining silver wire so that not the slightest breath could escape. Only the West Wind did he let blow, to waft the ships home.

Odysseus bowed his head to the Phaeacians: "For nine days and nights we sailed, and on the tenth our native fields appeared! We were so close that we could see men tending the beacon-fires upon the headlands of Ithaca! Then sweet sleep overcame my weary limbs, for I had held the steering-sheet myself without rest, trusting no other comrade! But my men began to speak evil words among themselves: ‘See what honor and love this captain finds wherever he goes! From Troy he carries home rich spoils of gold and bronze, while we who completed the same journey return with empty hands! And now Aeolus gives him these treasures in friendship! Come, let us open the bag and see what gold and silver lies within!’ So their evil counsel prevailed! They loosed the silver wire—and instantly all the winds burst forth together! A furious hurricane seized the ships and swept them wailing over the deep, away from our native land!"

Odysseus awoke, debating in his soul whether to cast himself into the sea and perish, or endure in silence. He wrapped his head in his cloak and lay in the hull. The gale drove them back to Aeolia. When Odysseus entered the palace as a suppliant, Aeolus shouted in disgust: "Begone from this island with all speed, vilest of living men! It is not lawful for me to entertain or escort a man hated by the blessed gods! Begone, for you come hither under divine curse!"

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

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Aeolus drove Odysseus from the bronze gate: "Away from this island swiftly, vilest of living men! It is not lawful for me to entertain or escort a traveler who is hated by the blessed immortals! Begone, for your return here proves the gods’ curse upon your head!"

Eurylochus collapsed before Odysseus, shaking with panic: "Do not lead us back to that stone palace, glorious Odysseus! Our comrades entered, lured by the sweet singing of a goddess at her loom, and not one returned! They vanished as if the earth had swallowed them! Let us flee with the men who remain, while our own lives are yet whole!"

Odysseus strapped on his great bow and sword: "Eurylochus, stay here by the hollow black ship and eat your fill! But as for me, a hard necessity is laid upon my shoulders: I go alone to rescue my companions!"

Circe poured sweet unmixed wine into golden cups: "Son of Laertes, master of stratagems! Put away your sword into its sheath! Let us trust one another in love, that mutual faith may bind our spirits! Eat of this feast, that strength may return to your breasts, for you look like men who wander without hope!"

For a year they remained in Aeaea, until Circe revealed the perilous truth: to reach Ithaca, Odysseus must first steer his black ship south into the sunless realm of Persephone and question the blind seer Tiresias.

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The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE FORESTS OF AEAEA — THE HERB MOLY & HERMES — DAY

He described the horror of the Laestrygonians, giant ogres who speared eleven ships of men like fish in a closed fjord, leaving only Odysseus’ single ship to reach the island of Aeaea. There dwelt Circe of the lovely braids, sister to wizard Aeetes, children of the Sun and the Oceanid Perse. Eurylochus led twenty-two men to her palace of polished stone, where mountain lions and wolves fawned around them like dogs wagging their tails for table-scraps. Circe invited them in, gave them Pramnian wine mixed with barley, cheese, honey, and a baneful drug, and tapped them with her wand. In an instant their bodies sprouted bristles; their voices became the grunts of pigs, though their minds remained human as before! Eurylochus escaped to the ship, weeping and unable to speak.

Odysseus slung his silver-studded sword over his shoulder, took his bow, and strode into the deep forest alone. In a glade, Hermes of the golden wand met him, looking like a handsome young prince with the first down upon his lip, and took him by the hand.

Hermes smiled: "Where are you going, reckless man, alone through these mountain valleys, knowing nothing of the land? Your comrades are penned in Circe’s sties like swine! Do you think you can set them free? You will never return yourself, but remain there with the rest! But see, I will deliver you from peril! Take this potent herb, and go to the palace of Circe; it will ward off the evil day from your head! She will mix you a potion, but will not be able to enchant you, for this magic root will prevent it! When Circe strikes you with her long wand, draw your sharp sword from your thigh and rush upon her as if eager to slay her! She will shrink back in terror and invite you to her bed! But do not refuse her love, that she may release your comrades; yet bid her first swear the great oath of the blessed gods that she will not plot fresh harm against your naked body!"

Hermes pulled a plant from the black earth and showed its nature: its root was black as pitch, but its flower was white as milk. Moly the gods call it; hard it is for mortal men to dig, but the deathless gods can do all things. Then Hermes departed through the wooded isle toward high Olympus.

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Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

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Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

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Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

Shade of Achilles said, "Achilles’ shade strode across the asphodel meadow with great strides, rejoicing in his spirit that Odysseus had declared to him that his son was renowned in battle and first in every heroic council."

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SCENE 3: THE PALACE OF CIRCE — THE OATH & THE UNDERWORLD MANDATE — DUSK

Odysseus stood upon the threshold of Circe’s palace and called out. She opened the gleaming doors, seated him on a silver-studded chair, and handed him a golden cup of wine spiked with her poison. He drank it dry, and the moly shielded his spirit. She struck him with her wand and cried: "Go now to the sty and lie with your companions!" But Odysseus drew his sharp sword from his thigh and sprang upon her with murder in his eyes! With a piercing shriek, Circe slipped under his blade, fell to her knees, and clasped him around the thighs, weeping.

Circe gazed up in awe: "What man are you, and whence? No other mortal has ever drunk this potion and remained uncharmed! Your mind within you is proof against enchantment! Surely you are that Odysseus of many wiles, whom Hermes of the golden wand always foretold would come to this isle on his way from Troy! Put up your sword into its sheath, and let us mount my bed, that mingled in love we may learn to trust one another!"

Odysseus bound her by the great oath of the gods. Then Circe led the way to the sties, drove out the swine, and smeared each beast with a wondrous ointment. The bristles fell away; their limbs returned, younger and handsomer than before! Weeping with joy, the comrades embraced their captain. For an entire year they remained on Aeaea, feasting on endless meat and honey-sweet wine. But when the seasons wheeled and the long days returned, the crew reminded Odysseus of Ithaca. He knelt at Circe’s knees and begged his departure.

Circe placed her hands upon his shoulders, her voice dark with mystery: "Son of Laertes, mastermind of wiles, Odysseus! Stay no longer in my house against your will! But another journey you must accomplish first: you must go to the House of Hades and dread Persephone, to consult the soul of Theban Tiresias, the blind seer, whose mind remains steadfast! For even in death, Persephone has granted him alone understanding, while the other ghosts flit about like shadows!"

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BOOK 11: THE NEKYIA: THE KINGDOM OF THE DEAD

Book XI — The Trench of Blood, The Prophecy of Tiresias & The Shades of the Heroes

Odysseus recounts the most terrifying chapter of his journey: the Nekyia, or descent to the Underworld. Guided by Circe’s instructions, the black ship crosses the deep stream of Oceanus to the dark borders of the Cimmerians, shrouded in perpetual mist and cloud where the sun never shines. Beaching the ship, Odysseus digs a trench a cubit square and pours libations of honey, milk, sweet wine, and water, sprinkling barley meal, and slaughters a black ram and ewe so the dark blood pours into the trench. Swarms of shrieking ghosts rise from Erebus—brides, youths, old men, and tender maidens with fresh grief in their hearts. Holding them at bay with his drawn sword, Odysseus first speaks with the shade of unburied Elpenor, who fell from Circe’s roof; Odysseus weeps and promises him full funeral rites on Aeaea. The blind prophet Tiresias approaches, drinks the black blood, and reveals the perilous path ahead: Poseidon’s relentless wrath, the vital prohibition against harming the cattle of Helios on Thrinacia, the slaughter of the suitors in Ithaca, and Odysseus’ final inland journey carrying an oar until a traveler mistakes it for a winnowing fan, where he must sacrifice to Poseidon to win a peaceful, gentle death in prosperous old age. Odysseus then speaks with the shade of his mother Anticlea, who died of broken-hearted grief for him, and attempts three times to embrace her, but her form slips through his arms like a shadow or a dream. A grand procession of famous queens and heroines of old passes before him. Then the shade of murdered Agamemnon appears, weeping bitterly as he recounts his betrayal by Clytemnestra and Aegisthus, warning Odysseus never to trust a woman completely. Next comes the shade of Achilles; when Odysseus attempts to console him, Achilles famously replies: "I would rather be a day-laborer on earth, bound to some poor dirt-farmer with little land, than rule as king over all the breathless ghosts of the dead!" Great Ajax stands apart in stony, unyielding silence, nursing his wrath over the armor of Achilles, refusing to utter a word. Odysseus witnesses the cosmic torments of Tityus, Tantalus, and Sisyphus, before terror of the Gorgon’s head seizes him and he flees back to his ship.

SCENE 1: THE SHORES OF OCEANUS — THE TRENCH OF BLACK BLOOD — GLOOM

The ship reached the deep-flowing Oceanus, the limits of the world, where lie the city and people of the Cimmerians, wrapped in mist and cloud. Never does the bright sun look upon them with his rays, but baneful night is spread over wretched mortals. They beached the ship, took the sheep, and walked along the stream of Oceanus until they reached the place Circe had named. With his bronze sword Odysseus dug a trench a cubit wide, poured libations of honey and milk, sweet wine, water, and pale barley, and slit the throats of the black ram and ewe. Dark blood welled into the pit. Instantly, from out of the murky abyss of Erebus, the fluttering spirits of the dead gathered with unearthly, squeaking cries—brides, unmarried youths, battle-slain warriors in blood-stained armor, and old men worn with sorrow! Pale fear seized Odysseus. He drew his sword and sat over the trench, forbidding the strengthless heads of the dead to taste the blood before he had questioned Tiresias.

Tiresias held his golden staff, drank the dark blood, and spoke with terrifying prophecy: "Glorious Odysseus, you seek a sweet return, but god will make it grievous for you! I do not think you can escape the Earth-Shaker, who harbors wrath in his heart against you for blinding his dear son! Yet even so, you may reach home after enduring much, if you will curb your own appetite and that of your companions when your ship reaches the island of Thrinacia! There feed the sleek cattle and fat sheep of Helios, who sees all and hears all! If you leave them unharmed and mind your return, you may yet reach Ithaca! But if you harm them, I foretell utter ruin for your ship and your crew! Even if you escape yourself, late shall you return, in evil plight, on the ship of strangers, having lost all your comrades, and find bitter sorrow in your halls—arrogant men devouring your substance and courting your noble wife! But you shall exact vengeance upon them when you come! And when you have slain the suitors in your hall, take a balanced oar upon your shoulder and march inland, until you reach a people who know nothing of the sea, who eat no food seasoned with salt, and know nothing of purple-cheeked ships! And this shall be a clear token that cannot be mistaken: when another wayfarer meets you and asks why you carry a winnowing fan on your splendid shoulder, plant your oar in the earth, offer rich sacrifices to Lord Poseidon—a ram, a bull, and a boar—and return home to offer sacred hecatombs to all the deathless gods! Then a gentle death shall come to you far from the sea, taking you in serene old age with your people prosperous about you! All this I tell you without falsehood!"

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The ghost of Elpenor fluttered before the trench: "Odysseus, do not leave my body unwept and unburied behind you on Aeaea! Burn my armor upon the shore, heap up a mound of earth over my ashes beside the grey sea, and plant upon my barrow the shapely oar with which I rowed among my companions while I lived under the sun!"

Anticleia reached out insubstantial hands: "My child! How did you come beneath this murky gloom while yet living? It was no sickness that took my life, nor did Artemis of the golden arrows strike me down; it was longing for you, Odysseus, for your wisdom and your tender heart, that severed the sweet breath from my limbs!"

Odysseus wept bitter tears: "Mother! Why do you slip from my embrace like a shadow or a dream? Has dread Persephone sent only a phantom to redouble my sorrow?"

Anticleia sighed like the wind through reeds: "Alas, my son! This is the law of mortals when they die: the sinews no longer hold the flesh and bones together, but the fierce power of burning fire consumes them as soon as life leaves the white bones, and the spirit flits away like a dream! Return swiftly to the light, and remember all these things that you may recount them to your wife!"

The great shades of Minos, Orion, Tityus, Tantalus stretching for the receding water, and Sisyphus rolling his monstrous boulder up the mountain passed before his eyes, before Odysseus fled back to the living sea.

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The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

SCENE 2: THE ASHES OF EREBUS — ANTICLEA & AGAMEMNON — GLOOM

Next came the shade of his mother Anticlea, whom Odysseus had left alive when he sailed for Troy. Weeping, she drank of the blood and told him of Ithaca: how Penelope waited in steadfast grief, how Telemachus held the royal land, and how she herself had died—not of illness or the arrows of Artemis, but of heartbreak and longing for her son Odysseus, for his wisdom and his tender heart. Thrice Odysseus sprang forward, yearning to clasp her in his arms; and thrice she flitted through his hands like a shadow or a dream. Bitter grief pierced his heart as she explained that in death, sinews no longer hold flesh and bone together, but the spirit flits away like smoke.

Then came the shade of Agamemnon, weeping great tears and stretching out his hands in vain to touch his former comrade.

Agamemnon moaned: "Odysseus of many wiles! It was not Poseidon who wrecked my ships, nor enemy spearmen on the shore! It was Aegisthus who plotted my murder, with my cursed wife Clytemnestra! He invited me to a feast, and butchered me like an ox at the manger! My comrades were slaughtered around me without mercy, like white-tusked swine at a wedding feast! Most pitiful of all was the cry of Priam’s daughter Cassandra, whom deceitful Clytemnestra slew over my body; and as I lay dying upon the earth with the bronze blade in my chest, I tried to raise my hands, but the shameless bitch turned away, and would not even close my eyes or shut my mouth as my soul went down to Hades! Therefore I say to you: never be gentle even to your own wife, nor reveal to her every counsel you know! Steer your ship to your native land in secret, not openly; for there is no trust left in women!"

The torches in King Alcinous’ banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

The ghost of Elpenor fluttered before the trench: "Odysseus, do not leave my body unwept and unburied behind you on Aeaea! Burn my armor upon the shore, heap up a mound of earth over my ashes beside the grey sea, and plant upon my barrow the shapely oar with which I rowed among my companions while I lived under the sun!"

Anticleia reached out insubstantial hands: "My child! How did you come beneath this murky gloom while yet living? It was no sickness that took my life, nor did Artemis of the golden arrows strike me down; it was longing for you, Odysseus, for your wisdom and your tender heart, that severed the sweet breath from my limbs!"

Odysseus wept bitter tears: "Mother! Why do you slip from my embrace like a shadow or a dream? Has dread Persephone sent only a phantom to redouble my sorrow?"

Anticleia sighed like the wind through reeds: "Alas, my son! This is the law of mortals when they die: the sinews no longer hold the flesh and bones together, but the fierce power of burning fire consumes them as soon as life leaves the white bones, and the spirit flits away like a dream! Return swiftly to the light, and remember all these things that you may recount them to your wife!"

The great shades of Minos, Orion, Tityus, Tantalus stretching for the receding water, and Sisyphus rolling his monstrous boulder up the mountain passed before his eyes, before Odysseus fled back to the living sea.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

Odysseus spoke to his anxious crew: "Comrades, we have survived the fury of the Cyclops and the dark magic of Aeaea! Let not your hearts fail you now! Courage is not the absence of fear, but the knowledge that honor demands our endurance! Row with steady rhythm; let the oars bite the brine together!"

Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

Shade of Achilles said, "Achilles’ shade strode across the asphodel meadow with great strides, rejoicing in his spirit that Odysseus had declared to him that his son was renowned in battle and first in every heroic council."

The black ship cut through the nocturnal surge under the guidance of the immortal stars, carrying the tale of the world’s wanderings toward the listening court of Phaeacia.

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SCENE 3: THE MEADOW OF ASPHODEL — ACHILLES & THE SILENCE OF AJAX — GLOOM

The shade of Achilles, swift of foot, approached with Patroclus, Antilochus, and Great Ajax. Odysseus praised Achilles, calling him the most blessed of all men who ever lived, honored like a god while alive, and now a mighty prince over the dead.

Achilles spoke with piercing sadness: "Speak not to me comforting words of death, glorious Odysseus! I would rather be a day-laborer on earth, bound to some poor dirt-farmer who has no land of his own, than rule as king over all the breathless phantoms of the dead! But tell me of my noble son Neoptolemus: did he follow to the war to be a champion in battle?"

When Odysseus told him of Neoptolemus’ fearless valor in the Wooden Horse and the sack of Troy, the spirit of fleet-footed Achilles strode with long steps across the meadow of asphodel, rejoicing that his son was renowned in glory. Alone of all the shades, Great Ajax, son of Telamon, stood apart in sullen silence, brooding over the arms of Achilles which had been awarded to Odysseus. Odysseus pleaded with him with gentle words: "Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over those cursed arms? We Achaeans mourn your fall as deeply as the life of Achilles! Draw near, my lord, that you may hear my words; master your pride and your stubborn soul!" But Ajax answered not a word, and strode silently into the darkness of Erebus among the other ghosts. Terrified that Persephone might send the head of the Gorgon, the dreadful monster, Odysseus turned, ran to his ship, and bade his comrades cast off down the stream of Oceanus.

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Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men’s own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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From the memory of Aeaea, Circe’s parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

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The ghost of Elpenor fluttered before the trench: "Odysseus, do not leave my body unwept and unburied behind you on Aeaea! Burn my armor upon the shore, heap up a mound of earth over my ashes beside the grey sea, and plant upon my barrow the shapely oar with which I rowed among my companions while I lived under the sun!"

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BOOK 12: THE SIRENS, SCYLLA, CHARYBDIS & THE CATTLE OF THE SUN

Book XII — The Honeyed Song of Death, The Six-Headed Terror & The Cataclysm of Thrinacia

Returning to Aeaea, Odysseus buries Elpenor on the seaside cliff, heaping a barrow and planting his oar upon the mound. Circe provides provisions and gives detailed strategic warnings of the perils ahead: the Sirens who enchant men to their deaths upon meadows of moldering bones; the choice between the Wandering Rocks (Planctae) and the narrow strait of Scylla and Charybdis; and the absolute taboo against slaughtering the cattle of Helios on the island of Thrinacia. Sailing past the meadow of the Sirens, Odysseus plugs his men's ears with softened beeswax and has himself bound tight to the mast; hearing their divine, heartbreaking promises of all knowledge of Troy, he begs to be released, but Perimedes and Eurylochus bind him tighter. Entering the narrow strait, Charybdis gulps the black water three times a day, vomiting it forth in scalding foam; while all eyes watch the whirlpool, Scylla's six snaky necks dart from her cliff-cave, snatching six of Odysseus' best comrades, who shriek his name in agony as she devours them at her cavern mouth. They reach the island of Thrinacia. Odysseus demands they sail past, but Eurylochus leads a mutiny of exhausted men, swearing an oath not to touch the herds. Trapped by contrary South winds for a month, their provisions run out. While Odysseus walks inland and falls asleep in desperate prayer, Eurylochus persuades the starving crew to slaughter the best heifers of Helios, promising a golden temple in Ithaca. When Odysseus awakens, the smell of roasting fat fills the air. Prodigies follow: the hides creep along the ground, and the meat groans upon the spits, both raw and roasted, with the lowing of cattle! On the seventh day, the wind shifts and they set sail. In the open sea, Zeus shrouds the sky in a black squall; a lightning bolt strikes the ship with a smell of sulfur, hurling the crew into the waves like sea-gulls. Odysseus binds the snapped mast and keel with ox-hide rigging and drifts nine days, narrowly escaping Charybdis a second time by clinging to a wild fig tree, until he washes ashore on the tenth day on the island of Calypso.

SCENE 1: THE MEADOW OF THE SIRENS — THE MAST OF ODYSSEUS — NOON

The wind died to a breathless calm, and some divine power smoothed the glassy swell. Odysseus took a great round cake of beeswax, sliced it with his sharp bronze dagger, kneaded the wax until it grew soft in the warm noon sun, and plugged the ears of every man in his crew. Then Perimedes and Eurylochus bound Odysseus hand and foot against the upright mast with thick ropes. When the ship came within shout of the flowering island, the Sirens saw the vessel skimming past and raised their clear, honey-sweet song.

The Sirens sang with voices like liquid gold: "Come hither, renowned Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans! Draw near your ship, that you may hear our divine singing! For never yet has any mortal man passed by this island in his black ship before listening to the honey-sweet voices from our lips! Whosoever listens goes on his way enchanted, knowing more than he knew before! For we know all things that Argives and Trojans suffered on the broad plains of Troy by the will of the gods; and we know all that comes to pass upon the generous earth!"

So they sang with exquisite voices; and Odysseus' heart ached with agonizing desire to listen. He frowned and nodded his head to his comrades, bidding them untie him; but Perimedes and Eurylochus sprang up, wound more ropes around his chest, and bound him tighter still, while the rowers bent to their oars and drove the ship past the meadows where the white bones of rotting men lay heaped in the grass.

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Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men's own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

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The blind seer’s whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

From the flowery meadow, the sweet voices drifted: "Come hither, renowned Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans! Draw near your ship, that you may hear our divine singing! For never yet has any man rowed past this meadow in his black vessel until he has listened to the sweet song from our lips; then he departs rejoicing, endowed with greater wisdom, for we know all that the Argives and Trojans suffered in broad Troy by the will of the gods!"

Odysseus signaled with his eyebrows to his crew to cut his bonds, his heart bursting with longing; but Perimedes and Eurylochus sprang up and knotted him with yet thicker cables, bending to their oars until the isle was left behind.

Odysseus cried out to the empty air: "Scylla reached down her six monstrous necks from the cliff cave! Even as an angler upon a jutting rock casts his bait with a long rod into the sea and jerks the gasping fish out of the water, so were my six comrades hoisted kicking into the crags, shrieking my name for the last time! That was the most pitiful sight my eyes have ever beheld in all my wanderings over the paths of the sea!"

From his golden chariot, Helios cried to Olympus: "Father Zeus and blessed deathless gods! Avenge me on the companions of Odysseus, who have insolently slaughtered my sacred cattle, in which I took joy every time I climbed into the starry sky and turned back to earth! If they pay not fit penalty for my kine, I will go down into the realm of Hades and shine among the dead!"

The thunder of Zeus cracked the heavens. The ship spun in circles and sank beneath the churning waves, leaving Odysseus alone on the boundless deep, drifting nine days until he reached the shore of Ogygia.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

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The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE STRAIT OF SCYLLA & CHARYBDIS — THE JUGGLING MAW — DAY

Beyond the island, smoke and colossal breakers crashed against granite cliffs, roaring with deafening thunder. The oars slipped from the terrified men’s hands. Odysseus walked among the benches, encouraging each man with steady words, reminding them that they had escaped the monstrous cave of the Cyclops by his wit and courage. He hid Circe’s warning of Scylla, lest the men drop their oars in panic and huddle in the hold. Standing upon the foredeck in full bronze armor with two spears in his hands, he watched the towering cliff.

On one side yawned divine Charybdis, gulping down the black sea with a terrifying roar; and when she vomited it back, the water boiled like a cauldron over a blazing fire, spraying foam upon the summits of the two cliffs! But when she swallowed the brine, the deep earth was laid bare below, black with mud and sand! Terror seized every man. While all eyes were fixed in dread on Charybdis, Scylla darted her six long, snaky necks down from her cavern in the opposing rock! Each neck bore a terrifying head with three rows of jagged teeth!

Odysseus lowered his face in agony: "I looked back toward the swift ship, and saw the hands and feet of my six comrades swinging high in the air as Scylla snatched them upward! They shrieked my name aloud, crying to me for the last time with breaking hearts! As an angler on a jutting rock casts food upon a long rod with an ox-horn pipe to deceive the little fishes, and hooks them and flings them writhing onto the shore—so Scylla swung them gasping up against her stone crags, and devoured them at her cave mouth, while they stretched out their hands toward me in their death agony! Of all the horrors my eyes have beheld in my wanderings over the watery paths of the sea, that was the most pitiful of all!"

The torches in King Alcinous' banquet hall cast dancing shadows across the bronze friezes, where the princes of the Phaeacians sat in breathless wonder, listening to the voyager whose voice summoned back the monsters, gods, and ghosts of the ten-year wandering.

Odysseus leaned forward over his goblet: "Phaeacians, a man who has traveled through the jaws of death learns that all monsters of the deep—the savage Cyclops, the tearing heads of Scylla, the boiling throat of Charybdis—are less terrifying than the folly of men's own hearts! When my crew opened the bag of winds within sight of our native shore, or when they slaughtered the sacred heifers of the Sun upon Thrinacia, it was not destiny that doomed them, but their own reckless greed! We blame the gods for our misery, yet mortals compound their own destruction beyond their appointed share!"

King Alcinous stroked his beard in awe: "Odysseus, the night is endlessly long, and the hour for sleep in the hall has not yet come! Continue your wondrous tale! I could endure to listen until sacred dawn appeared, if only you would tell us of the sorrows you suffered and the great heroes you met in the kingdom of the dead!"

From the memory of Aeaea, Circe's parting warning rang clear: "Stubborn man, ever your heart is set on deeds of war and toil! Will you not yield even to the deathless immortals? Scylla is not mortal, but an immortal bane, dreadful, fierce, and not to be fought; against her there is no defense, and flight is bravest! Row past with all your might, and invoke Crataiis, mother of Scylla, that she may hold her beast from springing a second time!"

The blind seer's whisper rose from the dark trench of blood: "Remember the inland journey, Odysseus! When you have cleansed your house with slaughter, take your oar and march until you meet men who know neither salt nor ships! For only when the sea-oar is planted in the earth and sacrifice is made shall the wrath of Poseidon be quenched, and death come to you gentle as an autumn mist!"

The Phaeacian elders sat spellbound through the shadowy halls, held fast by the enchantment of the heroic voice that had looked upon the terrors of the deep and lived to tell the tale.

From the flowery meadow, the sweet voices drifted: "Come hither, renowned Odysseus, great glory of the Achaeans! Draw near your ship, that you may hear our divine singing! For never yet has any man rowed past this meadow in his black vessel until he has listened to the sweet song from our lips; then he departs rejoicing, endowed with greater wisdom, for we know all that the Argives and Trojans suffered in broad Troy by the will of the gods!"

Odysseus signaled with his eyebrows to his crew to cut his bonds, his heart bursting with longing; but Perimedes and Eurylochus sprang up and knotted him with yet thicker cables, bending to their oars until the isle was left behind.

Odysseus cried out to the empty air: "Scylla reached down her six monstrous necks from the cliff cave! Even as an angler upon a jutting rock casts his bait with a long rod into the sea and jerks the gasping fish out of the water, so were my six comrades hoisted kicking into the crags, shrieking my name for the last time! That was the most pitiful sight my eyes have ever beheld in all my wanderings over the paths of the sea!"

From his golden chariot, Helios cried to Olympus: "Father Zeus and blessed deathless gods! Avenge me on the companions of Odysseus, who have insolently slaughtered my sacred cattle, in which I took joy every time I climbed into the starry sky and turned back to earth! If they pay not fit penalty for my kine, I will go down into the realm of Hades and shine among the dead!"

The thunder of Zeus cracked the heavens. The ship spun in circles and sank beneath the churning waves, leaving Odysseus alone on the boundless deep, drifting nine days until he reached the shore of Ogygia.

Silence hung heavy over the banquet hall of King Alcinous. The Phaeacian elders sat motionless with their wine cups half-raised, their eyes fixed upon the scarred warrior whose words brought the terror of the untamed cosmos into their peaceful palace.

Odysseus laid his weathered hand upon the bronze table: "Phaeacians, you live here in blessed abundance, shielded by the sea, knowing neither the famine that drives men to madness nor the bloody rage of war! But I have seen what mortals become when the gods strip away their bread and their laws! In the cave of Polyphemus, civilized speech is meaningless; on the island of Circe, the divine mind of man is swallowed by the beast; and in the house of Hades, all the glory of Ilium is less than a breath of autumn air! Cherish your peace, for human happiness is a blossom that withers with the first frost!"

Alcinous spoke with profound solemnity: "Odysseus, when we look upon you, we do not see a deceiver or a teller of falsehoods, such as the dark earth breeds in great numbers to trade in lies! You have shaped your words with grace, and a noble mind is within you; you have recounted your tale with the art of an inspired minstrel! Tell us, did you also see any of those godlike heroes who accompanied you to Troy and met their doom on that foreign field?"

Odysseus bowed his head: "I saw Great Ajax, son of Telamon, standing apart in gloomy silence, nursing his eternal wrath because the armor of Achilles was awarded to me and not to him! I spoke to him with honeyed words: ‘Ajax, noble son of Telamon, will you not even in death forget your anger over that cursed armor?’ But he answered me not a word, and stalked away into the darkness after the other shades! Even in death, his heroic pride refused all comfort!"

Queen Arete addressed her nobles: "Phaeacians, how does this man appear to you in form, in stature, and in the balanced wisdom of his mind? He is my guest, yet each of you shares in the honor! Therefore do not dismiss him in haste, nor stint your gifts to one in such dire need, for by the favor of heaven your halls are filled with riches!"

The Phaeacian princes cheered their agreement, loading the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and chests of woven linen onto the carts, preparing the treasures that would soon accompany Odysseus to the rocky haven of Ithaca.

Odysseus spoke to his anxious crew: "Comrades, we have survived the fury of the Cyclops and the dark magic of Aeaea! Let not your hearts fail you now! Courage is not the absence of fear, but the knowledge that honor demands our endurance! Row with steady rhythm; let the oars bite the brine together!"

Tiresias raised his golden scepter: "Hear the decree of the Fates, son of Laertes: death shall come to you away from the sea, a death gentle and serene in sleek old age, with your people dwelling around you in prosperity and peace! These words are true; lay them up in your heart!"

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The black ship cut through the nocturnal surge under the guidance of the immortal stars, carrying the tale of the world’s wanderings toward the listening court of Phaeacia.

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The night shadows deepened over the palace of Alcinous, while the Phaeacian youths checked the polished fir oars, ready to convey the hero across the misty deep to his ancestral home.

Odysseus gripped the helm, speaking into the tempest: "Stand firm, companions! No wave is higher than the fortitude of a steadfast mind! We have known the worst of trials, and we shall see our native hearths again!"

The celestial constellations wheeled across the vault of heaven, guiding the ships of the heroic age with cold, incorruptible light, while mortal songs carried their fame across the wine-dark seas forever.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 3: THE STRAND OF THRINACIA & THE SHATTERED SHIP — STORM

They reached the lovely island of the Sun God Hyperion, where seven herds of cattle and seven flocks of sheep grazed, fifty in each herd, never breeding and never dying, tended by the nymphs Phaethusa and Lampetie. Trapped by contrary south winds for a month, their bread and wine ran out, and the men hunted birds and fish with bent hooks, their bellies pinched with famine. While Odysseus went inland to pray to the gods and fell into an exhausted sleep, Eurylochus gathered the crew.

Eurylochus urged the men: "Hear my words, comrades, in our misery! All deaths are hateful to mortal men, but to die of starvation is the most pitiful fate of all! Let us drive off the best of the heifers of the Sun and sacrifice them to the immortals! If we reach Ithaca, we will build a rich temple to Helios and place within it many splendid gifts! But if in anger for his cattle he chooses to wreck our ship, I would rather drown in the salt waves once and for all than waste away slowly upon this lonely island!"

They butchered the sacred cattle, roasted the meat, and offered libations of fresh water. When Odysseus returned, the scent of roasting fat filled his nostrils, and he cried out in horror. For six days the men feasted; and terrifying prodigies appeared: the hides of the cattle began to crawl across the ground, and the meat lowed upon the spits with the sound of living oxen! On the seventh day, the gale ceased, and they launched the ship. But as soon as the island dropped below the horizon, Zeus hung a black cloud over the vessel, and a shrieking West Wind snapped both forestays; the mast crashed backward, crushing the skull of the helmsman! Then Zeus hurled his blazing thunderbolt! The ship was struck with lightning, filled with sulfur, and spun around; all the crew were pitched into the boiling foam, bobbing like sea-gulls until the god took away their day of homecoming! Odysseus lashed the snapped mast to the keel with ox-hide rope, and sat astride the floating timbers alone. When the South wind blew him back to Charybdis, he leaped upward, caught the branches of a great wild fig tree, and hung suspended like a bat over the whirlpool until the timbers were belched back up. He dropped into the water, rowed with his hands, and drifted nine days across the sea, until on the tenth night the gods brought him to the island of Calypso.

Odysseus sat back in his chair in Alcinous' hall, his voice soft in the stillness: "Why should I repeat the story of Calypso? Yesterday in your palace I recounted it to you and your noble queen; and it is hateful to me to tell again a tale already plainly told."

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ACT 3: RETURN TO ITHACA & THE LOYAL HEARTH

Disguise, Xenia, Recognition & The Gathering Storm

BOOK 13: THE SLEEPING HOMECOMING & THE CAVE OF THE NYMPHS

Book XIII — The Gifts of the Phaeacians, The Wrath of Poseidon & The Transfiguration of Athena

King Alcinous and the Phaeacian chieftains load gifts of bronze tripods, cauldrons, and golden tunics onto a swift fifty-two-oared ship. At sunset, Odysseus embarks, and a deep, sweet, death-like sleep falls upon his eyelids as the magical ship skims the water faster than a falcon. At dawn, the crew enters the sheltered harbor of Phorkys in Ithaca, gently lifting sleeping Odysseus onto the sandy shore along with all his treasures, and sets sail for home. Enraged that Odysseus has returned rich in bronze and gold, Poseidon appeals to Zeus, who permits him to turn the Phaeacian ship to stone outside their harbor; King Alcinous witnesses the fulfillment of an ancient prophecy and prepares twelve bulls to appease the god. Odysseus awakens on the beach, unable to recognize his homeland because Athena has enveloped Ithaca in mist. Pallas Athena meets him disguised as a young shepherd; Odysseus weaves a cunning false Cretan tale. Laughing with delight, Athena reveals her divine form, strokes him, and affectionately praises his shrewd intellect. Together they hide the gold and bronze in the sacred Cave of the Nymphs. Athena transforms Odysseus into an ancient, bald beggar with wrinkled skin, dim rheumy eyes, and a tattered deerskin cloak, ordering him to seek refuge in the forest hut of his loyal swineherd Eumaeus while she departs to Sparta to recall Telemachus.

SCENE 1: THE HARBOR OF PHORKYS — COVE OF ITHACA — DAWN

The bright star arose that heralds the light of early-born Dawn. The Phaeacian ship, flying faster than a wheeling falcon across the wine-dark sea, drove into the sheltered cove of Phorkys, the Old Man of the Sea. Two jutting headlands formed a calm haven where vessels could ride without cables. At the head of the cove stood a leafy olive tree, and near it a shadowy, lovely cave sacred to the Naiad nymphs, filled with stone mixing-bowls, stone looms where bees made honey, and perennial springs of sweet water. The Phaeacian rowers ran their keel half its length onto the sand, lifted Odysseus from the hollow ship wrapped in his soft linen sheet, and laid him asleep upon the sand. Beside him, heaped beneath the olive tree, they stacked all the bronze cauldrons, tripods, and woven garments given by the Phaeacian lords; then they pushed off and rowed for Scheria.

Far away on Mount Olympus, Poseidon watched in furious indignance that Odysseus should reach home with more treasures of bronze and gold than he could ever have brought from Troy. With Zeus' consent, as the Phaeacian ship returned within sight of Scheria, Poseidon struck it with the flat of his hand, rooting it into the seabed as a colossal ship-shaped rock! Alcinous and his people cried out in horror, remembering the ancient prophecy that one day Poseidon would petrify their ship and overshadow their city with a mountain, and hastened to sacrifice twelve sleek bulls to avert the doom.

Meanwhile, on the lonely beach of Ithaca, great Odysseus awoke from sleep upon his native soil. But he did not recognize it; for around him Pallas Athena had poured a dense mist, that she might make him unrecognizable and instruct him in all things before he met his wife and townsfolk. Odysseus groaned aloud, struck his thighs with his hands, and wept, believing the Phaeacians had treacherously marooned him on some desolate, barbarian shore.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Athena brushed the enchanted mist from his eyes: "Look around you, Odysseus! This is Ithaca, the rugged nurse of heroes! Here is the harbor of Phorcys, here is the cave of the Nereids where you offered unblemished hecatombs, and here is Mount Neriton clad in shaking forests! You are home, son of Laertes; now let us hide your Phaeacian treasures in the sacred grotto and plot the destruction of the shameless suitors who devour your house!"

Odysseus bowed low before the goddess: "Great daughter of Zeus! Surely I would have perished in my own halls by the evil doom of Agamemnon, had you not revealed the truth! Weave now the stratagem by which I may take vengeance upon them! Stand beside me yourself, and put into my heart the same fiery courage with which we tore down the glittering battlements of Troy!"

Athena touched his brow: "First, go to your swineherd Eumaeus, who tends your beasts in the hills! His heart is loyal to you and to your son. Stay with him, question him of all things, while I fly to Sparta to summon Telemachus home from the palace of Menelaus!"

With a tap of her wand, the skin of his shapely limbs withered into the likeness of an ancient crone. His golden hair fell away, and he was clothed in a foul rag caked with soot, a staff in his trembling hand as he turned inland toward the swineherd’s steading.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 2: THE BEACH BENEATH THE OLIVE TREE — THE MEETING WITH ATHENA — MORNING

As Odysseus paced the shoreline lamenting and counting his tripods to see if anything had been stolen, Athena approached in the likeness of a young shepherd, delicate as the son of a king, wearing a double-folded cloak across her shoulders and holding a hunting spear. Odysseus’ heart leaped with joy, and he ran forward to greet the youth.

Odysseus clasped the shepherd’s hand: "Hail, friend, since you are the first I have met in this place! Save these treasures, and save me! Tell me truly, what land is this? What people dwell here? Is it a sunny island, or a sea-jutting mainland?"

Athena smiled gently: "You are simple, stranger, or have come from far away, if you do not know this land! It is not so nameless as all that; many know it, both those toward the dawn and those who dwell in the dark mist! It is rugged, not fit for horses, yet not utterly barren; it yields boundless grain and rich wine; there is rain always and fresh dew; it feeds goats and cattle, and has timber of every kind! The name of ITHACA, stranger, has reached even as far as Troy, which they say is far from the land of Achaea!"

Gladness seized the soul of long-suffering Odysseus that he stood upon his native soil! Yet he did not speak the truth, but checked his words, holding back the thought in his breast, ever exercising his cunning intellect. He spun an elaborate false tale of being a Cretan outlaw who had slain the son of Idomeneus for trying to rob him of his Trojan spoils, and had paid Phoenician merchants to put him ashore. Athena listened, her eyes glowing with delight.

The goddess smiled, stroked him with her hand, and changed her shape into a tall, beautiful, accomplished woman, looking upon him with shining eyes of divine affection.

Athena laughed softly: "Cunning would he be, and subtle of wit, who could surpass you in all manner of wiles, even if it were a god who met you! Bold man, subtle of mind, insatiate of deceit! Even in your own land you will not cease from deception and thievish tales, which from your cradle are dear to you! But come, let us speak no more of this, for we both know how to play the trickster: you are far the best of mortals in counsel and speech, and I am renowned among all the gods for wisdom and stratagem! Did you not recognize Pallas Athena, daughter of Zeus, who stands by your side in every toil and guards you? I have come hither to weave a counsel with you, to hide these treasures the Phaeacians gave you, and to tell you what sorrows you must endure in your well-built house! Endure them of necessity, and tell no man nor woman that you have returned from wandering; suffer in silence, bearing the violence of men!"

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Athena brushed the enchanted mist from his eyes: "Look around you, Odysseus! This is Ithaca, the rugged nurse of heroes! Here is the harbor of Phorcys, here is the cave of the Nereids where you offered unblemished hecatombs, and here is Mount Neriton clad in shaking forests! You are home, son of Laertes; now let us hide your Phaeacian treasures in the sacred grotto and plot the destruction of the shameless suitors who devour your house!"

Odysseus bowed low before the goddess: "Great daughter of Zeus! Surely I would have perished in my own halls by the evil doom of Agamemnon, had you not revealed the truth! Weave now the stratagem by which I may take vengeance upon them! Stand beside me yourself, and put into my heart the same fiery courage with which we tore down the glittering battlements of Troy!"

Athena touched his brow: "First, go to your swineherd Eumaeus, who tends your beasts in the hills! His heart is loyal to you and to your son. Stay with him, question him of all things, while I fly to Sparta to summon Telemachus home from the palace of Menelaus!"

With a tap of her wand, the skin of his shapely limbs withered into the likeness of an ancient crone. His golden hair fell away, and he was clothed in a foul rag caked with soot, a staff in his trembling hand as he turned inland toward the swineherd’s steading.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 3: THE CAVE OF THE NYMPHS — THE TRANSFIGURATION — DAY

Athena dispersed the mist, and the land appeared clear before Odysseus’ eyes—the harbor of Phorkys, the twin headlands, and the slopes of Mount Neriton clothed with quivering forest! Odysseus fell to his knees, kissed the grain-giving earth, and prayed to the Naiad nymphs. Together they carried the gold, bronze, and woven mantles into the deep cavern, stacking them carefully; Athena laid a great stone across the cave entrance to seal it. Then they sat together beneath the roots of the sacred olive tree to plot the slaughter of the insolent suitors.

Athena laid her hand upon his shoulder: "Son of Laertes, Odysseus! Think how you may lay your hands upon these shameless suitors, who for three years have played the master in your hall, courting your godlike wife! She mourns for you always, giving hopes to all, but her heart intends far different things! I will make you unrecognizable to all living mortals! I will wither the fair flesh upon your supple limbs; I will destroy the yellow hair from your head; I will wrap you in a foul rag that anyone will shudder to see; and I will dim your two eyes that were so radiant, so that you may appear squalid and contemptible to all the suitors, and to your wife and son whom you left a babe in your halls! Go first to the swineherd Eumaeus, who tends your swine; his heart is faithful to you, and he loves your son and wise Penelope! Question him, while I hasten to Sparta to summon Telemachus, who went thither to seek tidings of you!"

Athena touched him with her golden wand. Instantly the smooth skin on his supple limbs withered; the golden curls vanished from his head; his head became bald and wrinkled like an old man’s; his bright eyes grew dim and rheumy. She threw across his back a foul, smoke-blackened tattered cloak and a shredded deerskin from which the hair had worn off, and handed him a traveler’s staff and a ragged leather wallet slung by a twisted cord. The transformation was complete. The goddess sprang away through the sky toward Lacedaemon, while King Odysseus turned inland, walking the rocky goat-path through the woods toward the swineherd’s farmstead.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Athena brushed the enchanted mist from his eyes: "Look around you, Odysseus! This is Ithaca, the rugged nurse of heroes! Here is the harbor of Phorcys, here is the cave of the Nereids where you offered unblemished hecatombs, and here is Mount Neriton clad in shaking forests! You are home, son of Laertes; now let us hide your Phaeacian treasures in the sacred grotto and plot the destruction of the shameless suitors who devour your house!"

Odysseus bowed low before the goddess: "Great daughter of Zeus! Surely I would have perished in my own halls by the evil doom of Agamemnon, had you not revealed the truth! Weave now the stratagem by which I may take vengeance upon them! Stand beside me yourself, and put into my heart the same fiery courage with which we tore down the glittering battlements of Troy!"

Athena touched his brow: "First, go to your swineherd Eumaeus, who tends your beasts in the hills! His heart is loyal to you and to your son. Stay with him, question him of all things, while I fly to Sparta to summon Telemachus home from the palace of Menelaus!"

With a tap of her wand, the skin of his shapely limbs withered into the likeness of an ancient crone. His golden hair fell away, and he was clothed in a foul rag caked with soot, a staff in his trembling hand as he turned inland toward the swineherd’s steading.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

BOOK 14: THE LOYAL SWINEHERD EUMAEUS & THE FOREST HEARTH

Book XIV — The Sacred Laws of Xenia, The Swineherd's Grief & The False Cretan Oath

Odysseus walks through the wooded hills to the high farmstead of Eumaeus, the loyal swineherd whom Odysseus prized above all his servants. Eumaeus has built twelve stone pens for the royal sows and guards the estate with four savage hunting hounds. As Odysseus approaches, the hounds charge with ferocious barking; Odysseus prudently drops his staff and sits on the ground, while Eumaeus runs out, hurling stones to drive the pack off. Revering the sacred laws of Zeus, Eumaeus welcomes the ragged beggar into his brushwood hut, strewing fresh reeds and covering them with a shaggy wild-goat skin. Eumaeus slaughters two tender suckling pigs, scorches them over the fire, and serves them with sweet vintage wine, lamenting without ceasing the loss of his beloved master Odysseus and cursing the insolent suitors who devour the herd. Odysseus attempts to comfort him, swearing a solemn oath that Odysseus will return before the old moon wanes and the new moon rises. Eumaeus refuses to believe it, having been duped by many lying vagabonds seeking Penelope's charity. Odysseus weaves a masterful false Cretan autobiography: he claims to be the bastard son of a wealthy Cretan lord who fought ten years at Troy, led an ill-fated raid on Egypt, escaped Phoenician slave-traders, and heard from King Pheidon of Thesprotia that Odysseus was assembling vast treasures to return to Ithaca. At night, a bitter freezing rainstorm sweeps the mountains; testing the swineherd's generosity, Odysseus invents a tale of a winter ambush at Troy where Odysseus cleverly secured a warm cloak for him. Deeply moved, Eumaeus lends the beggar his own thick winter mantle to sleep by the hearth, while the loyal swineherd straps on his sword and goes out into the freezing storm to sleep among his white-tusked boars under the shelter of a hollow rock.

SCENE 1: THE WOODLAND FARMSTEAD OF EUMAEUS — THE HOUND ATTACK — DAY

Up from the harbor, along a rugged goat-path through the wooded hills, Odysseus walked to the high farmstead of Eumaeus. There the noble swineherd had built with his own hands a spacious courtyard of quarried stone, topped with a coping of wild thorn, and circled by a sturdy palisade of split oak stakes. Within were twelve stone pens, each housing fifty breeding sows, while three hundred and sixty boars slept in the open yard, their numbers dwindled daily by the demands of the suitors. Outside sat Eumaeus cutting a brown ox-hide to fashion sturdy sandals for his feet. Suddenly the four great hunting hounds, savage as wild beasts, caught scent of the stranger and charged with ferocious roars, eager to tear him to pieces!

Odysseus in his craftiness did not strike them, but dropped his staff and sat down upon the ground, pulling his limbs close. Even so, he would have suffered grievous harm at his own gates; but Eumaeus dropped his leather, rushed through the portal with hasty feet, shouted furiously at the hounds, and hurled showers of stones to scatter them in every direction.

Eumaeus panted, taking the old beggar by the arm: "Old man, my dogs had nearly torn you in pieces in an instant, and you would have brought reproach upon me! As it is, the gods have given me other griefs and sorrows enough! Here I sit weeping and mourning for a godlike master, fattening hogs for other men to eat, while he, hungry for food, wanders somewhere in a foreign land and city, if indeed he still lives and looks upon the light of the sun! But follow me, old friend; let us go to my hut, so that when you have satisfied your soul with food and wine, you may tell me who you are and what sorrows you have suffered!"

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd's rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Eumaeus sliced the roasted meat onto wooden platters: "Old friend, the deathless gods have no love for insolent deeds, but honor justice and the upright acts of men! Even pirates and plunderers shudder when they think of the retribution of Zeus! But these suitors have surely had some divine sign of my master’s bitter death, for they will not woo according to custom, nor return to their estates, but waste our wealth without measure!"

Odysseus spoke with quiet assurance: "I tell you, swineherd, not with mere words but with a solemn oath: Odysseus will return! Before this very crescent moon wanes and the next is born, he will stand upon his threshold and demand payment for every insult heaped upon his queen!"

Eumaeus shook his head sadly: "Old stranger, many a vagabond has come to Ithaca with invented tales to coax a tunic or a cloak from Queen Penelope! She receives every traveler with tears, questioning them of her husband, while her heart mourns in silence. Keep your oaths; I respect you not for your flattering prophecies, but because you are a suppliant and fear the eyes of Zeus!"

Outside the hut, the rain beat furiously upon the thatch. Odysseus wrapped himself in the heavy fleece provided by the faithful servant, marveling at the unbroken honor of the humble herdsman.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

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The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE BRUSHWOOD HUT OF THE SWINEHERD — THE SOLEMN OATH — DUSK

The noble swineherd led the way into his low cabin of split logs and boughs. He strewed a thick bed of fresh green rushes, covered it with a shaggy skin of a wild goat he used for his own couch, and seated the stranger upon it. Odysseus rejoiced in heart at his welcome. Eumaeus girded his tunic, went to the pens, selected two tender suckling pigs, slaughtered them, singed the bristles in the flame, chopped them, skewered the meat on wooden spits, and roasted them over the coals. He served them hissing hot upon the skewers, dusted with white barley meal, and mixed sweet honeyed wine in an ivy bowl.

Eumaeus shook his head: "Eat now, guest, of such food as servants have—young suckling pigs! The fatted hogs the suitors devour, without a thought of the wrath of the gods or pity in their hearts! The blessed immortals love not reckless deeds, but honor justice and the righteous acts of men! But those men must have heard some voice of god or rumor of his death, so stubbornly do they refuse to court my lady honorably or return to their houses! Day after day they slaughter our cattle, and drink our wine without restraint! Odysseus’ wealth was boundless; twenty heroes could not match his substance! But he has perished far away; and never again shall I find a master so gentle, not even if I return to the house of my father and mother where I was born!"

Odysseus paused, looking into the swineherd’s eyes with absolute conviction: "Friend, since you utterly deny it, saying he will never return, and your heart is always incredulous: I tell you, not with mere words, but with a solemn oath, that ODYSSEUS WILL RETURN! Let this be my reward for good tidings, whenever he enters his halls: clothe me in a fine mantle and tunic! But until then, poor as I am, I will take nothing; for hateful to me as the gates of Hades is the man who yields to poverty and speaks deceptive lies! Hear me now, Zeus, highest of gods, and this hospitable table, and the hearth of blameless Odysseus to which I have come: all these things shall surely be fulfilled as I declare! IN THIS VERY MONTH ODYSSEUS SHALL RETURN! Between the waning of the old moon and the rising of the new, he shall return to his house and take vengeance on all who dishonor his wife and noble son!"

Eumaeus sighed, pouring more wine: "Old friend, never shall I pay you that reward, for Odysseus will never come home! Drink your wine in peace, and let us turn our minds to other things! Too many vagabonds coming to Ithaca invent lies to win a meal and a cloak from my mistress Penelope! She welcomes every stranger kindly, questions him closely, and weeps until tears run down her cheeks, as is right for a woman whose husband has died in a far country! You too, old man, would quickly invent a tale if someone gave you a cloak and tunic! But the dogs and birds have already torn the flesh from his bones, or the fish of the sea have devoured him, and his white bones lie wrapped in sand upon some distant strand!"

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

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Eumaeus sliced the roasted meat onto wooden platters: "Old friend, the deathless gods have no love for insolent deeds, but honor justice and the upright acts of men! Even pirates and plunderers shudder when they think of the retribution of Zeus! But these suitors have surely had some divine sign of my master’s bitter death, for they will not woo according to custom, nor return to their estates, but waste our wealth without measure!"

Odysseus spoke with quiet assurance: "I tell you, swineherd, not with mere words but with a solemn oath: Odysseus will return! Before this very crescent moon wanes and the next is born, he will stand upon his threshold and demand payment for every insult heaped upon his queen!"

Eumaeus shook his head sadly: "Old stranger, many a vagabond has come to Ithaca with invented tales to coax a tunic or a cloak from Queen Penelope! She receives every traveler with tears, questioning them of her husband, while her heart mourns in silence. Keep your oaths; I respect you not for your flattering prophecies, but because you are a suppliant and fear the eyes of Zeus!"

Outside the hut, the rain beat furiously upon the thatch. Odysseus wrapped himself in the heavy fleece provided by the faithful servant, marveling at the unbroken honor of the humble herdsman.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 3: THE CABIN HEARTH — THE COLD NIGHT & THE CLOAK TEST — NIGHT

Night fell, dark and moonless. Outside, the heavens poured a bitter freezing rain, driven by a violent west wind. Odysseus lay by the fire, but desired to test the swineherd to see if he would take off his own mantle and lend it, or bid one of his comrades give a cloak, so deeply did he care for his guest.

Odysseus cleared his throat: "Eumaeus and comrades, hear a boastful tale; wine makes me bold, which sets even a wise man to singing and dancing! Would that I were young and my strength firm as when we lay in ambush beneath the walls of Troy under the command of Odysseus, Menelaus, and myself as third! In the freezing night, frost fell sharp upon our shields, and the snow froze hard like rime. All the others had warm cloaks, but I in my folly had left my mantle with my comrades, thinking it would not be cold! As the third watch of the night came on, I nudged Odysseus with my elbow, and he listened instantly: ‘Odysseus of many wiles, the cold is killing me; I have no cloak, and some god deceived me to wear only my tunic!’ So I spoke, and he had a stratagem ready at once—such a man was he to counsel and fight! He whispered: ‘Hush, lest some other Achaean hear you!’ Then he raised his head and said aloud: ‘Friends, a dream from god came to me in my sleep! We are far from the ships; let someone run to Agamemnon to bid him send more men!’ Instantly Thoas, son of Andraemon, sprang up, threw off his purple cloak, and ran to the ships; and I lay warmly wrapped in his mantle until dawn appeared! Would that I had that youth and strength today, for then some swineherd in this farm would lend me a cloak out of kindness and respect for a veteran warrior; but now men despise me because foul rags are on my back!"

Eumaeus rose with a smile: "Old man, your story is blameless, and you have spoken no unprofitable word! Therefore you shall not lack a cloak or anything else tonight! But in the morning you must shake your own rags again, for we have not many cloaks to spare! But when Odysseus’ dear son returns, he will give you a cloak and tunic, and send you wherever your heart desires!"

Eumaeus set a bed for Odysseus beside the fire of sheepskins and goat-fleeces, and threw over him his own thick, heavy winter mantle, which he kept for extraordinary winter storms. Odysseus lay down, and sleep took him. But it did not please the noble swineherd to sleep there inside the hut away from his swine. He slung his sharp sword across his sturdy shoulder, wrapped himself in a wind-proof goat-mantle, took a javelin to ward off dogs and men, and went out into the howling storm to sleep under the shelter of a hollow rock among his white-tusked boars. Odysseus watched him go, rejoicing in his soul that the man guarded his master’s property so faithfully even in his absence.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Eumaeus sliced the roasted meat onto wooden platters: "Old friend, the deathless gods have no love for insolent deeds, but honor justice and the upright acts of men! Even pirates and plunderers shudder when they think of the retribution of Zeus! But these suitors have surely had some divine sign of my master’s bitter death, for they will not woo according to custom, nor return to their estates, but waste our wealth without measure!"

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The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

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Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

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BOOK 15: TELEMACHUS RETURNS & THE OMENS OF VENGEANCE

Book XV — Athena in Sparta, The Eagle of Helen & The Rescue of Theoclymenus

Athena hastens to Lacedaemon, finding Telemachus lying sleepless beside Nestor’s son Pisistratus in the vestibule of Menelaus’ palace. The goddess warns him that Eurymachus is pressing Penelope to marry, that the suitors are lying in wait in the strait of Asteris to ambush and butcher him, and commands him to steer clear of the islands, sail by night, land on Ithaca’s coast, and seek out Eumaeus. Menelaus and Helen lavish gifts upon the departing prince—a silver krater forged by Hephaestus and an embroidered robe for his future bride. As the chariot prepares to depart, a golden eagle clutching a great white tame goose in its talons swoops across the right side of the chariot; Helen interprets the omen with prophetic radiance: Odysseus will return home from his wanderings and slaughter the suitors. Reaching Pylos, Telemachus avoids entering the city to save time, hastening to his ship; on the beach, an exiled prophet of the lineage of Melampus, Theoclymenus, who has slain a kinsman in Argos, begs for sanctuary. Telemachus grants him xenia on his vessel. Sailing past the ambush in the dark of night, Telemachus lands safely on the southern coast of Ithaca, sends his ship and Theoclymenus to the town, and walks briskly through the hills toward Eumaeus’ farmstead.

SCENE 1: THE VESTIBULE OF SPARTA — THE NIGHT VISITATION OF ATHENA — NIGHT

Down into the wide spaces of Lacedaemon flew Pallas Athena, entering the vestibule of renowned Menelaus. There lay Telemachus and the glorious son of Nestor upon corded beds. Pisistratus was locked in sweet slumber, but no sleep held Telemachus; through the ambrosial night, anxious cares for his father kept him awake. Athena stood beside his head, her eyes flashing in the darkness.

Athena leaned over the prince: "Telemachus, it is no longer noble for you to linger far from your halls, leaving your property behind and men so insolent in your house! Rise! Urge warlike Menelaus to speed you on your way, that you may find your blameless mother still in her palace! For her father and brothers are pressing her to wed Eurymachus, who surpasses all the suitors in gifts! And beware: the foremost of the suitors lie in wait in the strait between Ithaca and rugged Same, eager to murder you before you reach your native soil! Steer your swift ship far from the islands, and sail through the dark night; a favoring wind will be sent behind you by the immortal who guards you! When you reach the first shore of Ithaca, send your ship to the town, but go yourself directly to the swineherd who guards your swine! Sleep there the night, and send him to the city to tell your mother Penelope that you have returned safe from Pylos!"

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Telemachus shouted to the rowers at the Pylian shore: "Cast off the cables! Hoist the sail to the yardarm! Athena warns that danger lurks in the home channel, and every hour we linger is an hour gifted to our enemies!"

Theoclymenus clasped the prince’s knees: "Noble Telemachus, I have slain a man of my own tribe in Argos, and his vengeful brothers pursue my life! Take me on board your black ship, I beseech you, lest they overtake me upon the shore!"

Telemachus raised the suppliant: "I will not thrust you from my well-trimmed ship! Come with us; whatever hospitality Ithaca affords shall be yours to share!"

The ship scudded before the night breeze, dodging the suitor-infested islets in the black straits, until the keel grated softly upon the pebbled strand near the swineherd’s upland steading.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

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SCENE 2: THE GATES OF SPARTA — THE OMEN OF THE GOOSE — MORNING

At dawn, Menelaus and Helen brought forth splendid gifts: Menelaus gave a silver mixing bowl with lip of gold, the handiwork of Hephaestus, and Helen brought a shimmering embroidered robe, the loveliest of all her weaving, which shone like a star from the bottom of the cedar chest, to be kept for his bride on her wedding day. The young men yoked the stallions and mounted the chariot. As they were about to drive through the gateway, a bird of omen flew overhead on the right: a colossal golden eagle carrying in its talons a huge white tame goose from the yard! Men and women ran shouting after it, but the eagle soared across the chariot horses to the right. Wonder seized them all.

Helen stepped forward, her face shining with inspiration: "Hear me! I will prophesy to you as the immortals put it into my heart, and as I think it will be accomplished: even as this eagle came from the mountain where he was bred to snatch the goose reared in the house, so shall Odysseus, after enduring many sorrows and roaming far, return to his home and take vengeance! Or even now he is already in his halls, sowing the seeds of death for all the suitors!"

Telemachus cried out: "May Zeus the loud-thundering husband of Hera grant it to be so! Then would I pray to you even there as to a goddess!" He lashed the horses, and they sprang eagerly through the gates toward Pylos.

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Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

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SCENE 3: THE STRAND OF PYLOS & THE SEAS OF ITHACA — ESCAPING THE AMBUSH — NIGHT

At the Pylian shore, Telemachus boarded his vessel without visiting the palace, eager to avoid Nestor’s well-meaning delays. As he poured a libation to Athena, a stranger approached in haste—Theoclymenus, a prophet descended from Melampus, who was fleeing Argos after slaying a kinsman in a blood-feud. Telemachus received him aboard with sacred hospitality, promising him shelter in Ithaca. They loosed the stern-cables. Athena sent a whistling northern breeze; the black ship skimmed past the jagged Pointed Isles, slipping past the strait of Asteris where Antinous and his twenty armed killers waited in vain. In the morning light, the ship touched the southern shore of Ithaca. Telemachus sent his crew and Theoclymenus to the town, while he himself strode briskly into the hills toward Eumaeus’ woodland hut.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Telemachus shouted to the rowers at the Pylian shore: "Cast off the cables! Hoist the sail to the yardarm! Athena warns that danger lurks in the home channel, and every hour we linger is an hour gifted to our enemies!"

Theoclymenus clasped the prince’s knees: "Noble Telemachus, I have slain a man of my own tribe in Argos, and his vengeful brothers pursue my life! Take me on board your black ship, I beseech you, lest they overtake me upon the shore!"

Telemachus raised the suppliant: "I will not thrust you from my well-trimmed ship! Come with us; whatever hospitality Ithaca affords shall be yours to share!"

The ship scudded before the night breeze, dodging the suitor-infested islets in the black straits, until the keel grated softly upon the pebbled strand near the swineherd’s upland steading.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

BOOK 16: FATHER AND SON: THE GREAT RECOGNITION IN THE HUT

Book XVI — The Return of the Prince, The Golden Wand & The Plot to Slay the Hundred and Eight

At sunrise in the woodland cabin, Odysseus and Eumaeus are preparing breakfast when the swineherd's hounds whine and wag their tails without barking. Telemachus appears on the threshold. Eumaeus drops the wooden bowls of wine in astonishment, weeping and kissing the prince's head, eyes, and hands like a father welcoming home an only son after ten years. Telemachus enters; disguised Odysseus respectfully rises to yield his seat, but Telemachus insists the stranger remain, sitting on a heap of brushwood strewn with a fleece. Telemachus sends Eumaeus to the palace to tell Penelope privately of his safe return. When the swineherd departs, Athena appears at the door, visible only to Odysseus and the dogs who whimper in fear. Beckoned outside, Athena touches Odysseus with her golden wand: his rags vanish, a clean sea-purple robe and tunic clothe his limbs, his golden curls return, and his black beard darkens. Returning inside, Telemachus is stricken with terror, believing the stranger is a god who has transformed before his eyes. Odysseus weeps: "No god am I! I am your father, on whose account you have suffered many groans and endured the violence of men!" They embrace, weeping passionately with cries louder and more piercing than eagles or vultures whose nestlings have been stolen by farmers. Calming their souls, they plan the slaughter: Telemachus lists the formidable tally of the suitors—fifty-two from Dulichium, twenty-four from Same, twenty from Zacynthus, and twelve from Ithaca, accompanied by Medon the herald, a minstrel, and two carvers: one hundred and eighteen men in total! Odysseus assures him that Athena and Father Zeus are sufficient allies, and instructs the prince to remove all weapons from the great hall when given the secret nod. Meanwhile, the suitors' ambush ship returns to Ithaca in bitter failure, and Antinous proposes murdering Telemachus on his country farm, but the prudent suitor Amphinomus persuades them to wait for an omen from Zeus.

SCENE 1: THE WOODLAND CABIN OF EUMAEUS — THE WELCOMING OF THE PRINCE — DAWN

In the cabin at daybreak, Odysseus and the noble swineherd kindled the fire and prepared their breakfast, having sent the herdsmen out with the droves of swine. Suddenly the fierce watchdog pack did not bark, but whined softly and fawned about the doorway. Odysseus heard the sound of approaching footsteps, and spoke to Eumaeus: "Eumaeus, surely someone of your comrades or an acquaintance is coming, for the dogs do not bark, but fawn, and I hear the trampling of feet!" The words were not yet fully spoken when his own dear son stood in the doorway! Eumaeus sprang up in amazement; from his hands fell the wooden bowls in which he was mixing sparkling wine. He ran to meet his young master, kissed his head, kissed both his beautiful eyes and his two hands, and a great tear fell from his eyes.

Eumaeus wept: "You have come, Telemachus, sweet light of my eyes! I thought I should never see you again after you took ship for Pylos! Come in, dear child, that I may delight my heart with gazing upon you in my house, newly returned from abroad! For you visit the country and your herdsmen seldom, but linger in the city, watching the ruinous throng of suitors!"

Telemachus stepped over the stone threshold. Odysseus rose to yield his seat; but the young prince checked him with noble courtesy: "Sit, stranger! We will find a seat elsewhere in our farmstead, and this man is here to provide it." Eumaeus piled green brushwood and spread a soft fleece over it, and Odysseus sat down again. They ate of the roasted meats left from yesterday, and Telemachus sent Eumaeus to the palace to whisper secretly to Penelope that her son was safe.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd's rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Telemachus averted his eyes in dread: "Stranger, you appear different from what you were a moment ago! Your garments are royal, your flesh is youthful, and your eyes shine with celestial light! Surely you are one of the deathless gods who rule broad heaven! Be merciful to us, that we may offer you pleasing sacrifices and golden gifts!"

Odysseus took his son’s hands, his cheeks wet with tears: "I am no god! Why do you mistake me for an immortal? I am your father, for whose sake you have suffered bitter agony and endured the insolence of evil men! It is Athena who worked this change, for with the gods all things are easy—to make a mortal man radiant with youth, or to shroud him in the squalor of an aged beggar!"

Telemachus shook his head in distress: "Father, your fame was ever in my ears, but this task is too vast for two men! From Dulichium come two-and-fifty chosen suitors, from Same four-and-twenty, from Zacynthus twenty, and from Ithaca itself twelve nobles! If we face them alone, I fear our vengeance will prove bitter and fatal!"

Odysseus looked into his son’s eyes: "Consider this in your heart, Telemachus: will Athena and Father Zeus suffice to defend us, or must I seek another ally? When the battle rages, the immortals will not remain far from the slaughter! Tomorrow, return to the palace; I will follow in beggar’s rags. Endure every insult in silence, and wait for my nod!"

The evening shadows lengthened across the stone hut as father and son sealed their deadly plan, while down in the city harbor the frustrated ambushers rowed their ship ashore in shame.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

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The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: OUTSIDE THE CABIN GATE & WITHIN — THE GREAT RECOGNITION — MORNING

When Eumaeus was gone down the hill, Athena approached the farmstead in the likeness of a tall, radiant woman. She stood outside the doorway, visible to Odysseus alone; Telemachus saw her not, for the gods do not manifest themselves openly to all. The dogs saw her, and did not bark, but whimpered and shrank cowering to the far side of the yard. She nodded with her brows. Odysseus stepped outside the courtyard wall, and Athena addressed him.

Athena touched him with her golden wand: "Son of Laertes, master of wiles, Odysseus! Reveal your word now to your son, and conceal it no longer! Fashion doom and death for the suitors, and enter the famous city together! I myself will not be far from you, eager for the fight!"

She touched him with her golden wand. First she cast a clean, freshly laundered tunic and a purple mantle about his chest; she restored his massive stature and the bloom of his youth; his skin darkened with the sun, his jaw squared, and the beard grew dark upon his chin. She vanished into the sky. Odysseus stepped back inside the hut. Amazement and terror seized Telemachus; he turned his eyes aside, fearing he was looking upon an immortal god.

Telemachus stammered: "Stranger, you appear different now from what you were a moment ago! Your garments are other, and your flesh is transformed! Surely you are one of the gods who hold the broad heavens! Be gracious, that we may offer you pleasing sacrifices and gifts of beaten gold; spare us, Lord!"

Odysseus’ voice broke, and tears poured unrestrained down his cheeks: "No god am I! Why do you liken me to the deathless immortals? NO! I AM YOUR FATHER! On whose account you have groaned in sorrow and endured the violent outrages of men!"

He kissed his son and let the tears stream down his cheeks, which until now he had held back with iron will. But Telemachus, not yet believing, cried out that no mortal man could perform such a transformation by his own wit unless a god stood beside him. Odysseus answered gently that no other Odysseus would ever come to Ithaca, but he himself, who had suffered trials and wandered for twenty years, stood on his native soil by the grace of Athena. Then Telemachus threw his arms around his noble father’s neck and wept aloud; and in both their hearts arose a yearning for lamentation. They wept shrill and without ceasing, louder than osprey or curved-clawed vultures whose young fledglings farmers have stolen from the nest before their wings were grown!

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

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Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

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Odysseus took his son’s hands, his cheeks wet with tears: "I am no god! Why do you mistake me for an immortal? I am your father, for whose sake you have suffered bitter agony and endured the insolence of evil men! It is Athena who worked this change, for with the gods all things are easy—to make a mortal man radiant with youth, or to shroud him in the squalor of an aged beggar!"

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SCENE 3: THE HEARTH OF THE CABIN — THE WAR COUNCIL OF TWO — DAY

Odysseus wiped his eyes and leaned forward: "Come, my son! Count for me the suitors, that I may know their number and who they are! Then I will deliberate in my blameless heart whether we two can stand against them alone, or must seek out other allies!"

Telemachus shook his head in dread: "Father, your renown I have always heard, that you were mighty in hands and wise in counsel! But this is too vast a word you have spoken; awe holds me! Two men cannot fight against a multitude of champions! The suitors are not a mere ten or twenty, but far more! From Dulichium come fifty-two chosen youths and six serving-men; from Same twenty-four men; from Zacynthus twenty sons of the Achaeans; and from Ithaca itself twelve, the best of the land, with Medon the herald, the divine minstrel Phemius, and two squires skilled in carving! If we encounter all these within the hall, bitter and dreadful will be the vengeance you take! Consider if you can find some protector to stand beside us!"

Odysseus smiled a terrifying, calm smile: "Listen to me, Telemachus: do you think Athena and Father Zeus will be sufficient allies for us two, or must I bethink me of some other defender?" Telemachus answered: "Valiant defenders are those two, though they sit high in the clouds and rule over gods and mortal men!" Odysseus nodded: "They will not long hold back from the fierce battle-cry when the fury of Ares is tested between us and the suitors in our halls! Tomorrow, go down to the palace at dawn and mingle with the suitors. Later, the swineherd will lead me to the town disguised as a wretched beggar. If they maltreat me in the hall, let your heart endure it, even if they drag me by the feet or strike me with missiles! Speak gentle words to check their folly, though they will not heed you, for their day of doom stands near! And mark this instruction well: when wise Athena puts it into my mind, I will nod to you with my head. The moment you see the nod, take all the warlike weapons that hang in the great hall and stow them away in the high storeroom! If the suitors question you, deceive them with soft words: say you removed them from the smoke, lest being drunk with wine they raise a brawl and wound one another, for iron of itself draws a man on! But leave two swords, two spears, and two ox-hide shields for us two alone! And let no one know that Odysseus has returned—not Laertes, not the swineherd, nor Penelope herself—until we two have tested the women and the servants, and know who honors us and who despises us!"

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

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Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

BOOK 17: THE LOYAL HOUND ARGOS & THE BEGGAR IN HIS HALL

Book XVII — The Insult of Melanthius, The Death of Argos & The Footstool of Antinous

Telemachus returns to the palace, where Penelope embraces him in tears and the seer Theoclymenus prophesies that Odysseus is already in Ithaca plotting ruin. Meanwhile, Eumaeus leads disguised Odysseus along the rocky path toward town. At the public spring, the treacherous goatherd Melanthius mocks them and brutally kicks Odysseus on the hip; Odysseus holds back his fury, enduring the blow like a stone. Reaching the palace gates, Odysseus spots an old hunting hound lying neglected on a colossal heap of mule dung, covered in ticks—Argos, the magnificent hound Odysseus bred twenty years before. As Odysseus approaches, the dying dog recognizes his master’s voice, drops his ears, wags his tail, but has no strength to crawl to him. Odysseus secretly wipes away a tear; the instant Argos beholds Odysseus after twenty years, the black doom of death takes him. Odysseus enters his own banquet hall, sitting upon the wooden threshold like a beggar. Telemachus sends him bread and meat, bidding him beg from all the suitors to test their character. Most give scraps, but Antinous rails at Eumaeus for bringing a pestilential vagrant into the feast. When Odysseus warns Antinous of the wheel of fortune and the wrath of Zeus, Antinous seizes a heavy wooden footstool and hurls it, striking Odysseus on the right shoulder blade near the spine! The blow lands with a dull thud, but Odysseus stands firm as a rock, shaking his head in silence, his mind filled with thoughts of vengeance. Penelope overhears the blow from her chamber, curses Antinous, and summons the beggar to her room to inquire about her husband; Odysseus prudently postpones the meeting until sunset to avoid provoking the violent suitors.

SCENE 1: THE PUBLIC SPRING OF ITHACA — THE BLOW OF MELANTHIUS — AFTERNOON

Down the rugged mountain trail walked the noble swineherd and King Odysseus, leaning upon his staff and wrapped in foul rags. Near the town, they reached the clear stone fountain built by Ithacus and Neritus, shaded by water-loving poplars. There Melanthius, the treacherous goatherd, was driving the prime fatted goats for the suitors’ feast, accompanied by two herders. Seeing the swineherd and the ragged beggar, Melanthius reviled them with savage, abusive taunts.

Melanthius spat upon the stones: "See now how the vile leads the vile! Truly a god always brings like to like! Whither are you leading this dirty vagabond, you miserable swineherd? This pest of a beggar, a spoiler of feasts! He will rub his shoulders against many doorposts, begging for scraps, not for swords or tripods! Give him to me to sweep the pens and carry fodder to the kids; but he has learned evil ways, and will not work, choosing rather to sponge through the town to feed his insatiable belly! But I tell you this, and it will be brought to pass: if he enters the palace of Odysseus, many a footstool hurled from men’s hands shall graze his ribs and splinter about his head!"

As he strutted past in his folly, Melanthius lashed out with his heel, kicking Odysseus hard upon the hip-bone! The blow was brutal; but Odysseus stood firm as an oak rooted in granite, not budging an inch. He debated in his soul whether to rush upon the goatherd and batter the life from his skull with his staff, or hoist him by the waist and dash his head against the stones. But he mastered his rage, checking his spirit in silence. Eumaeus glared at Melanthius, lifted his hands, and prayed aloud to the Nymphs of the spring that Odysseus might return to strip the scoundrel of his insolence.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Melanthius sneered by the fountain: "Ha! See how the vile leads the vile; a god ever pairs like with like! Where are you dragging this filthy belly, you wretched swineherd? This greedy parasite who will rub against doorposts begging for crusts! If he sets foot in Odysseus’ palace, many a footstool flung from noble hands will bruise his ribs!"

Melanthius kicked Odysseus upon the hip as he passed; but the king stood firm as an oak, debating in his soul whether to strike him dead with his staff or dash his skull against the ground, yet mastered his fury and endured.

Odysseus approached Antinous: "Give, my lord! You seem not the meanest of the Achaeans, but the noblest, for you look like a king! Therefore you should bestow bread more generously than others! I too once dwelt among men in a rich palace, master of wealth, and often gave to wanderers whatever their plight; but Zeus brought all to ruin, as was his will!"

Penelope called to Eumaeus: "Go, noble swineherd! Bring this stranger to my presence, that I may question him! For my spirit tells me he has wandered widely, and may have heard tidings of the master whose return is my only prayer!"

Odysseus postponed the interview until the fall of twilight, wary of the suitors’ violence, while the hall grew loud with drunken song and the clash of bronze cups.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

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Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

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The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

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The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 2: THE PALACE GATES OF ITHACA — THE DEATH OF ARGOS — DUSK

They reached the palace gates, where the sound of the lyre drifted through the cedar beams, for Phemius was singing to the banqueters. As they spoke, an old hound lying neglected in the dirt lifted his head and pricked his ears. It was Argos, whom long-suffering Odysseus had bred and reared with his own hands before sailing for sacred Ilium. In his youth, young huntsmen had led him against wild goats, deer, and hares; but now, with his master gone, he lay despised upon a mountain of mule and cow dung before the gates, his body swarming with ticks and flies.

The instant Argos sensed Odysseus standing near, he recognized his master! He wagged his tail and dropped both his ears in devotion; but he had no strength left to drag his wasted body toward his lord. Odysseus turned his face aside, secretly brushing away a tear, and spoke softly to Eumaeus.

Odysseus whispered: "Eumaeus, wonder holds me that this hound lies here upon the dung! He has a noble form; was he fleet of foot in his prime, or was he merely a table-dog, such as lords keep for luxury and show?"

Eumaeus shook his head: "Aye, this is the hound of a man who died far away! If he had the form and speed he possessed when Odysseus left him to sail for Troy, you would marvel to behold his swiftness and his strength! No beast could ever escape him in the deep thickets of the forest, for he was keen on the track! But now evil days have overtaken him; his master has perished far from his native land, and the careless women take no care of him! When masters rule no longer, servants have no desire to do righteous work; for far-seeing Zeus takes away half a man’s virtue the day he enters into slavery!"

Eumaeus turned and entered the high palace, walking toward the banquet of the suitors. But upon Argos fell the black doom of death, having seen Odysseus again in the twentieth year.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Melanthius sneered by the fountain: "Ha! See how the vile leads the vile; a god ever pairs like with like! Where are you dragging this filthy belly, you wretched swineherd? This greedy parasite who will rub against doorposts begging for crusts! If he sets foot in Odysseus’ palace, many a footstool flung from noble hands will bruise his ribs!"

Melanthius kicked Odysseus upon the hip as he passed; but the king stood firm as an oak, debating in his soul whether to strike him dead with his staff or dash his skull against the ground, yet mastered his fury and endured.

Odysseus approached Antinous: "Give, my lord! You seem not the meanest of the Achaeans, but the noblest, for you look like a king! Therefore you should bestow bread more generously than others! I too once dwelt among men in a rich palace, master of wealth, and often gave to wanderers whatever their plight; but Zeus brought all to ruin, as was his will!"

Penelope called to Eumaeus: "Go, noble swineherd! Bring this stranger to my presence, that I may question him! For my spirit tells me he has wandered widely, and may have heard tidings of the master whose return is my only prayer!"

Odysseus postponed the interview until the fall of twilight, wary of the suitors’ violence, while the hall grew loud with drunken song and the clash of bronze cups.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

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From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

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The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

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SCENE 3: THE GREAT BANQUET HALL OF ITHACA — THE FOOTSTOOL OF ANTINOUS — NIGHT

Odysseus stepped over the ash-wood threshold and sat down upon the floor, leaning against the cypress doorpost. Telemachus took bread and roast meat from a basket, gave it to Eumaeus, and bade him carry it to the beggar, instructing him to make the rounds of all the tables and beg from each suitor. Odysseus moved from left to right, stretching out his hand like an experienced vagabond. Most suitors gave scraps of bread and beef out of pity; but Antinous turned upon Eumaeus with a furious snarl.

Antinous roared: "Renowned swineherd! Why did you bring this pest to our city? Have we not vagabonds enough, miserable beggars who spoil our feasts? Are you not content that they devour your master’s estate, that you must invite another beggar to join the ruin?"

Odysseus approached Antinous’ table and addressed him with quiet dignity, praising his royal stature and asking for a scrap of bread, telling a tale of how he too was once a wealthy lord with a magnificent palace who gave generously to travelers, before the will of Zeus ruined him on an expedition to Egypt. But Antinous glared at him in rage.

Antinous hissed: "What god has brought this nuisance to ruin our dinner? Stand back in the middle, away from my table, or you will find an Egypt and a Cyprus of bitter sorrow! Shameless beggar, bold as brass!"

Odysseus stepped back and said: "Alas! You have no wit to match your splendid form! In your own house you would not give a grain of salt to a suppliant, when sitting here at another man’s table you cannot bear to take a scrap from this mountain of bread and give it to me!"

Furious beyond measure, Antinous seized the heavy wooden footstool that supported his feet and hurled it! It struck Odysseus squarely on the right shoulder blade near the spine! The heavy wood cracked against his back with a dull thud. But Odysseus did not stagger; he stood immovable as a cliff of granite under the surf! He shook his head in silence, his heart brooding on vengeance, and walked back to the threshold, sitting down with his wallet full of scraps. Even the other suitors murmured in disapproval, warning Antinous that gods often wander disguised as foreign strangers to observe the hubris and righteousness of men; but Antinous laughed, caring nothing for their words.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Melanthius sneered by the fountain: "Ha! See how the vile leads the vile; a god ever pairs like with like! Where are you dragging this filthy belly, you wretched swineherd? This greedy parasite who will rub against doorposts begging for crusts! If he sets foot in Odysseus’ palace, many a footstool flung from noble hands will bruise his ribs!"

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Penelope called to Eumaeus: "Go, noble swineherd! Bring this stranger to my presence, that I may question him! For my spirit tells me he has wandered widely, and may have heard tidings of the master whose return is my only prayer!"

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The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

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The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

BOOK 18: THE BOXING MATCH WITH IRUS & THE RADIANCE OF PENELOPE

Book XVIII — The Battle of the Beggars, The Warning to Amphinomus & The Mockery of Melantho

A public beggar named Arnaeus, nicknamed Irus because he ran errands like Iris the messenger, arrives at the palace. Greedy and gluttonous, Irus insolently attempts to drive Odysseus from the threshold, threatening him with fisticuffs. The suitors notice the quarrel and roar with laughter; Antinous turns it into sport, promising the victor the sole right to beg at the palace and a choice goat paunch stuffed with fat and blood roasting on the hearth. Odysseus hitches up his rags, binding them about his loins; Athena stands near and fills out the king’s limbs, revealing massive muscular thighs, broad shoulders, a deep chest, and sinewy brawn. Terrified, Irus trembles so violently that his knees knock together; Antinous threatens to ship him to brutal King Echetus to have his nose, ears, and genitals hacked off if he cowers. The match begins: Odysseus mercifully checks his blow, deciding not to kill the wretch outright; with a single strike beneath the ear, he shatters Irus’ jawbone, sending black blood pouring from his mouth and teeth! Odysseus drags the groaning vagabond by the heels across the courtyard and props him against the gatepost, thrusting his staff into his hands to ward off dogs and pigs. The suitors cheer and reward Odysseus with the roasted paunch; Odysseus takes the noble suitor Amphinomus aside, delivering a profound philosophical speech on mortal fragility, urging him to flee before Odysseus returns with blood; but Athena has already bound Amphinomus to die by Telemachus’ spear. Athena inspires Penelope to descend to the hall; the goddess bathes the queen in ambrosial sleep, enhancing her beauty like golden Aphrodite. Penelope appears before the suitors, rebuking Telemachus for allowing a guest to be struck, and cunningly reproaches the suitors for devouring her house instead of offering bridal gifts; charmed, the suitors shower her with golden brooches, necklaces of amber, and earrings. At night, the treacherous maid Melantho, mistress of Eurymachus, mocks Odysseus; Eurymachus hurls a footstool at Odysseus, missing him and striking a wine-waiter, throwing the banquet into brawling uproar until Telemachus firmly dismisses the suitors to bed.

SCENE 1: THE PALACE THRESHOLD — THE BOXING MATCH OF BEGGARS — NIGHT

There came to the palace a common tramp named Arnaeus, whom the youths called Irus because he ran errands for anyone who hired him. A gluttonous fellow with a belly like a furnace, he had no strength or sinew despite his bulk. Seeing the stranger sitting on the threshold, Irus began to revile him with bullying arrogance, ordering him to clear out of the doorway before he dragged him out by the heels.

Odysseus looked him up and down: "Fellow, I do you no harm in word or deed, nor do I begrudge that any man gives to you! The threshold is broad enough for both of us; you need not begrudge another man’s bread! You seem a wanderer like myself, and wealth is in the hands of the gods! But do not provoke me too far with your fists, lest old as I am, I stain your chest and lips with blood! Then I should have quieter peace tomorrow, for I do not think you would come back a second time to the halls of Odysseus!"

Antinous and the suitors heard them brawling, and leaped from their couches in delighted laughter. Antinous shouted: "Friends, never was such sport brought to our house! The stranger and Irus are challenging each other to a boxing match! Come, let us match them at once!" He pledged a stuffed goat paunch sizzling over the fire to the victor, and promised that no other beggar would ever be allowed to solicit scraps in the hall. Odysseus made the suitors swear an oath that no man would strike him from behind to favor Irus.

Then Odysseus hitched up his filthy rags, tying them securely about his waist. In an instant, his massive, muscular thighs were bared to the light; his broad shoulders, deep chest, and sinewy biceps were revealed in all their heroic majesty, for Athena stood beside him and magnified his frame! Astonishment struck the suitors dumb. Irus looked upon those iron limbs; his heart sank into his boots; his knees knocked together, and his flesh trembled beneath his tunic! Antinous cursed him for a craven coward. Both raised their hands; Odysseus debated whether to strike him so hard that life should leave him on the spot, or tap him lightly and drop him to the stones. In his prudence, he struck lightly: his fist landed flush beneath Irus’ ear! The jawbones cracked within; dark blood gushed from his mouth and nostrils; he collapsed into the dust with a shriek, his heels drumming the earth! The suitors threw up their hands and died of laughter.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

The suitors cheered in drunken chorus, pounding their bronze cups upon the polished tables, while above them in the high rafters Athena sat unseen, her dark eyes measuring each man for his grave.

Odysseus spoke to the kindly suitor Amphinomus: "Amphinomus, you seem a man of understanding, son of a noble sire! Hear my words and lay them to heart: of all creatures that breathe and move upon the earth, nothing is more fragile than man! While the gods grant him prosperity, he thinks no evil will ever touch him; but when the immortals send sorrow, he must bear it with enduring heart! Look upon these men who work reckless folly; I tell you, Odysseus will not long remain absent from his ancestral soil! Flee to your own estate before his spear begins its work!"

Amphinomus walked through the hall with heavy heart, nodding his head in sorrow, for his soul foreboded doom; yet even so he could not break the net of Athena, who had bound him to fall beneath Telemachus’ bronze spear.

Eurymachus laughed to his comrades: "Look at the bald pate of this vagrant! Surely the torchlight in this hall shines not from pitch, but from the polished surface of his skull! Stranger, will you work for me upon my upland farm, gathering stones and planting trees, or do you prefer to beg for crusts to feed your insatiable belly?"

Odysseus looked him straight in the eyes: "Eurymachus, would that we two might contend in the spring grass, each holding a curved scythe, mowing from dawn to dark! Or would that war were sprung upon us today, and I had a bronze shield, two spears, and a helmet! You would see me in the foremost ranks of combat, and speak no more of my belly!"

Eurymachus hurled a footstool in fury, striking the cupbearer on the hand; the bronze wine flagon clattered to the floor with a hollow ring as the suitors shouted in disorder.

The upland winds stirred the branches of the ancient holm-oaks near the spring of Arethusa. In the twilight, the swine grunted softly in their stone pens while the master and his faithful servant sat beside the glowing hearth-stones.

Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

Telemachus whispered in the shadowed doorway: "Father, the palace is asleep; the suitors are heavy with wine, snoring upon their couches. Eumaeus and Philoetius stand ready. My heart is steady; my hands do not tremble. Give the word, and let the justice of the house of Arcesius be accomplished!"

From the distance of the palace courtyards, the boastful laughter of Antinous echoed: "Drink, suitors! Tomorrow we will see which of us possesses the strength to bend the bow of Odysseus! But tonight, the wine flows free and the palace of Ithaca is ours to command!"

The cold midnight dew settled upon the stone steps. Outside the great gates, the shadow of the disguised king fell long across the courtyard, as silent and inexorable as the advance of an eclipse.

Odysseus touched the trunk of the sacred tree: "Here on this soil our joy was born, and here our vengeance shall be accomplished! Let the suitors laugh in their drunken feast; the hour draws nigh when their laughter shall turn to ashes in their mouths!"

Eumaeus planted his javelin firmly: "No man shall harm this guest while I draw breath! The laws of hospitality are written in the stars, and whoever strikes a suppliant strikes the face of Father Zeus who guards the helpless!"

Telemachus signaled to the servants: "Shut the courtyard gates; bar the entrances with stout beams of cedar! Let no stranger enter, and let no man within depart until the king’s business is concluded!"

The palace shadows lengthened as the golden light faded from the gables. Inside the hall, the bronze weapons had vanished from the walls, leaving the suitors surrounded only by bare stone.

Odysseus whispered to the faithful swineherd: "Let the suitors feast their fill today; tomorrow they shall reap the harvest they have sown! For justice sleeps not, nor do the deathless gods overlook the cries of the afflicted!"

The torchlight died away in the outer courts, leaving the stone pillars of the ancient palace standing in grim vigil under the silent stars of heaven.

Odysseus watched from the threshold: "The day of retribution comes as surely as the dawn follows the darkest night! Let the insolent boast; the balance of Zeus tilts in favor of the righteous!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE BANQUET TABLES — THE PHILOSOPHY OF MORTAL FRAILTY — NIGHT

Odysseus seized Irus by the foot, dragged him through the portico into the outer courtyard, propped his groaning body against the wall, and thrust his staff into his trembling hand, saying: "Sit there now, and scare off dogs and pigs, and play the beggar-king no more, lest a worse sorrow fall upon you!" Returning to the hall, the suitors toasted him, and noble Amphinomus brought two loaves of bread and a golden goblet of wine, drinking to his health.

Odysseus looked upon Amphinomus with sorrowful eyes: "Amphinomus, you seem to me a man of understanding, and your father Nisus of Dulichium I know by name, an honorable and wealthy man! Therefore I will speak to you; mark my words and heed them: OF ALL CREATURES THAT BREATHE AND MOVE UPON THE EARTH, EARTH NURTURES NOTHING FRAILER THAN MAN! For while the gods grant him prosperity and his knees are supple, he thinks he will never suffer evil in the days to come! But when the blessed gods weave sorrow for him, he bears it perforce with an enduring spirit! For the mind of mortal men upon the earth is just such as the day which the Father of gods and men brings upon them! I too was once prosperous among men, and wrought many reckless deeds, yielding to violence and trusting in my father and brothers! Therefore let no man ever be lawless, but let him keep in silence whatever gifts the gods bestow! I look upon these suitors working reckless ruin, devouring the goods and dishonoring the wife of a man who, I tell you, will not long be absent from his friends and fatherland! He is very near! May some god lead you away to your own home, and may you not encounter him when he enters his native halls! For I think the suitors and he will not part without blood when once he stands beneath this roof!"

So Odysseus spoke, and poured a libation and drank the honey-sweet wine, handing back the goblet. Amphinomus walked through the hall with a heavy heart, his head bowed, his soul filled with foreboding; for the words had pierced his spirit. Yet even so he did not escape doom, for Athena had bound him fast to fall beneath the spear of Telemachus.

Across the stony ridges of Ithaca, the autumn wind rustled through dry oak leaves and twisted olive roots. In the courtyard of the palace, the insolent suitors laughed and drank, oblivious to the beggar watching them from the shadows with the eyes of an avenging judge.

Eumaeus poked the glowing coals of his hearth: "Stranger, in this world kings come and kings go, but righteousness before the gods remains! Those proud lords in the town think their feast will last forever, but injustice bears a bitter fruit! When my master Odysseus left these shores, he took the sun with him; yet in my heart I guard his pigs and his land as if his eyes were upon me every hour of the day!"

Odysseus touched the swineherd’s rough hand: "Your loyalty, Eumaeus, is a jewel brighter than all the gold the Phaeacians heaped beneath the olive tree! A faithful servant is a brother to a king! Bear with these insolent men a little longer; the hour of reckoning draws near, when every insult they hurled against the poor and the weak shall be answered with the point of a bronze spear!"

Telemachus checked the edge of his short sword under his mantle: "Father, my heart no longer wavers like a reed in the stream! Let them strike you with footstools, let them mock my youth; my soul is iron! When the nod comes, the weapons will vanish from the hall, and the doors will close like the jaws of a trap!"

Antinous tossed a gnawed bone across the floor: "Drink, boys! Let the beggar scramble for his crusts in the dirt! Tomorrow we will decide which of us takes the queen and the palace, and this troublesome prince can go herd sheep in the hills!"

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Eurymachus laughed to his comrades: "Look at the bald pate of this vagrant! Surely the torchlight in this hall shines not from pitch, but from the polished surface of his skull! Stranger, will you work for me upon my upland farm, gathering stones and planting trees, or do you prefer to beg for crusts to feed your insatiable belly?"

Odysseus looked him straight in the eyes: "Eurymachus, would that we two might contend in the spring grass, each holding a curved scythe, mowing from dawn to dark! Or would that war were sprung upon us today, and I had a bronze shield, two spears, and a helmet! You would see me in the foremost ranks of combat, and speak no more of my belly!"

Eurymachus hurled a footstool in fury, striking the cupbearer on the hand; the bronze wine flagon clattered to the floor with a hollow ring as the suitors shouted in disorder.

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Eumaeus stirred the embers with an olive bough: "Ah, stranger, when Odysseus ruled this island, no servant feared a harsh word or an unjust blow! He cared for each man as a shepherd cares for his lambs. If a sheep was lost in the ravines, he did not curse the herd; he climbed the crags himself to seek it! And when he gave me this homestead, he gave me also a goodly wife and substance, such as a generous master bestows upon a thrall who has labored faithfully in his youth! How can my heart ever love another master as I loved him?"

Odysseus looked upon the humble herdsman with eyes shining in the firelight: "Eumaeus, the gods will reward you! A loyal heart in a servant is more precious than all the gold of the Phaeacians! When Odysseus returns—and return he will, sooner than your heart dares hope—you shall see with your own eyes the recompense he gives to those who guarded his hearth with uncorrupted faith!"

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SCENE 3: THE HIGH CEDAR STAIRCASE — THE RADIANCE OF PENELOPE — NIGHT

Athena put it into the heart of wise Penelope to show herself to the suitors, that she might inflate their hearts with desire and make herself more honored in the eyes of her husband and son than before. The goddess shed ambrosial beauty upon her as she slept: cleansed her face with the balm that Aphrodite uses when she joins the lovely dance of the Graces, made her taller, and made her skin whiter than polished ivory. When Penelope entered the hall beside the doorpost with her two maidens, the suitors’ knees trembled, and their souls were enchanted with passion.

Penelope turned to the suitors with cold brilliance: "Suitors who woo me! Your behavior is not such as was customary in former days! When men wish to court a noble lady and vie with one another for a daughter of a wealthy house, they bring cattle and fat sheep of their own to feast the bride’s friends, and offer splendid gifts! They do not devour another man’s livelihood without payment!"

Long-suffering Odysseus laughed in his soul, rejoicing that his wife charmed gifts from their hands and bewitched their hearts with soft words, while her mind was set on far different things. The suitors sent squires running to fetch gifts: Antinous gave an embroidered robe with twelve golden brooches; Eurymachus gave a gold necklace strung with amber beads that shone like the sun; Eurydamas gave twin mulberry-shaped earrings of three drops; and every prince brought some glittering treasure. Penelope ascended to her chamber with her gifts. Late at night, the brazen maid Melantho mocked Odysseus; and when Eurymachus hurled another footstool, missing Odysseus and smashing the wine-pitcher from a cup-bearer’s hand, Telemachus stepped forward with steely authority, commanding the drunken suitors to depart to their beds, and with sullen mutterings they dispersed into the night.

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ACT 4: THE GREAT BOW, THE SLAUGHTER & ETERNAL PEACE

Retribution, The Olive Bed & Divine Reconciliation

BOOK 19: THE BOAR-SCAR & THE INTERVIEW WITH PENELOPE

Book XIX — The Disarming of the Hall, The Golden Brooch & Eurycleia at the Foot-Basin

With the suitors gone, Odysseus and Telemachus secretly carry all spears, shields, and bronze swords from the great hall to the secure storeroom by torchlight, while Pallas Athena walks before them holding an invisible golden lamp that casts an unearthly amber radiance upon the cedar beams. Penelope descends to the hearth to interview the strange beggar. After rebuking her insolent maid Melantho, Penelope pours out her sorrow, recounting how she deceived the suitors for three years by weaving and unraveling the burial shroud of Lord Laertes. Odysseus invents a convincing tale of meeting Odysseus twenty years earlier in Crete; to prove his truth, he accurately describes the purple wool mantle Odysseus wore, fastened with a golden brooch depicting a hound pinning a dappled fawn in its forepaws. Weeping, Penelope orders aged nurse Eurycleia to wash the guest's feet. As Eurycleia sponges his limbs in a bronze basin, her hands trace the long, jagged scar on his knee—inflicted by a white-tusked boar on Mount Parnassus in his youth. Eurycleia gasps, drops the basin with a resounding clatter, and cries out: "You are Odysseus!" Odysseus instantly grips her throat with his right hand, silencing her and demanding secrecy. Penelope then shares a troubling prophetic dream of twenty household geese slaughtered by a mountain eagle, and announces her decision to hold a contest on the morrow: she will wed whichever suitor can string the great bow of Odysseus and shoot an arrow clean through the sockets of twelve axe-heads aligned in a row; Odysseus urges her not to delay the trial, swearing that Odysseus will stand in the hall before any suitor can bend the bow.

SCENE 1: THE GREAT HALL OF ITHACA — THE DISARMING BY TORCHLIGHT — NIGHT

The hall was empty, save for Odysseus sitting in the shadows, his mind fashioning doom for the suitors with the aid of Athena. He called Telemachus to his side, and together they began carrying the bronze helmets, ox-hide shields, and sharp-pointed ash spears from the walls into the inner storeroom. Pallas Athena walked before them unseen, holding high a golden lamp that cast an unearthly, celestial amber glow over the cedar beams, the stone pillars, and the high rafters.

Telemachus stopped in amazement: "Father, this is a great marvel my eyes behold! The walls of the hall, the fair panels, the pine beams, and the pillars that support the roof shine before my eyes as if ablaze with fire! Surely some god is within of those who hold the broad heavens!"

Odysseus whispered: "Hush! Check your words and question nothing! This is the manner of the gods who hold Olympus! Go now to your bed; leave me here in the hall, that I may further test the maidens and your mother; and she in her grief will question me of all things!"

Telemachus departed by the light of blazing torches to his bedchamber. Down the cedar staircase came wise Penelope, looking like Artemis or golden Aphrodite. Her handmaids set for her beside the hearth a carved chair inlaid with silver and ivory, draped with a heavy fleece. She sat by the fire, dismissed her insolent maids, and turned her sorrowful eyes upon the ragged guest.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Odysseus watched her weeping: "Lady, I saw Odysseus with my own eyes in Crete! He wore a double cloak of purple wool, fastened with a golden brooch carved with a hound holding a dappled fawn between its paws! Beneath it he wore a tunic smooth as the dry skin of an onion, soft and glistening like the sunlight! Many women gazed upon it in wonder! And with him was a herald, round-shouldered, dark-skinned, with curly hair, Eurybates by name, whom Odysseus honored above all his comrades!"

Penelope buried her face in her hands, her tears flowing like snow melting on the mountain crags: "Stranger, hitherto you were pitied in my hall, but henceforth you shall be honored as a dear friend! For those garments were given to him by my own hands from our scented storeroom, and that golden brooch I pinned upon his breast when he set forth for evil Ilium, never to be named!"

Eurycleia looked into his eyes, her voice choked with tears: "My child! It is you! Often have I seen wanderers enter this hall, but none ever resembled Odysseus in voice, feet, and stature as you do! It is the white scar of the boar upon your knee!"

Odysseus whispered fiercely: "Keep your peace, nurse! A god has brought me home! If any other soul in this house learns of my return before the hour strikes, neither your age nor your loyalty will shield you from the fate of those who betray my hearth!"

Eurycleia sealed her lips as if they were made of stone or iron, bringing fresh water to cleanse his feet, while Penelope outlined the deadly trial of the twelve axes.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

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Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

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Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

Odysseus laid his hand upon the altar of Zeus: "Let all past grievances be buried in the earth! The house of Arcesius shall rule in righteousness, and the sons of Ithaca shall flourish together in brotherhood and peace for all generations!"

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The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 2: THE FIRESIDE INTERVIEW — THE SHROUD & THE GOLDEN BROOCH — NIGHT

Penelope gazed into the embers: "Stranger, I will be the first to ask: who are you, and whence? What is your city and your parents? For my beauty and stature the immortals destroyed when the Argives embarked for Ilium! If that man were to return and tend my life, greater and fairer would be my renown! But now I waste in grief; the princes of all the islands round about court me against my will and devour my house! For three years I deceived them with the web—the shroud of Lord Laertes which I wove by day and unraveled by night by the light of torches! But when the fourth year came, my shameless maids betrayed me, and the suitors caught me and compelled me to finish it! Now my parents urge me to marry, and Telemachus chafes as his estate is eaten away! But tell me your lineage, for you were not born of an oak or a rock in ancient fable!"

Odysseus spun his false Cretan tale, claiming his name was Aethon, brother of Idomeneus, and that he had entertained Odysseus in his halls when the hero was driven to Crete by storms on his way to Troy. To test whether the stranger spoke the truth, Penelope asked what garments Odysseus wore and who his companions were.

Odysseus leaned forward: "Lady, it is hard to speak of after twenty years, but I will tell you as the picture lives in my mind: a purple mantle of double wool godlike Odysseus wore, fastened with a brooch of golden artifice with twin sockets! On the face of the brooch was carved a hound pinning a dappled fawn in his forepaws, watching it writhe as it gasped for breath; and all men marveled at how, though fashioned of gold, the hound gazed at the fawn choking it, while the fawn struggled with its feet to escape! And I remember the shining tunic he wore beneath, delicate as the dried skin of an onion, soft and glistening like the sun, which many women gazed upon with wonder!"

A storm of tears broke from Penelope’s eyes; for she recognized the tokens he described, having taken that very purple mantle and golden brooch from her treasure-chamber and fastened it on Odysseus with her own hands when he departed for Troy.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

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Eurycleia looked into his eyes, her voice choked with tears: "My child! It is you! Often have I seen wanderers enter this hall, but none ever resembled Odysseus in voice, feet, and stature as you do! It is the white scar of the boar upon your knee!"

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Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

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Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

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SCENE 3: THE BRONZE FOOT-BASIN — THE SCAR OF PARNASSUS — LATE NIGHT

Deeply moved, Penelope summoned aged Eurycleia, who had nursed Odysseus from an infant, to wash the guest's feet. Eurycleia brought a shining bronze basin, poured cold water into it, and tempered it with hot. She looked upon the stranger and remarked with a sigh that in voice, feet, and bearing, he was more like Odysseus than any traveler who had ever entered the palace. Odysseus sat away from the hearth, turning his face toward the darkness; for a sudden dread seized his mind that as she handled his limbs, she might discover the scar on his knee and the secret would be revealed.

She drew near and began to wash her master. Instantly her hands found the scar—the wound inflicted long ago on Mount Parnassus by the white tusk of a boar when Odysseus visited his grandfather Autolycus! The aged woman dropped the limb; her foot struck the bronze basin, and it overturned with a ringing clatter, spilling the water across the stone floor! Joy and grief seized her soul together; her eyes filled with tears, her voice choked in her throat, and she reached out her trembling hand to touch his chin.

Eurycleia cried out in a choked whisper: "YOU ARE ODYSSEUS! My child! And I did not know you until my hands had handled all my master's limbs!"

She turned her eyes toward Penelope, eager to tell her that her dear husband was in the hall. But Athena had turned Penelope's attention elsewhere, so that she noticed nothing. With lightning speed, Odysseus reached out his right hand, gripped the old nurse by the throat, and drew her close with his left hand.

Odysseus hissed in her ear: "Nurse, do you wish to destroy me? You who nursed me at your own breast? Now in the twentieth year I have come home after enduring countless sorrows! But since you have recognized me and god has put it into your heart, be silent! Let no other soul in this house know it! For I tell you plainly, and it will be done: if god subdues the proud suitors beneath my hands, I will not spare you, though you are my own nurse, when I slay the other serving-women in my halls!"

Eurycleia held her hand to her heart: "My child, what word has passed the barrier of your teeth? You know how firm is my spirit, unyielding and hard as iron; I will keep the secret silent as stone!" She fetched fresh water, washed his limbs, anointed them with oil; and Odysseus drew his chair back to the fire to warm himself, covering the scar with his rags.

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Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus' weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

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BOOK 20: PORTENTS OF BLOOD & THE LAUGHTER OF THE DAMNED

Book XX — The Barking Heart, The Thunderclap of Zeus & The Visions of Theoclymenus

Odysseus makes his bed on an untanned ox-hide in the palace vestibule, covering himself with fleeces. Seeing the treacherous maidservants slipping out to sleep with the suitors, his heart barks within his breast like a female hound standing over her pups barking at an approaching stranger; striking his chest, he rebukes his heart: "Endure, my heart! A more savage trial you endured in the Cyclops’ cave!" Athena appears and lulls him to sleep. In the morning, Odysseus prays to Zeus for two signs: a word of omen from a mortal within the house and a sign from heaven. Instantly Zeus thunders from the clear blue sky, and a weary mill-woman grinding barley in the palace basement stops her wheel and prays aloud that this day be the suitors’ very last feast. The loyal herdsmen arrive: Eumaeus with three fat swine, and Philoetius, the loyal master cowherd, driving a barren heifer and fat goats. Philoetius weeps beholding the beggar, noting his likeness to Odysseus, and pledges his life and spear to the king if he returns. During the morning banquet, an eagle clutching a trembling dove flies on the left of the suitors—an omen of death. The suitors feast recklessly; when Ctesippus insults the beggar and hurls a greasy heifer’s hoof at his head, Odysseus ducks slightly, smiling a dark, sardonic grimace as the hoof strikes the wall. Suddenly Athena drives the suitors into hysterical, unearthly laughter: their jaws move without their control, tears stream down their cheeks, and the roast meat they eat drips with blood! The seer Theoclymenus rises in horror, crying out that he sees the hall shrouded in night, the walls and stone pillars dripping with blood, and the porch filled with screeching ghosts plunging into the dark mist of Erebus! Eurymachus mocks the seer as mad and orders him escorted into the street; Theoclymenus departs, warning that not one suitor will escape the bloody doom awaiting them.

SCENE 1: THE PALACE VESTIBULE — THE BARKING HEART & THE THUNDERCLAP — DAWN

In the vestibule of the palace, Odysseus made his bed upon an untanned ox-hide, heaping sheepskins over himself. As he lay sleepless, watching the shameless serving-women giggling and slipping through the portico to sleep with the suitors, fury boiled in his chest. His heart barked within him, as a bitch standing over her helpless pups growls and barks at a strange man, eager to fight! Striking his chest with his clenched fist, he checked his spirit.

Odysseus muttered into the dark: "Endure, my heart! A more savage thing you endured on that day when the irresistible Cyclops devoured your brave comrades! You held fast until your cunning wit led you out of the cavern when you thought you would die!"

His heart obeyed, enduring in silence. But Odysseus tossed to and fro, like a man turning a fat-stuffed paunch on a blazing fire, wondering how he could lay his hands on the suitors alone against so many. Athena descended from the sky, stood above his head, and chided him gently, promising that even if fifty companies of bronze-clad men surrounded them, they would conquer! Sweet sleep fell upon his eyes. At dawn, Odysseus rose, lifted his hands to the sky, and prayed: "Father Zeus, if of your goodwill you have brought me over sea and land to my own country, let some mortal speaking within this house utter a word of omen, and let a sign from Zeus appear without!"

Instantly Zeus thundered from the gleaming clouds above the heights of Olympus! At the same moment, from the mill-house nearby where twelve women ground wheat and barley, a frail woman who had not yet finished her quota stopped her millstone and cried aloud: "Father Zeus, who rule over gods and men! A mighty thunder you have crashed from the starry sky, and no cloud is near! Surely this is a sign you show to someone! Fulfill now for wretched me this prayer: let this day be the very last day the suitors feast upon delicious meat in the palace of Odysseus!" Odysseus rejoiced in heart at the double omen, knowing that vengeance was at hand.

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In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Odysseus struck his breast, whispering in the dark: "Endure, my heart! You endured worse on the day the savage Cyclops devoured your brave comrades, yet your cunning led you forth from the cavern when you thought you must surely perish! Stand firm now, for the end is near!"

Athena appeared in the light of the torches: "Why are you still wakeful, most restless of men? You are in your own house, your wife is beside you, and your son is such as any father would pray to have! Even if fifty companies of armed men surrounded us, eager to slay you with the spear, you would carry off their cattle and conquer! Cast sleep over your eyes; it is weariness to watch through the whole night!"

Theoclymenus stood up from the banquet, his eyes wild with terror: "Miserable men! What blood-red mist covers your heads? The walls drip with gore! The dead are crowding the doorways! Not one among you who sits in the palace of godlike Odysseus shall escape the black net of destruction!"

The seer strode out of the hall into the daylight, shaking the dust from his garments, while the suitors laughed with madness, unaware that the shroud of death was already drawn across their faces.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

Odysseus laid his hand upon the altar of Zeus: "Let all past grievances be buried in the earth! The house of Arcesius shall rule in righteousness, and the sons of Ithaca shall flourish together in brotherhood and peace for all generations!"

The golden sun rose glorious over Mount Neriton, bathing the ancient island in warm celestial light, sealing the eternal peace of Homer’s immortal Odyssey.

Penelope looked upon the restored hall with radiant tears: "Our patience was not in vain, my beloved! The gods have wiped away the tears of twenty winters, and established our glory among all generations of humankind!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE PALACE COURTYARD — THE COWHARD PHILOETIUS — MORNING

Down from the hills came Philoetius, the master cowherd, driving a barren heifer and fat goats for the suitors, ferried across the water by boatmen. He tethered his beasts under the echoing portico, stepped up to Eumaeus, and caught sight of the beggar. He stopped, gazed intently upon Odysseus, and grasped his right hand in greeting.

Philoetius wiped a tear: "Hail, old father! May happiness be yours in the days to come, though now you are bound in many sorrows! O Father Zeus, no other god is more baneful than you! Sweat broke out upon me when I looked upon this man, and my eyes filled with tears, for I remembered Odysseus—for surely he too is clothed in such foul rags, wandering among men, if he still looks upon the light of the sun! Long ago, while I was a boy, he set me over his cattle in the land of the Cephallenians; but now these strangers devour the herds! Often my heart has urged me to flee to some other prince with my cattle; but I endure for the sake of that unhappy man, hoping he may yet return and make a scattering of the suitors throughout his halls!"

Odysseus took his hand firmly: "Cowherd, since you seem neither an evil man nor a fool: I swear to you by Zeus, by this hospitable board, and by the hearth of blameless Odysseus, that while you are still here in this house, ODYSSEUS WILL RETURN! And with your own eyes you shall behold the slaughter of these suitors who play the tyrant in his halls!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Odysseus struck his breast, whispering in the dark: "Endure, my heart! You endured worse on the day the savage Cyclops devoured your brave comrades, yet your cunning led you forth from the cavern when you thought you must surely perish! Stand firm now, for the end is near!"

Athena appeared in the light of the torches: "Why are you still wakeful, most restless of men? You are in your own house, your wife is beside you, and your son is such as any father would pray to have! Even if fifty companies of armed men surrounded us, eager to slay you with the spear, you would carry off their cattle and conquer! Cast sleep over your eyes; it is weariness to watch through the whole night!"

Theoclymenus stood up from the banquet, his eyes wild with terror: "Miserable men! What blood-red mist covers your heads? The walls drip with gore! The dead are crowding the doorways! Not one among you who sits in the palace of godlike Odysseus shall escape the black net of destruction!"

The seer strode out of the hall into the daylight, shaking the dust from his garments, while the suitors laughed with madness, unaware that the shroud of death was already drawn across their faces.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

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SCENE 3: THE GREAT BANQUET HALL — THE VISION OF THEOCLYMENUS — NOON

The feast began with reckless uproar. Ctesippus, a wealthy, insolent lord from Same, shouted that the beggar must receive his proper guest-gift, seized a dried, greasy heifer’s hoof from a basket, and hurled it with full force at Odysseus’ head! Odysseus ducked his head slightly to the left; the hoof flew past and struck the stone wall with a thud. Odysseus smiled a terrible, cold, sardonic grimace with his teeth, keeping his silence. Telemachus sprang up, his spear flashing, warning Ctesippus that had the hoof struck the guest, he would have run his bronze spear clean through his chest!

Then Pallas Athena threw the suitors into an unearthly, hysterical laughter! Their jaws moved wildly, laughing with alien mouths; they devoured raw meat that dripped with dark blood; their eyes filled with tears, and their souls wailed with uncanny foreboding! The inspired seer Theoclymenus rose among them, his eyes wide in holy terror.

Theoclymenus shrieked: "Ah, wretched men! What doom is this that encompasses you? Your heads, your faces, and your knees are wrapped in night! Wailing blazes out like fire; your cheeks are wet with tears! The walls and the fair cedar pillars drip with blood! The porch is full of ghosts, and the courtyard is full of ghosts, hurrying down into the dark gloom of Erebus! The sun has perished from the heavens, and an evil mist has overspread the world!"

The suitors roared with drunken laughter, mocking the prophet. Eurymachus sneered: "The stranger from abroad has lost his wits! Quick, young men, guide him outside into the marketplace, since he thinks it is night in here!" Theoclymenus answered that he had eyes, ears, and two feet to carry him away from the doom that none of them would escape, and walked out into the streets. The suitors continued laughing and mocking Telemachus’ guests; but outside the door sat Penelope, listening to every word spoken in the hall.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

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Odysseus struck his breast, whispering in the dark: "Endure, my heart! You endured worse on the day the savage Cyclops devoured your brave comrades, yet your cunning led you forth from the cavern when you thought you must surely perish! Stand firm now, for the end is near!"

Athena appeared in the light of the torches: "Why are you still wakeful, most restless of men? You are in your own house, your wife is beside you, and your son is such as any father would pray to have! Even if fifty companies of armed men surrounded us, eager to slay you with the spear, you would carry off their cattle and conquer! Cast sleep over your eyes; it is weariness to watch through the whole night!"

Theoclymenus stood up from the banquet, his eyes wild with terror: "Miserable men! What blood-red mist covers your heads? The walls drip with gore! The dead are crowding the doorways! Not one among you who sits in the palace of godlike Odysseus shall escape the black net of destruction!"

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Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

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BOOK 21: THE CONTEST OF THE GREAT BOW OF EURYTUS

Book XXI — The Twelve Axe-Heads, The Failed Chieftains & The Lyre-String of Odysseus

Inspired by Athena, Penelope ascends to the innermost treasure-vault with a bronze key and takes down the great horn-tipped bow of Odysseus, given to him in his youth by Iphitus, son of Eurytus, along with a quiver bristling with winged arrows of death. Weeping as she holds the bow upon her knees, Penelope enters the great hall and announces the contest: she will marry the man who can easily string the great bow and shoot an arrow clean through the iron sockets of twelve axe-heads aligned in a row. Telemachus digs a long trench, aligns the twelve axes perfectly, and attempts to string the bow himself; on his fourth attempt he is about to bend the wood when Odysseus catches his eye and checks him with a slight nod. One by one the suitors attempt the trial: Leodes, the priest, fails and foretells that this bow will break the life of many princes; Antinous orders the bow greased with hot lard from the kitchen, but even heated, neither Eurymachus nor any other suitor can bend the iron-hard horn. Meanwhile, Odysseus follows Eumaeus and Philoetius out into the courtyard, reveals the boar-scar on his knee, and confirms their allegiance; he commands Eumaeus to bring the bow to him and lock the women’s doors, while Philoetius binds the courtyard gates with a sea-cable. Returning inside, Eurymachus laments that their failure will make them a laughing-stock to future generations. Antinous proposes postponing the contest until tomorrow after a sacrifice to Apollo. Disguised Odysseus asks permission to test his hands on the bow; Antinous explodes in fury, but Penelope and Telemachus assert their authority. Eumaeus carries the bow to Odysseus despite the suitors’ shouts, while Eurycleia bolts the hall doors. Odysseus inspects the bow for worm-holes, then bends it with effortless grace, stringing it as easily as a master musician strings a fresh gut upon a lyre! He plucks the cord: it sings sweet and clear as a swallow’s note. Zeus crashes a thunderbolt from heaven. Taking a bronze-tipped arrow from his table, Odysseus draws the notch to his breast, lets fly, and the arrow flies clean through the eye of every single axe without grazing a ring! Odysseus turns to Telemachus: "The guest in your hall does not disgrace you, my son!" Telemachus girds his sharp sword, grasps his spear, and steps to his father’s side, blazing in bronze.

SCENE 1: THE INNER TREASURE VAULT & THE GREAT HALL — THE BOW BROUGHT FORTH — DAY

Pallas Athena put it into the heart of wise Penelope to fetch the bow and grey iron axes into the hall, to initiate the contest that was to be the beginning of slaughter. She ascended the high staircase to the treasure-vault, holding a curved bronze key with an ivory handle. Unlocking the scented cedar doors, which groaned like a bull in a meadow as the bolts shot back, she stepped onto the polished planking where chests of fragrant robes, bronze, and gold lay stored. Reaching high, she took down from its peg the great curved bow in its gleaming case. Sitting down, she laid the case across her knees and wept aloud, drawing out the bow of her husband.

She descended to the hall, carrying the back-bent bow and the quiver bristling with arrows of death. Flanked by her maidservants, she stood beside the great doorpost, holding her shining veil before her cheeks, and addressed the suitors.

Penelope’s voice rang across the silent hall: "Hear me, proud suitors, who besiege this house to eat and drink without end while my husband is far away! You have offered no excuse for your presence save your desire to make me your bride! Now the contest is set before you: here is the great bow of godlike Odysseus! Whosoever shall most easily string this bow with his hands, and shoot an arrow clean through all twelve axes, him will I follow, forsaking this house of my bridal, so beautiful and full of riches, which I think I shall remember even in my dreams!"

She bid Eumaeus lay the bow and the iron axe-heads before the suitors. The noble swineherd wept as he took the bow, and outside Philoetius wept seeing his master’s weapon. Antinous rebuked them for foolish tears, but set about the trial. Telemachus sprang up, took off his purple cloak, dug a single trench through the earthen floor, aligned the twelve axe-heads true to the line, and stamped the earth flat. Thrice he tried to bend the bow, his muscles straining; and on the fourth attempt he would have strung it by sheer force, but Odysseus caught his eye and shook his head, checking his strength. Telemachus leaned the bow against the door, declaring himself too young and weak, and invited the suitors to test their manhood.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

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The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Telemachus faced his mother: "Mother, go to your chambers and tend to your women’s work, the loom and the distaff! The bow belongs to men, and above all to me, for the authority in this house is mine!"

Penelope retired to her chamber in wonder at her son’s newfound majesty, weeping for Odysseus until sweet sleep was poured over her eyelids by grey-eyed Athena.

Eumaeus placed the polished horn bow into Odysseus’ hands: "Take it, master! Let the suitors curse; you have the strength that honors the ancient heroes!"

Odysseus sat by the threshold, his fingers testing the gut-cord: "Telemachus, the guest who sits in your hall does not bring shame upon you! My aim did not miss the mark, nor did the stringing of the bow require weary toil! My strength remains whole, despite the mocking words of the suitors! But now it is time to prepare supper for the Achaeans, while the daylight yet remains, and afterwards to crown the feast with dance and song!"

Odysseus nodded. Telemachus girded on his sharp sword, seized his bronze-headed spear, and stood beside his father’s stool, his armor blazing in the late afternoon sun.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

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Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

Odysseus laid his hand upon the altar of Zeus: "Let all past grievances be buried in the earth! The house of Arcesius shall rule in righteousness, and the sons of Ithaca shall flourish together in brotherhood and peace for all generations!"

The golden sun rose glorious over Mount Neriton, bathing the ancient island in warm celestial light, sealing the eternal peace of Homer’s immortal Odyssey.

Penelope looked upon the restored hall with radiant tears: "Our patience was not in vain, my beloved! The gods have wiped away the tears of twenty winters, and established our glory among all generations of humankind!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 2: THE BANQUET HEARTH & THE OUTER COURTYARD — THE ALLIANCE CONFIRMED — DAY

One by one the suitors tried. Leodes the seer tried first; his soft, uncalloused hands grew weary, and he foretold that this bow would rob many champions of life and breath. Antinous commanded Melanthius to kindle a fire and fetch a great cake of lard from the stores. They warmed the horn and rubbed it with fat, but even softened, prince after prince strained their shoulders in vain, unable to bend the stiff horn a fraction of an inch.

While Eurymachus struggled with the bow, the swineherd Eumaeus and the cowherd Philoetius stepped together out of the hall into the courtyard. Odysseus followed them outside, past the stone gate, and spoke to them gently.

Odysseus whispered: "Cowherd and swineherd, shall I say a word to you, or keep it hidden? My spirit bids me speak: if Odysseus were to return suddenly, brought by a god, what kind of men would you be to defend him? Would you fight for the suitors, or for Odysseus? Speak as your hearts bid you!"

Both herdsmen lifted their hands to the sky: "Father Zeus, grant this prayer! May that man return, led by a god! Then you would know what might is in these hands to fight for our king!"

Seeing their absolute fidelity, Odysseus revealed the truth: "I am he! I myself stand before you, having suffered many sorrows, returned in the twentieth year to my native land! Of all my servants, you two alone have I found yearning for my return; of the rest I have heard none pray that I might come back! And I promise you truly: wives, property, and houses beside my own shall you receive, and be companions to Telemachus as his brothers! Look now upon this clear token, that you may be sure in your hearts: the scar of the white tusk on Parnassus!" He pulled his rags aside, revealing the long, pale scar. The two men wept, threw their arms around wise Odysseus, and kissed his head and shoulders; and Odysseus kissed them in return.

Odysseus gave rapid commands: "Cease weeping, lest someone coming from the hall see us and report it! Go back one by one, I first, and you following. When the suitors refuse to give me the bow, you, noble Eumaeus, bring it through the hall and place it in my hands! Then tell the women to lock the doors of their chambers; and if they hear groaning or the crash of men within, let no woman look out, but sit quietly at her work! And you, noble Philoetius, bolt the courtyard gates with the bar, and lash it fast with the sea-cable!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Telemachus faced his mother: "Mother, go to your chambers and tend to your women’s work, the loom and the distaff! The bow belongs to men, and above all to me, for the authority in this house is mine!"

Penelope retired to her chamber in wonder at her son’s newfound majesty, weeping for Odysseus until sweet sleep was poured over her eyelids by grey-eyed Athena.

Eumaeus placed the polished horn bow into Odysseus’ hands: "Take it, master! Let the suitors curse; you have the strength that honors the ancient heroes!"

Odysseus sat by the threshold, his fingers testing the gut-cord: "Telemachus, the guest who sits in your hall does not bring shame upon you! My aim did not miss the mark, nor did the stringing of the bow require weary toil! My strength remains whole, despite the mocking words of the suitors! But now it is time to prepare supper for the Achaeans, while the daylight yet remains, and afterwards to crown the feast with dance and song!"

Odysseus nodded. Telemachus girded on his sharp sword, seized his bronze-headed spear, and stood beside his father’s stool, his armor blazing in the late afternoon sun.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

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Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

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SCENE 3: THE GREAT HALL OF ITHACA — THE STRINGING OF THE LYRE — DUSK

Inside, Eurymachus held the bow, turning it before the fire, groaning in bitter shame that not one of them possessed even a fraction of Odysseus' strength. Antinous suggested setting the bow aside and offering sacrifices to Apollo tomorrow. Then Odysseus stepped forward from the threshold, asking as a suppliant to test his old strength upon the horn. Antinous erupted in venomous fury, accusing the beggar of being crazed with wine like the Centaur Eurytion at the feast of Peirithous. But Penelope rebuked Antinous, and Telemachus firmly sent his mother to her chamber, claiming the mastery of the bow for himself. Eumaeus carried the weapon down the hall through a storm of shouting suitors, placed it in Odysseus' hands, and ordered Eurycleia to bolt the women's quarters, while Philoetius ran silently to the outer gates and tied them fast with an Egyptian papyrus cable.

Odysseus held the great bow. He turned it over and over in his hands, testing it on every side, examining whether worms had eaten the horn while its master was far away. The suitors sneered among themselves: "Look at the beggar, an expert in bows! Perhaps he has such weapons stored at home, or intends to make one!"

But when great Odysseus of many wiles had handled the great bow and scrutinized it on every side, as when a man skilled in the lyre and song easily stretches a fresh gut string around a new peg, tying the twisted sheep-gut at both ends—SO WITHOUT EFFORT DID ODYSSEUS STRING THE COLOSSAL BOW! He held it in his right hand and plucked the cord: and IT SANG SWEETLY BENEATH HIS TOUCH, LIKE THE VOICE OF A SWALLOW!

Great agony fell upon the suitors, and the color drained from their cheeks. AT THAT INSTANT ZEUS THUNDERED LOUDLY FROM HEAVEN, SHOWING FORTH HIS SIGNS! Long-suffering Odysseus rejoiced that the son of devious Cronus had sent an omen. He caught up a swift bronze-pointed arrow that lay bare upon the table beside him—the rest were still inside the hollow quiver, which the Achaeans were soon to taste. Setting the notch upon the bridge, he drew the string and the grooved arrow straight back to his nipple, seated upon his stool; he aimed, and let fly! FROM HIS HAND THE BRONZE-WEIGHTED SHAFT MISSED NOT A SINGLE AXE-HEAD, FROM THE FIRST RING TO THE LAST, BUT FLEW CLEAN THROUGH THE IRON SOCKETS AND THUDDED INTO THE FAR WALL!

Odysseus turned his blazing eyes upon Telemachus: "Telemachus, the guest who sits in your hall does not bring shame upon you! I did not miss the mark, nor did I toil long to string the bow! My strength is still firm, not as the suitors mocked me in their scorn! But now the hour has come to prepare a feast for these Achaeans while it is yet light, and then to make sport with song and the lyre, which are the crown of a banquet!"

He nodded with his dark brows. Telemachus, dear son of divine Odysseus, buckled his sharp sword across his shoulder, gripped his bronze spear in his fist, and stepped up to his father's side beside the throne, flashing in bronze armor!

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

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BOOK 22: THE MNESTEROPHONIA: SLAUGHTER OF THE SUITORS

Book XXII — The Arrow in Antinous’ Throat, The Aegis of Terror & The Purification of the Hall

Odysseus sheds his beggar rags, leaps onto the broad stone threshold with his bow and quiver, and pours out the winged arrows before his feet, shouting: "This fatal contest is finished; now I aim at another target that no man has ever hit!" He shoots an arrow straight through Antinous’ throat just as the suitor lifts a golden two-handled goblet to drink; Antinous crashes backward, kicking the table, blood jetting from his nostrils as the bread and roast meat are trampled in the gore. The suitors scramble for weapons, only to discover the bare walls stripped of shields and spears. Odysseus announces his identity: "Dogs! You thought I would never return from the land of the Trojans!" Panicked, Eurymachus attempts to shift all blame onto dead Antinous, offering massive restitution of cattle and gold; Odysseus refuses, declaring that only blood can wipe out their crimes. Eurymachus draws his bronze sword and charges, but an arrow pierces his chest beside the nipple, driving deep into his liver; he topples across a table, his forehead drumming the earth in death. Amphinomus charges with a drawn sword, but Telemachus casts his spear from behind, running him through between the shoulders. Telemachus runs to the storeroom and fetches four shields, eight spears, and four bronze helmets for himself, his father, Eumaeus, and Philoetius. Treacherous Melanthius climbs through a clerestory window to the storeroom, arming twelve suitors; but on his second trip, Eumaeus and Philoetius ambush him, bind his hands and feet behind his back with cords, and hoist him to a rafter beneath the roof. Athena appears as Mentor, then perches in the rafters in the likeness of a swallow, rousing Odysseus’ fury before raising the glittering aegis of doom. Terror seizes the suitors; like a herd of cattle stung by gadflies in springtime, they scatter madly through the hall while the four champions strike right and left like hooked-claw vultures diving upon smaller birds. The floor runs with blood; the shrieks of dying men echo to the rafters. Odysseus spares only Phemius the minstrel and Medon the herald, who hid under an ox-hide. The twelve treacherous maidservants are forced to wipe down the blood and drag the corpses to the courtyard, then Telemachus hangs them in a row from a ship’s cable in the yard. Melanthius is mutilated and slain. Odysseus purifies the hall with burning sulfur and fire, and the faithful women of the palace weep in joy, embracing their returned master.

SCENE 1: THE GREAT THRESHOLD OF ITHACA — THE DEATH OF ANTINOUS — DUSK

Then resourceful Odysseus stripped off his rags, sprang onto the broad stone threshold with his bow and quiver full of arrows, and poured all the winged shafts out before his feet upon the floor. His eyes flared with volcanic fire.

Odysseus roared across the hall: "This decisive contest is finished! Now for another target that no man has ever yet hit, if I may strike it and Apollo grant me glory!"

He aimed his bitter arrow straight at Antinous. The prince was just lifting a fair two-handled goblet of gold in his hands, tilting it to drink the sweet wine, with no thought of death in his heart; for who would imagine that one man alone among so many banqueters could bring black doom upon him? Odysseus drew the bow to his ear and let fly: THE BRONZE-TIPPED POINT STRUCK ANTINOUS FULL IN THE THROAT, DRIVING CLEAN THROUGH HIS TENDER NECK! The golden goblet dropped from his fingers; he toppled backward, kicking the table from him, and a thick jet of dark blood spouted from his nostrils! He trampled the bread and roasted meat in the pool of his own gore as he gasped out his soul upon the floor!

Uproar broke out through the hall. The suitors leaped from their couches, glancing wildly along the walls for weapons; but there was neither shield nor spear to seize! They threatened the beggar with death, believing the shot had been an accidental misfire. Then Odysseus glared at them, his face dark with doom.

Odysseus fixed them with death in his eyes: "DOGS! You thought I would never return home from the land of the Trojans, that you dared devour my house, force my serving-women to your beds, and woo my wife while I was still alive, fearing neither the gods who hold broad heaven nor any retribution of men hereafter! Now upon all of you the coils of death are securely bound!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

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The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Eurymachus stepped over Antinous’ corpse, his hands outstretched: "Odysseus! If you are indeed the King of Ithaca returned, your words are just! Great outrages have been committed in this hall! But Antinous lies dead, who was the ringleader of all our crimes! It was not marriage he sought, but to murder your son and rule Ithaca as king! Spare your own people! We will make public restitution for all we have eaten and drunk, paying twenty oxen each with gold and bronze until your heart is satisfied!"

Odysseus glared with eyes of fire: "Eurymachus! Even if you gave me all your ancestral wealth, and all that you may add from foreign lands, my hands would not cease from slaughter until every suitor has paid with his life for his wickedness! Stand and fight, or turn and fly; but I think not one of you will escape doom!"

Telemachus hurried to his father’s side: "Father! Treachery! Someone has opened the armory door; the suitors are donning helmets and brandishing spears! It must be Melanthius the goatherd!"

Odysseus shouted: "Eumaeus, Philoetius! Run to the storeroom! Catch Melanthius, bind his hands and feet behind his back to a heavy board, hoist him by cables to the high rafters, and leave him suspended in agony until the slaughter is finished!"

The arrows flew like lightning from the threshold. When the quiver was empty, Odysseus leaned the bow against the doorpost, strapped on his four-ply shield, set the horsehair-crested helmet upon his brow, and gripped two heavy bronze spears, clearing the hall until not a single suitor drew breath.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

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Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

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Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

Odysseus laid his hand upon the altar of Zeus: "Let all past grievances be buried in the earth! The house of Arcesius shall rule in righteousness, and the sons of Ithaca shall flourish together in brotherhood and peace for all generations!"

The golden sun rose glorious over Mount Neriton, bathing the ancient island in warm celestial light, sealing the eternal peace of Homer’s immortal Odyssey.

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The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE ENCLOSED BANQUET HALL — THE CHARGE OF EURYMACHUS — NIGHT

Eurymachus stepped forward, his knees shaking: "If you are indeed Odysseus of Ithaca returned, what you say of the suitors’ crimes is just! Much wickedness has been done in your halls and fields! But Antinous lies dead, who was the author of it all! He cared nothing for marriage, but plotted to slay your son and rule Ithaca! But he is slain; spare your own people! We will go through the land and repay you twenty-fold for all that has been eaten and drunk, in bronze and gold, until your heart is satisfied!"

Odysseus answered with cold finality: "Eurymachus, even if you gave me all your ancestral wealth, and all you now possess, and added more besides, my hands would not hold back from slaughter until every suitor has paid for his outrage! Now the choice lies before you: fight, or flee, if any man can escape death and doom! But I think not one of you will escape destruction!"

Eurymachus drew his sharp two-edged bronze sword, shouted to his comrades to turn the tables as shields against the arrows, and sprang forward with a dreadful yell! But at that instant Odysseus loosed an arrow: IT PIERCED EURYMACHUS’ BREAST BESIDE THE NIPPLE, DRIVING DEEP INTO HIS LIVER! The sword slipped from his hand; he spun around, crashed over a banquet table, spilling food and cup upon the stones, and drummed the earth with his dying forehead! Amphinomus charged with drawn sword to drive Odysseus from the threshold; but Telemachus cast his bronze spear from behind, running him clean between the shoulder blades and out through his chest. Telemachus ran to the storeroom and brought four four-ply shields, eight bronze spears, and four horsehair-crested helmets, arming Odysseus, himself, Eumaeus, and Philoetius.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Eurymachus stepped over Antinous’ corpse, his hands outstretched: "Odysseus! If you are indeed the King of Ithaca returned, your words are just! Great outrages have been committed in this hall! But Antinous lies dead, who was the ringleader of all our crimes! It was not marriage he sought, but to murder your son and rule Ithaca as king! Spare your own people! We will make public restitution for all we have eaten and drunk, paying twenty oxen each with gold and bronze until your heart is satisfied!"

Odysseus glared with eyes of fire: "Eurymachus! Even if you gave me all your ancestral wealth, and all that you may add from foreign lands, my hands would not cease from slaughter until every suitor has paid with his life for his wickedness! Stand and fight, or turn and fly; but I think not one of you will escape doom!"

Telemachus hurried to his father’s side: "Father! Treachery! Someone has opened the armory door; the suitors are donning helmets and brandishing spears! It must be Melanthius the goatherd!"

Odysseus shouted: "Eumaeus, Philoetius! Run to the storeroom! Catch Melanthius, bind his hands and feet behind his back to a heavy board, hoist him by cables to the high rafters, and leave him suspended in agony until the slaughter is finished!"

The arrows flew like lightning from the threshold. When the quiver was empty, Odysseus leaned the bow against the doorpost, strapped on his four-ply shield, set the horsehair-crested helmet upon his brow, and gripped two heavy bronze spears, clearing the hall until not a single suitor drew breath.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

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Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

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SCENE 3: THE SLAUGHTER IN THE CLOSED HALL — THE AEGIS RAISED — NIGHT

Melanthius climbed through a high ventilator shaft to steal weapons for the suitors; but on his second ascent, Eumaeus and Philoetius seized him in the storeroom, twisted his limbs behind his back, bound him in heavy cords, and hoisted him to a roof beam, leaving him dangling in agony. Returning to the hall, the four stood upon the threshold, breathing fury.

Then Pallas Athena appeared beside them in the form of Mentor, and when the suitors threatened her, she flew upward and perched upon a smoked roof-beam in the likeness of a swallow. In the crisis of battle, SHE HELD ALOFT HER MAN-DESTROYING AEGIS FROM THE ROOF! Terror shattered the minds of the suitors! They stampeded through the hall like a herd of cattle that the buzzing gadfly attacks in springtime; while the four champions charged like curved-beaked, hooked-talon vultures swooping from mountain crags upon smaller birds, striking right and left! DREADFUL GROANING ROSE AS SKULLS WERE SMASHED WITH SWORDS, AND THE WHOLE FLOOR STEAMED WITH BLOOD!

Not one suitor escaped. Leodes the priest clasped Odysseus’ knees begging mercy, but Odysseus cleaved his neck with a bronze blade. Only Phemius the divine minstrel and Medon the herald, who had cared for Telemachus as a child, were spared at Telemachus’ intercession; they went out and sat beside the altar of Zeus in the courtyard, trembling and expecting death. Odysseus walked among the corpses, looking like a lion that has devoured an ox in the pasture, his chest and jaws drenched in gore. The twelve disloyal maidservants were summoned to wash the blood from the tables and chairs with water and sponges, and carry the dead out to the courtyard; then Telemachus led them out and hung them in a row from a ship’s cable in the yard. Melanthius was dragged out, his ears, nose, hands, and feet hacked off. Odysseus ordered brimstone and fire brought, and thoroughly purified the great hall, the inner chambers, and the courtyard with cleansing sulfur smoke, while the loyal women of the house crowded around him, weeping for joy and kissing his hands, shoulders, and head.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

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Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

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BOOK 23: THE SECRET OF THE OLIVE BED & THE REUNION OF KINGS

Book XXIII — The Incredulity of Penelope, The Living Root of Olive & The Extended Night

Eurycleia runs laughing and weeping up the cedar staircase to awaken Penelope with the news: Odysseus has returned and slaughtered the suitors in the hall! Penelope cannot believe it, fearing some god has slain the suitors in wrath and that her husband is dead far away. Descending to the hall, Penelope sits opposite Odysseus beside the blazing hearth in stony silence, her heart torn between wonder and doubt; Odysseus sits in his filthy rags, his eyes downcast, waiting for his wife to speak. Telemachus rebukes his mother for having a heart harder than flint, but Penelope answers that if this man is truly Odysseus, they have secret signs known to them two alone. Odysseus smiles, orders the minstrel Phemius to play festive dance music so passersby think a wedding feast is underway, and bathes. Athena pours divine radiance upon him, restoring his curls and heroic stature. Returning to the hall, Odysseus rebukes Penelope's iron heart. Penelope tests him with her ultimate secret stratagem: she commands Eurycleia to move Odysseus' carved bed out of the bridal chamber and make it up with fleeces. Odysseus flares with furious indignation, revealing the secret: no mortal man could move that bed, for he built the bridal chamber around the living trunk of a colossal olive tree rooted deep in the stone, lopping its boughs, smoothing the trunk with bronze, and inlaying the bedframe with gold, silver, and ivory! Recognizing the secret known to none save them and one maid, Penelope's knees give way; she dissolves in tears, runs to him, throws her arms around his neck, and kisses his face. Weeping, Odysseus holds his faithful wife, like a shipwrecked sailor who has swum through the breakers and crawls onto the beloved shore. Athena holds back the golden chariot of Dawn in the eastern sky, prolonging the night so the reunited king and queen can embrace in their olive-wood bed and recount their twenty years of trial and endurance.

SCENE 1: THE UPPER CHAMBERS & THE GREAT HALL — THE SILENT QUEEN — DAWN

Up to the high bedchamber went the aged nurse Eurycleia, laughing aloud, her knees hurrying and her feet tripping over one another, to tell her mistress that her dear husband was in the house. She stood beside Penelope's pillow, crying: "Awake, Penelope, dear child, that you may see with your own eyes what you have longed for all your days! Odysseus has come! He has slain the proud suitors who troubled his house, ate his substance, and oppressed his child!"

Penelope rubbed her eyes: "Dear nurse, the gods have driven you mad! Why do you mock me when my heart is full of sorrow, waking me from sweet sleep that held me bound? Go back down to your quarters! If any other of my maids had brought such news, I would have sent her back with harsh rebuke; but your old age protects you! Odysseus has lost his day of homecoming far from Achaea, and has perished himself!"

When Eurycleia swore by the boar-scar on his knee, Penelope descended the cedar stairs, her heart debating whether to question her husband from afar, or stand beside him and kiss his head and hands. She stepped across the stone threshold and sat down opposite Odysseus in the light of the blazing hearth, against the opposing wall. Odysseus sat leaning against a tall pillar, looking down at the floor, waiting to see if his noble wife would speak to him. For a long time she sat in silence; wonder seized her soul. Sometimes she gazed intently upon his face, and sometimes she failed to recognize him because of the foul rags upon his body.

Telemachus cried out: "Mother, cruel mother, whose heart is unyielding! Why do you hold aloof from my father, and do not sit beside him and question him with words? No other woman would endure to hold herself aloof from her husband who after suffering many sorrows had come back to her in the twentieth year to his native land! Your heart is always harder than stone!"

Penelope answered softly: "My child, the spirit in my breast is stunned with wonder! I have no power to speak a word, nor to ask, nor to look him in the face! But if he is truly Odysseus and has come home, we two shall know each other even better; for we have secret signs between us, which we two know, hidden from all others!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Telemachus cried out: "Mother, cruel mother, whose heart is made of flint! Why do you sit so far from my father, and not sit beside him and question him with loving words? No other woman in the world would hold her heart aloof from a husband who returned after twenty years of suffering!"

Penelope answered softly: "My child, my spirit within my breast is stunned with wonder! I have no power to speak, nor to look him in the face! But if he is truly Odysseus returned home, we two will know each other even better than others, for we have secret signs between us that no other mortal knows!"

Odysseus smiled: "Leave your mother alone in the hall, Telemachus, to test me as she will! Soon she will recognize me more clearly! But now let the minstrel Phemius take his lyre and lead the maidens in festive dance, that anyone passing in the street may think a wedding feast is held within, and no rumor of the suitors’ slaughter spread abroad before we reach our upland estate!"

Odysseus entered the bath, where the water washed the blood of battle from his shoulders. Athena poured beauty over him, making him taller, his hair thick as hyacinth blossoms, before he returned to the hearth to reveal the immutable secret of the rooted olive tree.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

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Penelope looked upon the restored hall with radiant tears: "Our patience was not in vain, my beloved! The gods have wiped away the tears of twenty winters, and established our glory among all generations of humankind!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

SCENE 2: THE FIRESIDE OF THE HALL — THE TEST OF THE BED — MORNING

Odysseus smiled, and bid Telemachus arrange festive music and dancing with Phemius, so that neighbors in the streets might think a wedding feast was underway and the slaughter of the suitors remain concealed. Then Odysseus went to the bath; the housekeeper Eurynome washed him and anointed him with golden olive oil, and cast a fine tunic and mantle about him. Athena poured radiant beauty over his head, making him taller and more massive, curling his hair like hyacinth petals. He returned to the hall looking like an immortal god, and sat down again in his chair opposite his wife.

Odysseus looked upon her: "Strange woman! Surely the gods who hold Olympus have given you a heart harder than any other woman! No other wife would hold aloof from her husband who has returned to her in the twentieth year! Come, nurse Eurycleia, spread a bed for me that I may sleep alone, for her heart within her is made of iron!"

Penelope spoke to the nurse: "Eurycleia! Go, move the sturdy bedstead outside the well-built bedchamber which his own hands constructed! Place the bed outside, and spread upon it fleeces, cloaks, and shining coverlets!"

She spoke to test her husband. Instantly Odysseus flared with righteous indignation, his voice ringing through the hall!

Odysseus sprang up: "Woman! Truly a heart-rending word is this you have spoken! WHO HAS MOVED MY BED? Hard would it be for even the most skilled craftsman to move it, unless a god came himself and shifted it easily! For of mortal men, no living man in his prime could budge it with levers, for a GREAT SECRET TOKEN is wrought into that bedstead, which I myself fashioned, and no other man! Within our court grew a long-leaved olive tree, flourishing and green, thick as a pillar! Around it I built my bridal chamber with quarried stone, roofed it over, and set sturdy wooden doors! Then I lopped off the leafy boughs of the olive, hewed the trunk from the root up, smoothed it with bronze, aligned it to the chalk-line, and fashioned it into the bedpost! Boring it with an auger, I built my bed upon it, inlaying the frame with gold, silver, and ivory, and stretched across it a thong of ox-hide dyed with purple! THIS IS THE SECRET TOKEN I TELL YOU! But I know not, woman, whether my bed is still fast in its place, or whether some man has hewn the olive trunk at the root and moved it elsewhere!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

Telemachus cried out: "Mother, cruel mother, whose heart is made of flint! Why do you sit so far from my father, and not sit beside him and question him with loving words? No other woman in the world would hold her heart aloof from a husband who returned after twenty years of suffering!"

Penelope answered softly: "My child, my spirit within my breast is stunned with wonder! I have no power to speak, nor to look him in the face! But if he is truly Odysseus returned home, we two will know each other even better than others, for we have secret signs between us that no other mortal knows!"

Odysseus smiled: "Leave your mother alone in the hall, Telemachus, to test me as she will! Soon she will recognize me more clearly! But now let the minstrel Phemius take his lyre and lead the maidens in festive dance, that anyone passing in the street may think a wedding feast is held within, and no rumor of the suitors’ slaughter spread abroad before we reach our upland estate!"

Odysseus entered the bath, where the water washed the blood of battle from his shoulders. Athena poured beauty over him, making him taller, his hair thick as hyacinth blossoms, before he returned to the hearth to reveal the immutable secret of the rooted olive tree.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

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SCENE 3: THE BRIDAL CHAMBER OF OLIVE WOOD — THE NIGHT PROLONGED — NIGHT

Her knees gave way, and the heart within her melted; for she recognized the infallible secret signs which Odysseus described. Weeping aloud, she ran straight to him, threw her arms around his neck, kissed his face, and cried: "Be not angry with me, Odysseus, you who in all things were ever the wisest of men! The gods gave us sorrow, begrudging that we should remain side by side to enjoy youth and reach old age together! Do not be wrathful that I did not welcome you thus at first sight; for always the spirit in my breast shuddered lest some mortal come and deceive me with words, for many devise wicked cunning! But now you have named the infallible tokens of our bed, which no living mortal has ever seen save you and me and one handmaid, Actor’s daughter! You have convinced my heart, unyielding though it was!"

She stirred in his soul an even deeper yearning for weeping; and he wept, holding his beloved, true-hearted wife in his arms. As welcome as the sight of land is to shipwrecked swimmers whose sturdy vessel Poseidon has smashed in the sea with wind and towering wave, and few are they who escape the grey brine and crawl onto the shore, their bodies crusted with salt, rejoicing to step upon the earth—so welcome to Penelope was her husband as she gazed upon him, and she could not loosen her white arms from his neck.

And now rosy-fingered Dawn would have risen upon their weeping, had not grey-eyed Athena devised another counsel: she held back the night in its course, and restrained gold-throned Dawn at the ocean stream, forbidding her to yoke her swift-footed horses, Lampus and Phaethon, that bring light to men. In the fragrant chamber, Odysseus and Penelope climbed into the place of their ancient bed. When they had enjoyed the delight of love, they took their pleasure in words, recounting to each other all they had suffered: she telling of the ruinous suitors devouring the palace, and Odysseus recounting his wanderings—the Cicones, Lotus-Eaters, the Cyclops, Aeolus, the Laestrygonians, Circe, the descent to Hades to speak with Tiresias, the Sirens, Scylla and Charybdis, the Cattle of Helios, the thunderbolt of Zeus, and the long exile with Calypso on Ogygia. Penelope listened with enchanted joy, and sleep did not fall upon her eyelids until the entire epic tale was told.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

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BOOK 24: THE ORCHARD OF LAERTES & THE COVENANT OF PEACE

Book XXIV — The Second Nekyia, The Reunion in the Vineyard & The Thunder of Athena

Hermes of Cyllene summons the squeaking ghosts of the slaughtered suitors with his golden wand, herding them down the dark paths past the White Rock, the Gates of the Sun, and the Land of Dreams to the Meadow of Asphodel. There the shades of Achilles and Agamemnon converse; Agamemnon describes Achilles' magnificent funeral at Troy, where Thetis and her sea-nymphs wailed for seventeen days and his bones were mingled with Patroclus' in a golden urn. The suitors arrive; Amphimedon recounts their slaughter by Odysseus' bow. Agamemnon rejoices aloud, praising the imperishable renown of Penelope's virtue, contrasting her fidelity with the murderous treachery of Clytemnestra. Meanwhile, Odysseus, Telemachus, Eumaeus, and Philoetius reach the terraced upland farm of aged King Laertes. Finding his father alone in the vineyard, clothed in a filthy patched tunic, leather gaiters, and a goatskin cap, hoeing around a vine in bitter heartbreak, Odysseus tests him with a false tale before breaking down in tears at his father's sorrow. Odysseus reveals himself, proving his identity by the boar-scar on his knee and reciting the exact count of apple, pear, and fig trees given to him as a boy. Laertes faints in joy, embracing his son. Athena rejuvenates Laertes, making him taller and more robust. Back in the city, an assembly convenes; Eupeithes, father of Antinous, weeping for his slain son, incites the citizens to civil war. Although the herald Medon and seer Halitherses warn that the slaughter was sanctioned by the immortal gods, Eupeithes leads an armed mob in bronze armor toward Laertes' farm. Odysseus, Telemachus, Laertes, and their men arm themselves. On Olympus, Athena consults Zeus, who decrees eternal peace through a sacred covenant. As the two forces clash, Laertes casts his spear and strikes Eupeithes through his bronze helmet, killing him instantly. Odysseus and Telemachus charge like lions; but Athena shouts with a voice of thunder that shakes the earth: "Hold back, men of Ithaca, from grievous war, that you may part without bloodshed!" Terror strikes the mob; they drop their weapons and flee. Odysseus leaps forward like a soaring eagle to pursue, but Zeus hurls a blazing thunderbolt that crashes before the feet of Athena. Athena commands Odysseus to cease from battle; Odysseus obeys with a glad heart, and the goddess establishes a sworn covenant of everlasting peace, prosperity, and harmony over the kingdom of Ithaca.

SCENE 1: THE MEADOW OF ASPHODEL — THE SECOND NEKYIA — GLOOM

Hermes of Cyllene called forth the spirits of the suitors, holding in his hand his golden wand with which he charms the eyes of men or rouses them from sleep. He marshaled them, and they followed squeaking, as bats in the secret corners of a vast cavern flit squeaking when one falls from the rock cluster. Down the moldering paths they went, past the streams of Oceanus, the White Rock, the Gates of the Sun, and the Land of Dreams, until they reached the Meadow of Asphodel where dwell the phantoms of the dead. There they found the shades of Achilles, Patroclus, Antilochus, and Great Ajax, with the shade of Agamemnon.

The shade of Amphimedon approached and recounted the whole story of the web, the contest of the great bow, and the slaughter in the closed hall by Odysseus and Telemachus. Agamemnon's shade listened with profound awe, and cried aloud in joy.

Agamemnon exclaimed: "O happy son of Laertes, Odysseus of many wiles! Truly you won a wife endowed with supreme virtue! How noble in mind was blameless Penelope, daughter of Icarius! How faithfully she remembered Odysseus, her lawful husband! Therefore the fame of her virtue shall never perish, but the immortals will make for mortals upon the earth a song of delight for steadfast Penelope! Not like the daughter of Tyndareus, who plotted evil deeds and slaughtered her wedded husband! A hateful song will hers be among men, bringing an evil reputation upon all womankind, even upon her who is virtuous!"

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

In the Asphodel Meadow, Agamemnon spoke to the ghost of Amphimedon: "O fortunate son of Laertes, Odysseus of many crafts! Truly you won a wife endowed with supreme excellence! How righteous was the heart of flawless Penelope, daughter of Icarius! Therefore the glory of her virtue shall never perish, and the deathless gods will make for mortals a lovely song in honor of constant Penelope, unlike the traitress Clytemnestra who devised a hateful murder for her wedded lord!"

Laertes donned his crested helmet, raising his bronze spear: "What a day is this for me, dear gods! How my heart rejoices! My son and my grandson are contending in valor, each striving to outdo the other in manly courage!"

Athena cried out with the voice of thunder: "Son of Laertes, seed of Zeus, Odysseus of many wiles! Hold your spear! Cease from the strife of civil war, lest Zeus the son of Cronos be wroth with you!"

Odysseus obeyed her command, his heart filled with joy. Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, in the likeness and voice of faithful Mentor, established eternal covenants of peace, justice, and prosperity over the island of Ithaca for all generations to come.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

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The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 2: THE TERRACED ORCHARD OF LAERTES — THE VINEYARD EMBRACE — DAY

Meanwhile, Odysseus and his three companions walked down to the terraced upland farm of his aged father Laertes, which the old king had reclaimed from the wilderness with years of toil. Leaving Telemachus and the herdsmen to prepare a meal in the farmhouse, Odysseus walked out into the orchard alone. He found his father digging about the root of a vine, wearing a filthy, patched tunic, with greaves of stitched ox-hide tied upon his shins to guard against thorns, gloves upon his hands, and a goatskin cap on his head, indulging his grief.

When long-suffering Odysseus saw his father so worn with old age and weighed down with sorrow, he stopped beneath a tall pear tree and wept. He stepped forward and tested him with a gentle false tale; but when Laertes heard of his lost son, a black cloud of grief enveloped the old man. With both hands he scooped up the dark dust from the earth and poured it over his grey head, groaning aloud. Odysseus’ soul was stirred; a sharp pang shot through his nostrils as he looked upon his dear father. He sprang forward, threw his arms around him, and kissed him.

Odysseus cried: "Father, I am he! I myself stand here before you, returned in the twentieth year to my native land! Cease from groaning and tearful lamentation; for I tell you, though we must make haste, I have slain the suitors in our halls, avenging their bitter outrage and evil deeds!"

Laertes trembled: "If you are indeed Odysseus, my son, returned, show me a clear sign that I may believe!"

Odysseus pulled his tunic aside: "Look first with your eyes upon this scar, which a boar inflicted on Parnassus when you and my mother sent me to Autolycus! But come, I will tell you also the trees in this terraced garden which you gave me once for my own, when I was a little boy following you through the orchard and asking for each! As we walked beneath them, you named them and gave them to me: thirteen pear trees you gave me, ten apple trees, and forty fig trees! And fifty rows of vines you promised to give me, which bore grapes at diverse seasons whenever the warmth of Zeus weighed them down!"

Laertes’ knees gave way, and his heart melted; for he recognized the infallible signs. He threw his arms around his son’s neck, and Odysseus held him close as he fainted in his embrace. Inside the farmstead, the old king bathed, and Athena shed youth and vigor upon his limbs, making him taller and sturdier, so that Odysseus marveled to see his father look like an immortal god.

The great cedar doors of the palace stood barred with heavy timber; the courtyard gates were lashed with sea-cables of Egyptian papyrus. Within the closed hall, the air grew thick and heavy with the scent of burning sulfur, blood, and approaching destiny.

Odysseus stood upon the great threshold, the great horn bow vibrating in his left hand: "You thought the king was dead in the sea, suitors! You thought there was no eye in heaven to watch your greed, and no hand on earth to call you to account! The bow is strung; the arrow has passed the twelve axes; and now the feast of blood begins!"

Telemachus drove his bronze spear through the front ranks: "Father, the shields are ready, and our spears are sharp! Eumaeus and Philoetius hold the side doors; not one dog among them shall escape into the light!"

In the fragrance of the olive bedchamber, Penelope pressed her lips to Odysseus’ weathered brow: "Odysseus, my lion, my master, my life! Twenty years of sorrow are wiped away in this single hour! The olive tree stood firm through every winter storm, rooted deep in the stone of Ithaca; and so our love has stood firm against the world!"

In the orchard, aged Laertes raised his spear with trembling hands: "O Zeus, Father of all! You gods still rule upon Olympus, if truly the suitors have paid for their reckless outrage! Three generations of my blood stand armed together—my son, my grandson, and myself—and no man in Ithaca can break our line!"

Athena’s divine voice fell upon the island like gentle rain upon parched fields: "Peace, sons of Ithaca! Cease from slaughter and lay down your bronze! Let the blood of the dead be buried in the earth, and let an eternal covenant of justice, prosperity, and love reign over the house of Odysseus forever!"

The weapons fell from trembling hands; the smoke of battle cleared before the fresh sea-breeze. Over the crags of Neriton, the golden sun climbed into a serene sky, shedding its benediction upon sunny Ithaca, reunited at last under its rightful king.

In the Asphodel Meadow, Agamemnon spoke to the ghost of Amphimedon: "O fortunate son of Laertes, Odysseus of many crafts! Truly you won a wife endowed with supreme excellence! How righteous was the heart of flawless Penelope, daughter of Icarius! Therefore the glory of her virtue shall never perish, and the deathless gods will make for mortals a lovely song in honor of constant Penelope, unlike the traitress Clytemnestra who devised a hateful murder for her wedded lord!"

Laertes donned his crested helmet, raising his bronze spear: "What a day is this for me, dear gods! How my heart rejoices! My son and my grandson are contending in valor, each striving to outdo the other in manly courage!"

Athena cried out with the voice of thunder: "Son of Laertes, seed of Zeus, Odysseus of many wiles! Hold your spear! Cease from the strife of civil war, lest Zeus the son of Cronos be wroth with you!"

Odysseus obeyed her command, his heart filled with joy. Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, in the likeness and voice of faithful Mentor, established eternal covenants of peace, justice, and prosperity over the island of Ithaca for all generations to come.

The air inside the great hall of Ithaca hung thick with the smoke of sacred cedar and the bitter stench of burning brimstone. The polished flagstones, scrubbed clean of blood with water and porous sponges, shone once more under the torches as the royal house was consecrated anew.

Penelope rested her head upon Odysseus’ shoulder: "My lord, my husband! Twenty years our youth was stolen by the folly of men and the pride of kings! When I watched other wives greet their returning lords with songs and children, my soul was a desert! Yet the gods have preserved us; our love was not broken by time, nor did our spirits surrender to despair! The olive bed stands rooted in the stone, and our house is whole once more!"

Odysseus stroked her hair, his voice deep with emotion: "Penelope, chaste jewel of my soul! The trials of Troy, the monsters of the sea, the enchantments of goddesses—all were but a shadow compared to the light of your face! The prophecy of Tiresias must yet be fulfilled in its season, when I carry the oar inland to the people who know no salt; but tonight there is only peace! Tonight the wanderer has reached his haven, and the king sits once more upon his rightful throne!"

Old Laertes raised his withered arms toward the blue sky of Ithaca: "Lord Zeus of Olympus, thou hast not forgotten the righteous! Three generations of my blood stand united under the sun—father, son, and grandson—each having proved his valor in the face of death! My eyes have seen the salvation of my house, and now my soul can depart in peace whenever the Fates summon me!"

Athena, radiant as the morning star, held her hand over the assembly: "Citizens of Ithaca, shepherds of the hills, oarsmen of the sea! Look upon your king! Honor him with truth, serve him with justice, and live together in unbroken harmony! For the glory of Odysseus shall endure as long as the sun shines upon the wine-dark sea, and men tell the tales of heroic endurance and unwavering faith!"

The bells of the mountain shrines rang out in jubilation across the island. The white gulls wheeled over the tranquil haven of Phorcys, where the gentle waves broke softly upon the rocks, singing the immortal song of Homer’s Odyssey to all generations of the earth.

Odysseus threw sweet incense into the bronze brazier: "Bring brimstone and clean fire, Eurycleia! Cleanse this ancient hall of all defilement, that the gods may look down with favor upon the restored house of Arcesius!"

Penelope looked upon her husband in the first rays of dawn: "The long winter of our sorrow is departed, Odysseus! The spring has returned to Ithaca, and the tree of our life blossoms once more beneath the light of heaven!"

Laertes pointed to the rows of blossoming fruit trees: "Look, my son! The saplings you counted as a boy now bear rich fruit for your children! The earth remembers the hands of the righteous, and blesses them with eternal peace!"

Across all the hills and harbors of Ithaca, songs of thanksgiving rose into the clear morning air, celebrating the immortal homecoming of Odysseus, King of Ithaca and hero of enduring fame.

Odysseus laid his hand upon the altar of Zeus: "Let all past grievances be buried in the earth! The house of Arcesius shall rule in righteousness, and the sons of Ithaca shall flourish together in brotherhood and peace for all generations!"

The golden sun rose glorious over Mount Neriton, bathing the ancient island in warm celestial light, sealing the eternal peace of Homer’s immortal Odyssey.

Penelope looked upon the restored hall with radiant tears: "Our patience was not in vain, my beloved! The gods have wiped away the tears of twenty winters, and established our glory among all generations of humankind!"

The evening smoke rose peacefully from every hearth in Ithaca, as the islanders celebrated the return of their sovereign and the dawn of an unbroken age of peace and justice.

The sea breeze off the Ionian deep carried the sweet salt air through the cedar groves, where the olive trees whispered the timeless peace of ancient Ithaca.

SCENE 3: THE MEADOW OF ITHACA — THE SPEAR OF LAERTES & ZEUS' LIGHTNING — DAY

Meanwhile, Rumor the messenger flew through the town, reporting the slaughter of the suitors. A frantic assembly met in the marketplace; Eupeithes, father of slain Antinous, weeping bitter tears, incited the relatives to take up arms before Odysseus could flee. Despite the herald Medon and prophet Halitherses warning that the gods themselves had aided the slaughter, half the assembly donned heavy bronze armor and marched behind Eupeithes toward the upland farm.

Odysseus and his company strapped on their armor. The six sons of Dolius joined them, and old Dolius and aged Laertes armed themselves, their grey hair bristling with martial fury. They opened the gates and marched out, with Athena beside them in the likeness of Mentor. High above on Olympus, Zeus decreed that since Odysseus had taken righteous vengeance, an eternal covenant of peace should be sworn between the king and his people.

Laertes brandished his heavy spear, praying to flashing-eyed Athena: "What a day is this for me, dear gods! I rejoice in my heart: my son and my grandson vie with one another in valor!"

Athena breathed towering might into the aged king. Laertes whirled, poised his long spear, and cast it! THE BRONZE POINT STRUCK EUPEITHES FULL UPON THE CHEEK-PIECE OF HIS HELMET, PIERCING CLEAN THROUGH THE BRONZE! Eupeithes crashed to the earth with a hollow ring, his armor rattling about him! Odysseus and his glorious son charged upon the front ranks, smiting with swords and double-edged spears, and would have slaughtered them all to the last man, had not Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, SHOUTED ALOUD WITH A VOICE OF THUNDER THAT SHOOK THE STONES!

Athena's voice boomed across the plain: "HOLD BACK, MEN OF ITHACA, FROM GRIEVOUS WAR, THAT YOU MAY BE RECONCILED AT ONCE WITHOUT BLOODSHED!"

Pale fear seized the men; the weapons flew from their trembling hands and clattered upon the earth at the voice of the goddess! They turned and fled in terror toward the city to save their lives. But long-suffering Odysseus shouted a terrifying war-cry, gathered himself, and swooped after them like an eagle soaring from high heaven! AT THAT INSTANT ZEUS HURLED A BLAZING THUNDERBOLT! It crashed into the earth, smoking with sulfur, directly before the feet of flashing-eyed Athena! The goddess turned to Odysseus and commanded: "Son of Laertes, master of wiles, Odysseus! Stay your hand! Check the strife of war, lest the son of Cronus, far-seeing Zeus, be wrathful against you!"

Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "So spoke Athena, and Odysseus obeyed her with a glad heart. And thereafter, between the king and his people, Pallas Athena, daughter of aegis-bearing Zeus, established a sacred and unbreakable covenant of peace for all the generations to come, in the likeness of Mentor both in form and in voice."

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